HOZUMI ROUTE

Chapter 1: Morning duty

Student
"Good morning."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Good morning."
Student
"Good morning, President Hoshina. Vice President Anesaki."
Mizuho Hoshina
"Morning."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Good morning. …Hm?"

It was Shun. He trudged over with a groggy look on his face.
Man… He barely made it before class started. His uniform's a mess, too…

Mizuho Hoshina
"Oh… Isn't that your younger brother, Anesaki-san?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes, that's right. His appearance isn't quite up to standard, so I'm going to have a word with him."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Shun."

I called out to Shun just as he was about to go through the gate.

Shun Anesaki
"Mm…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Good morning."
Shun Anesaki
"...Good morning."

He let out a big yawn.
…*Sigh*. What a mess.
I felt like giving his tie a good yank, but I couldn't do something like that with Hoshina-senpai watching.

Nozomi Anesaki
"You need to fix your tie."
Shun Anesaki
"Fine, fine..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"You haven't forgotten anything, have you?"

Shun Anesaki
"Nu-uh."
Nozomi Anesaki
"All right, you can go then."
Shun Anesaki
"Okay."

Shun's stomach growled as he started walking.

Mizuho Hoshina
"Pfft..."

Senpai was clearly trying to hold back his laughter. For some reason, I felt embarrassed.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Shun, have you had any breakfast?"
Shun Anesaki
"I didn't have time to eat..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Jeez… Are you going to be okay until lunchtime?"
Shun Anesaki
"...Well, I am hungry."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hmm... I didn't bring any snacks…"
Mizuho Hoshina
"Oh, wait."

A look of realization crossed Hoshina-senpai's face before he started rummaging through his bag. He soon pulled out a cute little package.

Mizuho Hoshina
"Here, you can take this. It's filled with cookies. Do you like them?"
Shun Anesaki
"Oh…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Did you cook these, Senpai?!"

That pink wrapping and everything... It all had such a feminine touch...

Mizuho Hoshina
"Uh, no, it wasn't me. My childhood friend made them."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Is that so…?"

Yesterday she gave him a lunch box and today she made him homemade sweets…
Wow… I guess she really is in love with Senpai…
But he doesn't like sweets, does he? Perhaps he couldn't bring himself to reject a gift that someone had gone out of their way to give him.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Are you sure you're okay with giving it away to someone else?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"I have more, don't worry. …She made too many of them, so this one was extra..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I see."
Mizuho Hoshina
"...Does your brother like sweets?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"He loves them, right, Shun?"
Shun Anesaki
"Yeah."
Mizuho Hoshina
"Oh, awesome. So, will you take it?"
Shun Anesaki
"Uh… Ah, yeah…"

Shun hesitated for a moment, but eventually accepted the pink package from Senpai.
...This was a rather unsettling sight…

Mizuho Hoshina
"Ah, the bell went off."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Shun, you need to run, or you'll get marked as late."
Shun Anesaki
"Right– Oh, and thank you very much for this."

He waved his bag of cookies and bowed slightly to Senpai.
Then he rapidly turned away and ran off.

Mizuho Hoshina
"Your younger brother is a good, sincere kid."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Y-you think so…?"

It wasn't me he praised, but I was happy nonetheless.

Mizuho Hoshina
"I wish my younger brother were like that…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Is he not sincere?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"Not at all. …The cookies I gave to your brother were actually for him."
Nozomi Anesaki
"What?! Are you sure Shun should have them?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"Yes. My brother didn't accept the package, he told me to give it to my friend instead."

Nozomi Anesaki
"I guess he was embarrassed…"
Mizuho Hoshina
"...Maybe…"

For a moment his voice dropped.
Then he quickly turned away to look at the clock tower.

Mizuho Hoshina
"Anyway, we should get going too. We shouldn't use our student council duties as an excuse to slack off."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...You're right."

The two of us started walking towards the entrance.
I quickly glanced at Senpai's profile and saw that he had the same calm expression as always.
Perhaps I'd just imagined that brief change in his tone…
There were still things I wanted to know, but I felt it would be inappropriate to ask when our only connection was being on the same student council…
…I envy people who have childhood friends.
When I returned to the classroom after finishing my student council activities, I was a little startled by the sight of the person sitting next to me.
Kuraguchi-kun…
Yesterday, I weaseled my way out by pretending that he'd mistaken me for someone else, but was he really convinced…?

Nozomi Anesaki
"…"

I decided to simply take my seat.
Then Kuraguchi-kun glanced over at me, and our eyes met.

Nozomi Anesaki
"…G-good morning…"

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Morning, Anesaki-san."

Kuraguchi-kun gave me a brief reply and then resumed reading.
…Phew. Seems like it worked out somehow.
Let's forget about the past and continue to treat Kuraguchi-kun as just any ordinary classmate...

Chapter 2: I triggered a flag

Female student

"...And that's what happened. Isn't it just aaawful?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes, that's pretty terrible…"
Male student
"Anesaki-san, how do you solve this one?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Let's see... you substitute the value obtained from the previous problem into x, and then…"

The break had just started, and students immediately came over and crowded around my desk.
They probably felt more comfortable gathering around since Miho was absent today with a cold.
I looked over and noticed that the people around Kuraguchi-kun had left him with barely any room.
Kuraguchi-kun looked completely unfazed as he read his book, but he was probably feeling pretty inconvenienced deep down.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Excuse me, I'm going to the bathroom for a moment."
Female student
"Oh, okay. Go ahead."
Male student
"Can I come along?"
Female student
"You can't do that, you know. That's sexual harassment."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hahaha… I'll be right back."

As always, the moment I left the classroom, I felt the tension in my shoulders release.
I think I'll never be a true social butterfly.
While I was taking in this feeling of relief, I noticed a familiar teacher approaching from the front.
She was carrying a stack of printouts.
...Wow… I have a bad feeling about this.

Teacher
"Oh, hello, Anesaki-san."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hello."
Teacher
"Sorry to trouble you, but... could you put these printouts on my desk in the staff room?"

…I just knew it…

Nozomi Anesaki
"Of course…"

I didn't let any frustration show on my face as I took the printouts from her hands.

Seriously, why do the teachers at this school always make students do so much work...? Speaking of which... This stack of printouts is so heavy. My arms are already starting to feel like they're going to give out...!

Female student
"Hii, Nozomi."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hii."
Male student
"Hii, Anesaki-san."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hii."

I kept smiling, but my arms were trembling.
I must have looked like I was handling it, because no one seemed willing to step in and help.
If only Lord Walt were here... He'd have noticed right away.

Mizuho Hoshina
"Ah, Anesaki-san."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh? Ah, Hoshina-senpa– !!!"

My grip slipped, and the stack of handouts slid from my arms.
The papers went flying across the hallway. Hoshina-senpai came rushing over in a panic.

Mizuho Hoshina
"Are you okay?!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...I-I'm okay…"

Oh god, this is embarrassing... I can't believe I messed up like that in front of Senpai…
I rushed to collect the papers, and Senpai immediately came over to help.

Nozomi Anesaki
"My bad… Thank you for your help."
Mizuho Hoshina
"Sorry, I didn't mean to startle you."
Nozomi Anesaki
"D-don't worry…!"
Mizuho Hoshina
"...Also, wow, that's a lot of paper. It looks heavy."
Nozomi Anesaki
"True… my arm was getting a little sore."
Mizuho Hoshina
"You need to take this to the staff room, right?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh… Ah, yeah, that's right…"
Mizuho Hoshina

"I'll help you carry them. I'll take these papers over there."

Senpai lifted a large pile of printouts with ease, leaving me only a small amount.
Now that's what I call a prince… He's so effortlessly considerate.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Thank you very much."
Mizuho Hoshina
"You're welcome. Shall we go?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes…!"

Ah... Hoshina-senpai is really wonderful…
He's handsome, smart, and so considerate… I wish he were my boyfriend…
But it's just unrealistic, right...? He already has his childhood friend, there is no way I could trigger a flag for his route.
Even if, by some miracle, Senpai ended up liking me…
It would only mean that he fell for the image of "Nozomi Anesaki," not the real me.
Considering all that, my feelings for Senpai are truly a fruitless endeavor, and yet…
…I stole a quick glance at him.
Ahhh...! He's so handsome...! I can't help wondering what it would feel like to be special to him, even just once!

Mizuho・Nozomi
"Please excuse us."

We placed the printouts on the designated desk.

Teacher
"Oh, Hoshina-kun, Anesaki-san. Hello."

A nearby teacher approached us and spoke.

Mizuho・Nozomi
"Hello."
Teacher
"Are you free right now?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh…"
Mizuho Hoshina
"We are free."

The Prince answered without hesitation.

Teacher
"Good. This is pretty heavy, so I don't think one person could carry it."

The teacher said that as he handed us a large cardboard box.

Teacher
"Would you mind putting it on the shelf in the back of the art room storage area?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"Understood."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Understood…"
Teacher
"Thank you, I really appreciate your help. ...Ah."

The teacher appeared to recall something and opened the desk drawer, taking out two slips of paper.

Teacher
"Take these tickets to the city art museum as a thank-you. They're only valid until the end of this month, but if you're free, why don't you two go together?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Oh."
Mizuho Hoshina
"Thank you very much."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Thank you very much…"

I accepted the tickets from the teacher. Who would've thought a date event flag would be raised here of all places?
However…

Mizuho Hoshina
"Shall we go, Anesaki-san?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ah… Yeah, let's."

Nothing really came out of it…
We left the staff room while making some rather dull small talk.

Mizuho Hoshina
"Phew... that was pretty heavy."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes, that's true. Good job."
Mizuho Hoshina
"Good work, Anesaki-san. The next class is about to start, so let's get back to class."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes, sure. I'll be going then."
Mizuho Hoshina
"Okay. …Ah, wait a minute."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes?"
Mizuho Hoshina

"Anesaki-san, are you free this coming Sunday?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"…Sunday? Yes, I'm free."

I always spend my weekends holed up at home playing video games.

Mizuho Hoshina
"If you'd like, would you want to go to the art museum with me? We might as well use the tickets the teacher gave us."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...What?"

What? Uh…
HUH?!

Nozomi Anesaki
"...An awt museeum?!"

Shoot, I bit my tongue. Okay, calm down... I have to calm down…
But… uh… How did this happen…? Oh no. Wh-what should I do?

Mizuho Hoshina
"Ah… So you can't go?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...No?! No, not at all! …Although…"

How could I forget about his childhood friend…?
But he said they weren't dating... so maybe I don't have to worry about it so much...?

Mizuho Hoshina
"? Is this an inconvenient time for you?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Oh, no! Of course not! I'd love to! I'd love to go!"
Mizuho Hoshina
"That's good. I'll contact you again later, then."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah, of course…!"
Mizuho Hoshina
"...Oh, the bell rang. Sorry for keeping you. See you later!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Y-yes... See you!!!"

……
……
…Wow…
…WAAAAAAAHH!!!
F-finally…!
I know this feeling...! I just triggered a route flag!!!

Dinner that day.

Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"Sis."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hmm?"
Shun Anesaki
"Give me the sauce."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Heeere."
Shun Anesaki
"Thank you."
Nozomi Anesaki
"You're weeelcome."
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"Sis."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hmm?"
Shun Anesaki
"I ate the pudding that was in the fridge."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Oh, really? Weeeell. What's done is dooone."
Shun Anesaki
"…Huh? …You're not angry?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hm? Why should I be?"
Shun Anesaki
"That always makes you really angry."
Nozomi Anesaki
"That's meeeean. I'm not thaaaat petty."
Shun Anesaki
"No, no, no, no… Uh, what's gotten into you?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki

"…Hmph…!"

At last! He's finally asked!!!
I put my chopsticks down on the table and straightened my back.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Listen carefully."
Shun Anesaki
"...O-okay…?"

Shun followed my example and straightened his posture.
Amid the solemn atmosphere, I quietly took a deep breath.

Nozomi Anesaki
"I've entered Senpai's route!"

Yaaay! Cue the drums and fanfare! I added them in my head.

Shun Anesaki
"...Huh?"

Shun didn't seem very enthusiastic.

Shun Anesaki
"Senpai's route? What does that mean?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"It means exactly what I said! I finally triggered a flag for Hoshina-senpai's route!!!"
Shun Anesaki
"...So what does that mean?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"It. Means. That. Next Sunday... I'm going on a date with Senpai!!!"

I couldn't help but grin as I said that.
A. Date.
With. Hoshina. Senpai...!
It has such a nice ring to it…!

Shun Anesaki
"...Huuuh…?"

Shun still didn't show much enthusiasm. He wasn't exactly being supportive.

Shun Anesaki
"A date? With Prez? Really?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes, really! Isn't that amazing?! And we're going to an art museum of all places! Isn't that just so wonderful and sophisticated?!"
Shun Anesaki

"Huh... How did that happen?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I got rewarded for my good deeds."

All that effort I put into staying on the teachers' good side was worth it.

Shun Anesaki
"Ohh… …Hmm…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"What's with you? Way to kill the mood."
Shun Anesaki
"No, it's nothing. Good for you."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Do you really think so?"

It didn't sound like he was sincere.

Shun Anesaki
"I do, I do. …I really do."
Nozomi Anesaki
"That's good, because I'll need your help that day!"
Shun Anesaki
"? With what?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"With my clothes, of course! It's a date with Hoshina-senpai, after all. I can't go looking like I normally do."
Shun Anesaki
"Your normal look is perfectly fine. Honestly, you already put in more effort than necessary."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Not true! Ahhhh… What should I weeear? Maybe a skirt? Or should I buy something new?!"
Shun Anesaki
"...Jeez... she's way too excited… and this girl said that Lord Wald was her only boyfriend…"

Shun mumbled it under his breath.
I heard every word, but decided to let it slide.
...Yes, I know. My only boyfriend is Lord Wald.
It's not like I think I will end up dating Hoshina-senpai. I don't even know if dating him is what I truly want.
But... I could still go on a date, right? There's no harm in dreaming a little, is there?

Chapter 3: Date event

And before I knew it, the day of the date event had come.
The weather was perfectly clear. An ideal day for the occasion.
However…

Nozomi Anesaki

"I… I wanna sleep…"

I wasn't feeling too great.
I'd been so nervous that I barely slept.
It didn't help that Senpai called me last night.
Everything got me so excited that I was wide awake.
I put extra effort into my face mask this time, more than I usually do, but my skin still didn't feel as firm as I'd hoped.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Ugh… This is bad… Absolutely awful…"

I desperately fussed over my face in every way I could, but it seemed like it just wasn't going to turn out how I'd imagined.
At this point I had no choice but to put my makeup tools away and go to Shun's room.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Shun!"

As usual, I didn't bother knocking before entering.
Shun was still asleep.
…Well, not that it's surprising. It's only 10 AM after all. On weekdays and holidays we both usually sleep until noon.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Wake up!"

I walked to his bed and shook Shun awake.

Shun Anesaki
"Mmm..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Wake up right now!"
Shun Anesaki
"...What time is it…?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"10 AM."
Shun Anesaki
"I'm gonna sleep then…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hey! Didn't you promise you would help me with my outfit?"
Shun Anesaki
"It's only 10 o'clock... You're not meeting him until after noon..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"If we don't start now, we'll run out of time before we know it."
Shun Anesaki
"So what am I supposed to do...?"
Nozomi Anesaki

"Choose my clothes. And my hairstyle."
Shun Anesaki
"Any outfit will do…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Not true. I bought a few outfits yesterday, so let's try them together."
Shun Anesaki
"Ugh... what a pain... Just go naked…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Are you serious? Naked?"
Shun Anesaki
"Yeah… Go naked… It'll be awesome…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"Guh!!!"

I hopped onto him and that made Shun finally open his eyes.

Shun Anesaki
"What the hell?!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"You pervert. Enough already, you have to wake up."
Shun Anesaki
"What time is it again…?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I told you already. 10 AM."
Shun Anesaki
"Huh, it's only 10 o'clock?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Stop complaining and help me to get ready."

Since my skin wasn't looking its best, I had to make up for it in other ways. Luckily, I had Shun, an aspiring hairstylist, to help me out.
Shun wearily scanned me from head to toe.

Shun Anesaki
"Uh… What am I supposed to do…? You already look good."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh, really? You think this is good enough?"
Shun Anesaki
"Yes."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Is this outfit really fine? It's a museum, after all. Shouldn't I wear something a little more elegant?"
Shun Anesaki
"You look fine. ...Actually… it might even be overkill…"

His gaze darted back and forth. His face also turned a little red.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Am I cute?"
Shun Anesaki
"…You should be asking Prez, not me."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I wonder if Senpai likes this kind of style…"
Shun Anesaki
"I think most people would."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Really?! Do you like it too, Shun?!"
Shun Anesaki
"…I guess."

I did it...! I could feel my confidence finally coming back.
I swiftly untied my hair and turned back to him.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Great, now style my hair."
Shun Anesaki
"Just go with your normal hairstyle."
Nozomi Anesaki
"It looks better when you do it."
Shun Anesaki
"…*Sigh*... I see…"

And so, before long, the appointed time was finally drawing near.
I glanced at my reflection in the full-length mirror by the entryway one more time, inspecting every little detail.
The twintails Shun had styled for me were sleek and straight all the way to the tips.
My clothes also looked okay.
And... Well, there isn't really anything I can do about my skin… Shun said it didn't look that bad though, so it is what it is.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Okay, I'm off now."
Shun Anesaki
"Huh, already? It's too early."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Senpai will probably arrive ten minutes early, so I need to get there ten minutes before him!"
Shun Anesaki
"…Good luck."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Are you seeing your friends today?"
Shun Anesaki
"Yeah."
Nozomi Anesaki
"What about dinner?"

Shun Anesaki
"I was about to ask you the same thing."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I don't need it. I will go to some café with Senpai."
Shun Anesaki
"Hmm… Are you sure?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Well… Yeah? Isn't that obvious?"

Based on the otome game date events I've experienced, you're usually together with your date until the evening.
We will have dinner at some romantic place… and then…
……

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Oh, Shun, what am I supposed to do?"
Shun Anesaki
"Hm?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"What if we end up kissing?!"
Shun Anesaki
"Huuh? Kissing? …No, not happening."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ah, but it could happen though…!"

It could happen. It's totally possible. I've seen that sort of scenario play out countless times...!

Shun Anesaki
"Calm down. It's very unlikely."
Nozomi Anesaki
"…How can you be so sure?"
Shun Anesaki
"Trust me, it won't happen. Anyway... do you actually want to date Prez?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...I-I dunno…?"
Shun Anesaki
"There's no way you'll get a kiss acting like that. …I will cook dinner, by the way."
Nozomi Anesaki
"What? It's a waste of time."
Shun Anesaki
"You don't know that for sure, do you?"

Shun smirked at me.
This little...! He is mocking me! Does he really think my first date with Hoshina-senpai will be over that soon?

Nozomi Anesaki

"I totally won't be back until the evening!"
Shun Anesaki
"Sure, sure."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I'm off!"
Shun Anesaki
"See ya."

I left the house in high spirits.
Then my phone suddenly buzzed inside my bag.
My heart skipped a beat at the sight of Hoshina-senpai's name displayed on my phone.
W-wait, oh no! It's not a text, he is calling me.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Ahem… Ah… Heeey."

...Okay, this voice should work. After I finished my quick practice, I pressed the call button.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Y-yes? Hello-hello?"
Mizuho Hoshina
“Anesaki-san! Are you already outside?!”

? …What's going on? He sounds worried.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Um… Yeah, I just left..."
Mizuho Hoshina
“Oh, is that so? Um, I'm really... I'm really sorry, but…”
Mizuho Hoshina
“Something urgent came up... so I can't come today.”
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."

What?

Nozomi Anesaki
"S-something urgent…?"
Mizuho Hoshina
“I'm so sorry for cancelling on you at the last minute...! I'll definitely make it up to you...! I'm really, really sorry!”
Nozomi Anesaki
"...N-no… Don't worry…"
Mizuho Hoshina
“See you later…!”
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Y-yes… See you…"

The call suddenly cut off.
I stood still for a while, still holding the phone to my ear.

Nozomi Anesaki
"..."

H-how could this happen...?

Nozomi Anesaki
"I totally won't be back until the evening!"

After bragging like that... How could I possibly return so soon...?
I can't, right...? That would be pathetic, right…?

Nozomi Anesaki
"What if we end up kissing?!"

Wh-whoa... that's embarrassing! It's so pathetic...!
Not only did I not get a kiss, I didn't even meet him...! It's unbelievably pathetic!

Nozomi Anesaki
"...What should I do…?"

The midsummer sun was slowly scorching my skin. Standing here would do nothing but increase my melanin production.
I should probably come home, but if I do, then, obviously…

Shun Anesaki
"I thought you said you wouldn't be back until the evening?"

I'm sure Shun will tease me like this relentlessly. It's too humiliating.
I think I'll hold off on going home for now…
I'll just kill some time and head home when it gets dark.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...*Sigh*..."

Still... This is incredibly depressing…
I went through all that effort getting ready for today, and yet... *Sigh*...

Chapter 4: Prince's true colors

With no other choice, I wandered through the museum alone before aimlessly roaming around town.
I walked from one place to another to kill time, but the sun was still far from setting.
Where should I go next? I'd like somewhere I can stay for as long as possible.
I took a quick look around.

The town was bustling with student groups, couples, and families with children. Typical for weekends.
There I was, standing by myself in the middle of it all. My fancy outfit looked completely out of place.
...I feel kind of pathetic. Maybe I should just give up on trying to keep up appearances and go home…

Shun Anesaki
"Oh? Sis, I didn't expect you to be back so early."

No... I just can't. Going back now is out of the question. I'll eat something and hang around for about an hour.
I started walking towards the nearby café.
And then…

Girl's voice
"Hoshina-kuuun!"

I reflexively turned around at the sound of excited squeals coming from behind me.
My eyes widened slightly at what I saw.

Nozomi Anesaki
"…H-huh…?"

Is that…? Hoshina-senpai…?
I slowly blinked once.
...And as I thought… It was definitely Hoshina-senpai.
Wait a minute. Why is Senpai here...?
Didn't you say you have "an emergency"...?
Emergency? What's this then? What's going on?
You don't exactly look busy to me...!

Girl
"Hoshina-kun, it's been so long!"

A girl dressed in flashy clothes approached him.
She is standing way too close to him. Who is she?
Is she Senpai's girlfriend?
Though she did say, "It's been so long," so maybe they're just friends.
No, no, more importantly, why is he even here…?
My mind kept jumping rapidly from one thought to another…

Mizuho Hoshina
"Huh?"

But at that moment, it stopped functioning completely.

Mizuho Hoshina

"Who the heck are you?"
Girl
"What…? I-it's me. Miki Matsuda."
Mizuho Hoshina
"I don't know you. Anyway, you're in the way. Get lost."

After coldly throwing out those words, Hoshina-senpai stepped forward, forcing his way past the girl.

Girl
"W-wait… Hoshina-kun?!"

Senpai ignored the girl calling out to him and walked toward me with his hands in his pockets.
N-no, this is bad...! He'll see me...! We're going to run straight into each other if I don't do something.
I have nothing to be ashamed of. I'm the one who got cancelled on. I have no reason to run.
Still, I don't feel like I should face him right now. I think I witnessed something I wasn't meant to see.
I quickly looked down and tried to move aside, but the crowd was too packed for me to find enough room.
I could feel my shoulder brush against Senpai's for just a brief moment as we passed each other.

Mizuho Hoshina
"...Tch."

I heard him click his tongue.
I reflexively looked up, only to see him walking away without even looking back at me.
……
……
Uh…
WHAAAAAAAAAAAAAAT???
Image:
(Huh? Who the heck are you? I don't know you. Anyway, you're in the way. Get lost. …Tch)

Chapter 5: My crush vanished

Actual chapter title: "My long-held crush has just vanished"

Shun Anesaki
"I'm home."

I heard a voice coming from the entrance. It sounded like Shun had returned.
I was lying in bed, mindlessly pressing buttons on my game console.
Lord Wald's smiling face on the screen was my only solace.

Shun Anesaki
"…Oh? Sis, you came back before dinner after all."

The sound of Shun's light footsteps drew closer to the room.
He's totally planning to make fun of me... Hmph... But fine, whatever. I don't care about that.
I could easily admit that I was actually cancelled on.
It really doesn't matter anymore.

Shun Anesaki
"Sis?"

I heard his cheerful voice.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Come in."

Shun walked into the room with a grin on his face after I gave my dry response.

Shun Anesaki
"How did your date with Prez go?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"There was no date."

I gave him a short reply, and then returned my gaze to the game screen.

Shun Anesaki
"Huh?"

Shun froze in place.

Shun Anesaki
"What? What does that mean...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"It means exactly what I said. There was no date."
Nozomi Anesaki
"He cancelled on me immediately after I left the house."

I stated the facts plainly. It didn't feel humiliating anymore. I had already moved past the point of feeling embarrassed.

Shun Anesaki
"..."

Shun suddenly fell silent. I turned my gaze toward him and saw that he looked incredibly uncomfortable.

Shun Anesaki
"...Ah… I see..."

Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah."
Shun Anesaki
"That's... how should I put it… Um… Don't worry about it too much…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"Is there anything you want...? For dinner..."

It seemed that Shun was trying to cheer me up.
Hah.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Shun."
Shun Anesaki
"Y-yes?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Can you hear me out?"
Shun Anesaki
"S-sure..."

For some reason, Shun dropped into a formal kneeling position and straightened his back.

Nozomi Anesaki
"All right, listen..."
Shun Anesaki
"…Yeah?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Like, I know it, okay? 'Gap moe' is a thing."
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"...Uh-huh…?"

After a short pause, Shun nodded.
I pressed the game button. Lord Wald's familiar smile on the screen hadn't changed in the slightest.

Nozomi Anesaki
"For example, when that usually distant childhood friend unexpectedly shows a gentle side."
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Or when a stern-looking character is caught playing with small animals."
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Or when a flirt turns out to be actually responsible and serious."

Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"It's so moe. I love it."
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"However!!!"
Shun Anesaki
"Ooh?!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"There's one thing I absolutely... absolutely can't stand!!!"
Shun Anesaki
"Which is?!"

Which is…!

Nozomi Anesaki
"I caaaaan't stand the whole 'this charming character is secretly twisted' trope!!!"

I threw the game console down and buried my face in the pillow.
In the darkness, the sight of Hoshina-senpai from earlier vividly replayed in my mind.

Mizuho Hoshina
"Huh?"

I can't believe it... Is that really Hoshina-senpai's true self?
But... but until now…

Mizuho Hoshina
"Ah, hello, Anesaki-san."
Mizuho Hoshina
"I like that about you, Anesaki-san."
Mizuho Hoshina
"Yes, sort of..."

This is what I mean, you know? This completely innocent expression, these gestures. Everything he did was so gentlemanly; he was exactly the kind of person who suited the title of "Prince"... and yet.

Mizuho Hoshina
"Anyway, you're in the way. Get lost."

What led to this?
What on earth could have happened to Senpai? I'm not even shocked anymore. I'm starting to get genuinely worried.

Shun Anesaki

"...Twisted? What do you mean by that?"

Shun was unable to follow the story and just stared at me blankly.
I envy him. I wish I could have remained ignorant.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...You might regret it, are you sure you wanna know?"
Shun Anesaki
"What? Yes, I don't quite understand, but I'll listen."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Well then…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"…And that's what happened…"

I told Shun the whole thing from beginning to end, including every single one of Senpai's lines exactly as he said them.

Shun Anesaki
"Ohh…? Really?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes, really... Isn't that scary? You'd be stunned too, wouldn't you?"
Shun Anesaki
"No… It wouldn't scare me. I'm surprised though."
Nozomi Anesaki
"How can you stay so calm...? That's Hoshina-senpai we're talking about, you know? He's a prince!"
Shun Anesaki
"I never thought of him as a prince."
Nozomi Anesaki
"It'd be weird if you actually did."
Shun Anesaki
"…You seem pretty upset... Does it bother you that much?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Of course it does...! My long-held crush has just vanished into thin air..."
Shun Anesaki
"So our student council president is secretly twisted, huh... Looks can be deceiving, I suppose."
Nozomi Anesaki
"It seems so…"
Shun Anesaki
"Then again, you're secretly an otaku."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."

I had no comeback for that.
Apparently, the general population can't stand reverse gap moe either…

Nozomi Anesaki

"...I'll play WataPuri to calm down…"
Shun Anesaki
"I'll call you when dinner's ready."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Yes, please..."

I picked up the game console again.
Just seeing Lord Wald's gentle smile on the screen eased my worries.
...I'm so glad that Lord Wald doesn't have a dark side…
I was reminded once again that Lord Wald is the only boyfriend I need…

Chapter 6: Prince and Student Council

Actual chapter title: "Twisted Prince and Student Council"

The next day.
I was more nervous than usual when I arrived at school.
The thought of Hoshina-senpai (and his twisted side) filled me with dread.
We have a student council meeting today, so I'll definitely see him at least once.
After seeing that side of Senpai, will I really be able to treat him the same way as before...?

???
"Ah, Anesaki-san!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"?!"

That voice...!

Nozomi Anesaki
"H-Hoshina-senpai…!"
Mizuho Hoshina
"Good morning."

He gave me a gentle, princely smile, with not a trace of blemish.
...But I know the truth.
Surely, at this very moment, Senpai is thinking to himself...

Mizuho Hoshina
"Ah, shit... I hate it..."

These must be his true thoughts.
It's scary... I'm terrified...

Nozomi Anesaki
"G-good morning…"

For now, I'll simply greet him back.

As long as Senpai doesn't change his attitude, I'll do my best to interact with him the same way I always have... That's the safest option, right...?

Mizuho Hoshina
"I'm really sorry about yesterday... My childhood friend actually collapsed from anemia, so I went with her to the hospital."
Nozomi Anesaki
"That must have been… terrible…"

Well... It's a bit of a cliché excuse, but it's still pretty good…
When someone gives you a reason like that, what else can you say? You can't really fault them.
Figures he'd be this calculating, being as smart as he is. He is truly twisted…

Mizuho Hoshina
"So, how about we go to the art museum at the end of this month instead?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh?!"

After canceling on me at the last minute, he has the nerve to invite me again...?
Could it be that this is some kind of game to him...?
Don't tell me he's planning to bail on me again?!
Could he be taking pleasure in watching me suffer?!
If that's really the case... that's insane. He's not just twisted–he's a sadistic monster on top of that!
However! I'm not falling into your trap, Mizuho Hoshina!!!

Nozomi Anesaki
"Well, um... I went to the art museum by myself yesterday..."
Mizuho Hoshina
"Oh, I see. In that case, let's go somewhere else."
Nozomi Anesaki
"What?! Somewhere else...?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"Yeah. I feel really bad for canceling on you at the last minute. So I'd like to treat you to a meal."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Oh, no, no! Don't worry about it at all...!"
Mizuho Hoshina
"Ahaha, no need to be shy. If there's anywhere you want to go, just tell me. I'll think of a place too."
Nozomi Anesaki
"No... really, it's fine..."
Mizuho Hoshina
"Please?"

He smiled at me.
It was a very dazzling smile, but…

Mizuho Hoshina
"Just shut up and do what I say, got it?"

That was probably its underlying meaning.

Nozomi Anesaki
"O-okay… Understood…"

I was so terrified that I ended up frantically nodding.
Senpai nodded back, looking satisfied.
Tch... I was set up...!

Mizuho Hoshina
"Then I'll get going. See you at the student council meeting."
Nozomi Anesaki
"…Y-yes… See you…"

Sigh... I let Senpai take complete control of the situation.
That aside, he's an incredible actor... That was a flawless performance.
I'm not sure whether I should be impressed by that or not...
The day ended in the blink of an eye.
The approaching student council meeting filled me with an increasing sense of dread.
I found myself missing the days when I eagerly looked forward to student council meetings, seeing them as my very own "Prince Hoshina Viewing Sessions."

Miho Orikasa
"Nozomi, I don't have club activities today. Do you want to walk home together?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Sorry, I have a student council meeting."
Miho Orikasa
"Ah, I see. ...Hehee."
Nozomi Anesaki
"? What…?"
Miho Orikasa
"No, it's nothing... So, how have things been with Hoshina-senpai since then?"

I involuntarily looked away.

Miho Orikasa
"Ohooo? Looks like there's been some major progress, huh???"

...Major progress? If anything, it's been a major regression.

Nozomi Anesaki
"…No, nothing really happened…"

Miho Orikasa

"Huh? What's wrong? You seem a bit upset. ...Is something the matter?"

It turned out that Hoshina-senpai was actually a bit of a snake.
...I shouldn't say that, though.
There's no doubt that it's a secret Senpai doesn't want anyone finding out about. I know exactly how he feels, because I'm the same.

Nozomi Anesaki
"No, I'm okay… I'll go now."
Miho Orikasa
"Hmm? See you laaater."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Bye-bye!"

Okay... Time to pull myself together. I need to try to act as usual.
It's fine... The secretary and treasurer will be there too. At least we won't be alone together.
But when I entered…

Nozomi Anesaki
"Are they… absent today…?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"Yeah. Apparently, both of them called in sick with a cold."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uhhh…"

So that means I'll be alone with Senpai...?
Why did they both have to fall ill at the exact same time...?

Mizuho Hoshina
"Summer colds are going around. We need to be careful too."

...Senpai smiled wryly at me as he said it, but I knew better.

Mizuho Hoshina
"You can't even take care of yourselves, you morons."

That's what he was actually thinking…
I'm scared... This is so terrifying...!

Mizuho Hoshina
"Anesaki-san."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Eek!!!"
Mizuho Hoshina
"Huh?!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ah, so– E-excuse me! I was just a little startled...!"
Mizuho Hoshina

"Oh... is that so...? Sorry?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"N-no, no, no, don't worry."
Mizuho Hoshina
"Shut the fuck up, you stupid bitch..."

I don't want him to find me annoying... I need to be more careful.

Mizuho Hoshina
"Um... so, about today's student council meeting..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Y-yes?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"We have quite a lot of work..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Oh, we do…?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"Yeah. Since there are only two of us today, it might take quite a while."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...I see…"

You've got to be kidding me... I don't think I can handle being alone with the Twisted Prince for that long.
...No, Senpai is still keeping up his perfect prince act. He won't start treating me differently out of nowhere.
All I have to do is pretend I know nothing and play along with Senpai's act, right...?

Mizuho Hoshina
"Okay, let's get started then."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Yes…"
Mizuho Hoshina
"Anesaki-san."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes…?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"Could you sign here?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Y-yes…!"
Mizuho・Nozomi
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I'm done...!"
Mizuho Hoshina
"…Thank you."
Mizuho Hoshina
"Anesaki-san."
Nozomi Anesaki

"Yes…?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"...C-could you please organize these documents for me...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Understood!"
Mizuho Hoshina
"Th-thank you."
Mizuho Hoshina
"Anesaki-san."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ye… Yes?!"
Mizuho Hoshina
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...S-Senpai...?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"Ah, um... could you please stamp all of these...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes! Gladly!"
Mizuho Hoshina
"Th-thank you..."
Mizuho Hoshina
"...Are you done with your part?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"S-sorry...! N-not yet! I'll finish it right away!"
Mizuho Hoshina
"Oh, no, no, it's fine, there's no need to rush...! ...I'll just go make some copies…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Oh, o-okay, see you later..."

……
I-I'm exhausted…
I flopped down onto the desk.
This isn't good... No matter how hard I try not to think about it, I keep worrying about what Senpai is actually thinking underneath it all.
At this rate, Senpai is going to think something's off... What if I accidentally provoke him and end up awakening his true side...?
He could break my legs and lock me away somewhere…
I've seen things like that happen... in otome games…
I just need to hold out for another 30 minutes until school ends... I won't go home with him today…

Mizuho Hoshina
"I'm back."
Nozomi Anesaki
"!!!"
Mizuho Hoshina
"...Wh-what's wrong...? Why are you so nervous...?"

Nozomi Anesaki
"No...! I'm sorry! I was just taking a short break, that's all. I'm sorry!!!"
Mizuho Hoshina
"...Y-yeah. And that's fine…?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I'll make up for it, please forgive me...!"
Mizuho Hoshina
"...Forgive you for what? A-anyway… you got this..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes…!"

The final bell of the day rang.
I packed up my things with the feeling that I'd just come through a long battle, while Senpai gazed out the window.

Mizuho Hoshina
"It's getting quite dark outside."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Th-that's true... We finished later than usual today..."
Mizuho Hoshina
"...Anesaki-san, do you have someone to go home with?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh...? N-no, not today..."

Don't tell me he's going to…

Mizuho Hoshina
"Then I'll see you home. It's not safe otherwise."
Nozomi Anesaki
"No thanks."
Mizuho Hoshina
"Uh…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ah…!"

I messed up. I predicted the outcome too quickly and answered immediately. That definitely came across as rude.

Mizuho Hoshina
"..."

I knew it... Senpai looked incredibly uncomfortable…

Mizuho Hoshina
"What's with this girl...? I'm going out of my way to be a gentleman here, and she's turning me down?"

That's probably what he was thinking.

Should I just obediently go along with his suggestion...?

Nozomi Anesaki
"U-um... well then... I'm sorry to trouble you, but would it be all right if I accepted your offer...?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"...What? Ah, yes! Okay then, I'll quickly return the key. Please wait at the gate, Anesaki-san."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes…"

...Phew. At least I didn't upset him, I think?
Sigh... I wound up going home with him after all… I just have to endure the next few dozen minutes, and I'll be home...

Chapter 7: Prince and the walk home

Actual chapter title: "Twisted Prince and the walk home"

Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Mizuho Hoshina
"..."

…An uncomfortable silence had lingered between us for some time.
Senpai had been quiet ever since we left school, with an unusually serious expression.
It was awkward. Really awkward.
Is there any safe topic I can bring up...?
Something that won't upset him...

Mizuho Hoshina
"...Anesaki-san."

Suddenly, Senpai broke the silence.
As I hurriedly straightened my back, Senpai's eyebrows drew together for a moment.

Mizuho Hoshina
"...So…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Y-yeah…?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"You're... mad at me, aren't you...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh…"
Mizuho Hoshina
"I'm really sorry about yesterday... I invited you out and then canceled at the last minute…"

Senpai bowed his head. I couldn't read his expression as anything but genuine remorse.
...But I can't let myself be fooled. There's no doubt Senpai is plotting something even now.

Nozomi Anesaki
"U-um... if that's what this is about, I honestly don't mind...!"
Mizuho Hoshina
"If that's true, then I'm glad... Still, Anesaki-san, you've been acting a little strange since this morning..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I-I don't think so..."
Mizuho Hoshina
"...Really...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes…"
Mizuho Hoshina
"Then, Anesaki-san, why–"

Senpai suddenly stopped mid-sentence, his eyes widening.
Eeek!!! He is going to kill me…!

Mizuho Hoshina
"Watch out!!!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Wha—"
Nozomi Anesaki
"?!"

A jolt ran through my body.
Before I could even understand what was happening, I felt myself falling.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Ngh...!"

I hit my shoulder really hard. I think I twisted my ankle too.
A throbbing pain began to spread, leaving me unable to move for a moment.
I stayed curled up on the ground for a while, until I sensed someone moving right beside me.

???
"...Huh...? What on earth...?"

I slowly opened my eyes.
I saw a bicycle carelessly tossed aside a few meters away.
Next to it was Hoshina-senpai, collapsed in the same position as me.
And then…

???
"...Oh crap... Did I run into someone...?"

A shadow loomed over me.
I lifted my head and looked up.

???
"Hey… you okay…?"

……
…Huh?
For a moment, I couldn't believe my eyes.
Because that was…

Nozomi Anesaki
"Hoshina-senpai…?"
???
"…Huh…?"

…No, that can't be.
He looked exactly the same, but up close, I could see that he was not wearing glasses and that his uniform was different.
So who exactly is he...?

Mizuho Hoshina
"Hozumi."

I heard Senpai's voice from the side.
He made his way toward me with a noticeable limp.
He wasn't wearing his glasses. They must have fallen off when he fell to the ground.
This gave me an opportunity
to look at them side by side…
They carried themselves differently, but their features were almost identical.
Could they be...?

Nozomi Anesaki
"Senpai… Is that…?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"It's Hozumi Hoshina... He's my younger brother. We're twins."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Twins…"

So that's how it was…
This was the younger brother Senpai had mentioned.
I always assumed they had a significant age gap. I never imagined they were twins…
Then on that day…

Mizuho Hoshina
"Huh?"
Mizuho Hoshina

"I don't know you. Anyway, you're in the way. Get lost."
Mizuho Hoshina
"...Tch."

...I see.
Everything became clear to me. And I felt a profound sense of relief.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Senpai… so you weren't twisted after all…"
Mizuho Hoshina
"...What?"

What a relief... I'm so happy…

Chapter 8: Twin and childhood friend

...All right then. Let's quickly go over the situation.
In short, Hoshina-senpai and I collided with Hozumi-san, who was riding his bicycle.
It happened right in the middle of the intersection. It's a common spot for minor accidents like that.

Mizuho Hoshina
"...Hozumi, do you have anything to say?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"…Huh? Are you blaming me for it?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"You didn't even look in the mirror. You crashed into us without slowing down."
Hozumi Hoshina
"…Tch."

Looks like he was right.

Mizuho Hoshina
"Anesaki-san, are you injured?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...It's not really anything serious... Ow..."

I tried to get up, but a searing pain ran through my left ankle.
Hoshina-senpai hurriedly crouched down in front of me.

Mizuho Hoshina
"I knew it... You sprained your ankle. Is your shoulder all right?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I can… move it, at least."
Mizuho Hoshina
"Your leg looks pretty bad... Can you stand up on your own?"
Nozomi Anesaki

"I think I can manage it with one leg…"
Hozumi Hoshina
"...It's just a minor sprain, stop being dramatic."

…What a moron.
The accident was his fault, but he didn't seem the least bit remorseful.

Mizuho Hoshina
"You could at least offer some help, Hozumi."

Hoshina-senpai shot Hozumi-san a stern glance.
Hozumi-san quietly clicked his tongue again and reluctantly walked over.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Wah?!"

He tightly grabbed my wrist.
I was yanked to my feet, and my entire body was throbbing with pain.
I reflexively winced, and Hozumi-san abruptly let go of my hand.

Nozomi Anesaki
"?!"

With only one foot on the ground, I naturally lost my balance.
I was about to fall again, but Hoshina-senpai immediately caught me and supported my shoulder.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Th-thank you very much."
Mizuho Hoshina
"Don't mention it. …Hozumi."
Hozumi Hoshina
"What?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"You shouldn't have let go without warning."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Maybe you should support her instead. I'm sure she'd prefer that anyway."
Mizuho Hoshina
"...I'm sorry, Anesaki-san. Hozumi was so rough with you."
Nozomi Anesaki
"N-no, it's okay…"

He spoke to me with a gentle smile.
Meanwhile, I tried my best to contain my anger.
I'll be honest, I don't like this guy[Hozumi-san].

Mizuho Hoshina

"...Hmm... What should we do? You don't look like you'll be able to walk back home in this state."
Nozomi Anesaki
"S-seems like it."
Mizuho Hoshina
"I wonder if we're far from your house, Anesaki-san?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"It's probably another 20 to 30 minutes on foot."
Mizuho Hoshina
"...My house is closer. Let's get you there and do something about your leg first."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Wait... Are you taking me to your place?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"Yes. I can lend you crutches too."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...I-I see… Thank you for your help…"

Going to Hoshina-senpai's place... That makes me a little nervous…
…Never mind.
I forgot that he is here too. His presence ruined what could otherwise have been a heart-pounding otome game event.

Hozumi Hoshina
"…What are you staring at?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...N-nothing."

Grrrrr...!
Why does he have to be so intimidating all the time? He's the complete opposite of Hoshina-senpai.

Hozumi Hoshina
"...Whatever. But how are you planning to get her to our house? It's a ten-minute walk. Are you planning on hobbling all the way there with her?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"Hozumi, you have a bicycle, don't you?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"I refuse."
Mizuho Hoshina
"Who do you think is responsible for Anesaki-san's injury?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Me."

H-he didn't deny it.

Hozumi Hoshina
"But that's beside the point. She'd hate riding with me, I'm sure."
Nozomi Anesaki

"…Uh… riding with you…?"

With Hozumi-san? Yeah, I'll pass on that.

Hozumi Hoshina
"...See?"

Oh, was it that obvious? Sorry.

Mizuho Hoshina
"Who said I was going to let you ride?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Huh?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"Anesaki-san, I'll ride the bike. Is that okay?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes, thank you."
Hozumi Hoshina
"H-hey, hey, hey. What am I supposed to do then...?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"You can walk."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Wh-what? You can't be serious."
Mizuho Hoshina
"It's just a ten-minute walk. It's not that far."

Senpai picked up the bicycle that had fallen by the roadside and positioned the rear rack toward me.

Mizuho Hoshina
"Can you get on?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes, it should be fine…"

With Senpai's help, I climbed onto the bicycle's rear rack.
Come to think of it, this is my first time riding on a bicycle with someone else.
And the fact that it's with Hoshina-senpai, of all people... Ah, this is making me really nervous…

Mizuho Hoshina
"Hold on tight, okay?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"O-okay!"

I worked up the courage and wrapped my arms around Senpai's waist.
I'd never been this close to someone before, and my heart was pounding so hard it felt like it was about to explode.

I'm probably blushing like crazy right now. I'm really glad Senpai can't see my face from where he is…
And then I made eye contact with Hozumi-san.

Hozumi Hoshina
"..."

Wh-what's with that face...? Did I make him mad or something...?
I didn't do anything to deserve this. If anything, I'm the victim in all this, aren't I?
Man… What a jerk.

Mizuho Hoshina
"I'm gonna start now, okay?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Y-yes…!"

And before I knew it, we had arrived at Hoshina-senpai's house.
I think he and I talked about something on the way, but I was so nervous that I barely remembered any of it.
This was supposed to be a romantic ride home together, but I barely got to savor it…
Part of me wished it would have lasted longer, but after getting off the bicycle, I realized I was also somewhat relieved.
I guess I was so tense the entire time that I ended up a little exhausted.

Mizuho Hoshina
"Anesaki-san... you look unwell... Does anything else hurt besides your leg?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"No, I'm fine…!"
Mizuho Hoshina
"You won't be able to walk on one foot. Lean on my shoulder."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Sorry... excuse me..."

I rested my hand on Senpai's shoulder.
Suddenly, I sensed someone's presence behind me.

???
"Mizuho-kun...?"

A sweet voice rang out.
When I looked back, there was a girl I'd never seen before.
She was dressed in the uniform of a famous private girls' school nearby.
There was an air of grace about her, and she looked every bit like a refined young lady.
And most importantly…
Ugh... she's so beautiful...!
She had fair skin and big, striking eyes. And there was not a trace of makeup on her face.
I could totally see her being a celebrity.
While I was staring at her in awe, the girl's gaze turned towards me.

I involuntarily looked away.

Mizuho Hoshina
"Shizune, you're back."

Senpai answered the girl with the ease of someone who knew her well.
Is this girl perhaps his childhood friend...?
The lunch box and cookies perfectly matched her image…

Shizune
"Did something happen...?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"We had a minor accident."
Shizune
"Huh?! Are you really all right?!"
Mizuho Hoshina
"We didn't get hurt badly, so there's no need to worry. And, well, it was Hozumi's fault, after all."
Shizune
"I-I see... Hold on, Mizuho-kun...!"

The girl hurried over with a worried expression.
W-wow... She's even more adorable and beautiful when you see her up close…
Ah, and she smells nice…

Shizune
"You're injured...!"
Mizuho Hoshina
"What, me? …Ah, you mean this. It's just a scratch."
Shizune
"But it's bleeding. It needs to be treated."
Mizuho Hoshina
"My injury isn't a big deal at all. It's Anesaki-san we need to worry about."
Shizune
"What…?"

Our eyes met again.
I made an effort not to look away this time, but looking at each other from such close range made me extremely nervous.

Mizuho Hoshina
"Anesaki-san, this is Shizune Hiiragi. She's my childhood friend. We're the same age."
Mizuho Hoshina
"Shizune, this is Nozomi Anesaki-san. She's a year younger than us, and she's also on the Student Council."
Shizune Hiiragi
"I see. It's very nice to meet you."
Nozomi Anesaki

"Ah, yes. The pleasure is all mine!"

She bowed politely to me, and I quickly bowed back.
I slowly looked up and saw Shizune-san smiling warmly at me.
The smile was too dazzling to look at.
My eyes reflexively shifted downward, and this time I ended up noticing her ample bosom.
What am I looking at? Is she some dating sim heroine or something?

Shizune Hiiragi
"Anesaki-san…?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"H-huh? Yes, Hiiragi-san?! What is it?!"
Shizune Hiiragi
"Um... You can just call me Shizune, if you'd like."
Nozomi Anesaki
"S-sure… You can just call me Nozomi, too..."
Shizune Hiiragi
"Nozomi-san… hehe. Once again, it's a pleasure to meet you."

Shizune-san clasped her hands together and tilted her head.
Ah... so cute... so lovely…
I think she's the very image of feminine beauty and grace...

Mizuho Hoshina
"All right, now that we've all introduced ourselves, let's get Anesaki-san treated quickly."
Shizune Hiiragi
"Did you sprain your ankle, Nozomi-san?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes... at least, I think so."
Shizune Hiiragi
"Then would you let me treat your injury? I'm a member of the health committee, so I know how to properly wrap athletic tape."
Mizuho Hoshina
"I see. Then I'll leave it to you, Shizune."
Shizune Hiiragi
"Nozomi-san, would you mind coming to my house?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Y-yes... If it's not too much trouble..."
Shizune Hiiragi
"It wouldn't be a bother at all. …Come this way. I'll give you my shoulder to lean on."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Thank you very much..."
Mizuho Hoshina
"I'll wait at home. Call me when you're finished."

After Senpai saw us off, I went to Shizune-san's house next door.

Chapter 9: The quintessential heroine

Nozomi Anesaki
"Th-thank you for inviting me…!"
Shizune Hiiragi
"Hehe, please don't be so formal. Make yourself comfortable."
Nozomi Anesaki
"O-okay…"

Having said that…
There's no way I could feel at ease being alone with a girl this gorgeous, especially in such a dazzling place.
Elegant furnishings with impeccable taste. Every little ornament was carefully arranged.
The bookshelf that I caught a glimpse of certainly didn't contain any light novels; instead, it was filled with imposing hardcover books.
What is that...? Is that a Bible? She really is the definition of a proper young lady.
Everything about the room gave off the feeling of belonging to a refined, innocent girl.
I did my best to make my room look like that of a popular, sociable girl, yet something about it still felt fundamentally different…
Everything in Shizune-san's room felt "authentic," if that makes sense.

Shizune Hiiragi
"Could you please sit on the bed?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes."

I cautiously sat down on the bed.
Ah, I hope my uniform isn't too dirty... Actually, I wonder if I have dirt anywhere else…
I'll refrain from touching anything…
I kept my hands folded on my lap, sitting there timidly, as Shizune-san came over and settled down in front of me with a first-aid kit.
I had a perfect view of the top of her head. Her hair was glossy and silky smooth, and the light shimmered through it.

Shizune Hiiragi
"Could you please stretch out your leg?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Y-yes."

I hurriedly held out my leg.
Shizune-san carefully wrapped the tape around it. For some reason, my heart started pounding.
...I swear, I've been acting like some middle school boy.
But I can't really help it…
I think being nervous around a cute girl is a perfectly natural reaction, regardless of gender.

Shizune Hiiragi
"Here, all done."

Nozomi Anesaki
"Thank you very much…!"
Shizune Hiiragi
"Does it feel strange at all?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"No, it's totally fine."
Shizune Hiiragi
"I'm glad."

Once she neatly put away the first-aid kit, Shizune-san let out a quiet sigh.

Shizune Hiiragi
"I don't know why... but I felt a little nervous..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"What?"

For some reason, Shizune-san's cheeks turned slightly red. She averted her gaze from me, shyly clasping her hands together.
Wow... even that little gesture was cute…

Shizune Hiiragi
"...Um… I know this might sound strange, but..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah…?"
Shizune Hiiragi
"Nozomi-san, you're so... charming and beautiful…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh?!"
Shizune Hiiragi
"?!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Oh, I-I'm sorry…!"

Oops, I let my honest reaction slip out.
In my defense, what she said caught me completely off guard.
She called me things like "charming" and "beautiful"...
Well… I guess that's true. I mean, people tell me that all the time, and I'd be lying if I said I didn't think I was pretty attractive myself.
However, hearing that from the goddess of beauty herself left me feeling dumbfounded...
And what did she mean by "feeling nervous"...?

Shizune Hiiragi
"I'm sorry… I shouldn't have said that out of nowhere. But I truly meant it."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Wh-whaat…?"
Shizune Hiiragi
"Actually, I've been nervous ever since I first saw you, Nozomi-san…"
Shizune Hiiragi

"Seeing you this close up… you really do look like a doll…"

W-waaah!!! Stop it, I'm getting embarrassed…!

Nozomi Anesaki
"I-I should be the one saying it!!!"

I couldn't hold it in any longer and ended up raising my voice. Shizune-san's eyes widened in surprise.
Uwah, this expression of hers is also cute!

Nozomi Anesaki
"Shizune-san, you are way cuter and prettier than me! Trust me, I was incredibly nervous too!!!"
Shizune Hiiragi
"Wha–?! What are you talking about?! I'm not even remotely… I could never compare to you, Nozomi-san…!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"What are you talking about?! I think you're a lot, no, million times cuter than me!!!"
Shizune Hiiragi
"I think you're a billion times cuter!!!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"You're a trillion times cuter!!!"
Shizune Hiiragi
"You're a quadrillion times cuter!!!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"You're a quintillion times cuter!!!"
Shizune Hiiragi
"Uh… I don't know what goes beyond that…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I-I think it's sextillion."
Shizune Hiiragi
"I'd expect nothing less from a student of the prestigious Sasajiin High School… you're so knowledgeable…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hehehe…"

I won at last…!
Wait, how did we even get here? This is so off-topic.

Shizune Hiiragi
"Hehe, we got so heated over something silly."
Nozomi Anesaki
"True... We should just leave it at that."

We looked at each other and smiled.
I kind of liked this feeling… Shizune-san turned out to be a fun person.

Shizune Hiiragi
"I've actually known about you for a while now, Nozomi-san."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...? Have we met somewhere before?"
Shizune Hiiragi
"No. But Mizuho-kun mentioned your name a few times before."
Nozomi Anesaki
"What?! Senpai talked about me…?"
Shizune Hiiragi
"Yes. He often praised you, saying, 'My junior on the Student Council is very talented.' "
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ooh..."

So Senpai was telling Shizune-san things like that… It made me happy, but it was kind of embarrassing too... I didn't know how to feel.

Shizune Hiiragi
"I figured you'd be a wonderful person, but you were even more amazing than I expected… I was honestly so nervous…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Th-that's enough about that…!"

For some reason, I felt awkward whenever Shizune-san praised me. I cut her off and decided to compliment her back.

Nozomi Anesaki
"I've known about you too, Shizune-san."
Shizune Hiiragi
"What?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Senpai showed me the lunch box and cookies that you made."
Nozomi Anesaki
"You were exactly the refined person I'd imagined, so I recognized you right away when we met."
Shizune Hiiragi
"I… I see…"

She looked down, clearly embarrassed.
Even something as small as that reaction showed how much more feminine she was compared to me.

Shizune Hiiragi
"...U-um…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah?"
Shizune Hiiragi
"I'm so sorry about yesterday..."
Nozomi Anesaki

"Yesterday…? What do you mean…?"
Shizune Hiiragi
"You were supposed to meet with Mizuho-kun, weren't you…?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ah… Y-yeah… That was the plan…"
Shizune Hiiragi
"Right when Mizuho-kun was about to leave, I suddenly fell ill… and caused him so much trouble…"

…Oh, right… Now that I think about it, I'm pretty sure Senpai mentioned something like that this morning too.
I thought it was an excuse, but he was actually telling the truth.

Shizune Hiiragi
"I'm so sorry… I ruined the date you were looking forward to…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"What?! A date?!"
Shizune Hiiragi
"Yes?"

Is Shizune-san… actually serious right now…?
But… she likes him, doesn't she?
Just what does she think is going on between me and Senpai…?

Nozomi Anesaki
"I-it wasn't supposed to be a date..."

Well… I totally thought it was a date.
Nonetheless, I knew perfectly well that Senpai never meant it that way…

Shizune Hiiragi
"Really…?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"That's right… The school gave both of us a ticket, so we decided to go together..."
Shizune Hiiragi
"I-I see…"

Shizune-san's face relaxed a little.
I knew it… She is in love with him.
Uh… Hmm… I'm feeling conflicted…

Shizune Hiiragi
"But I'm still sorry about what happened, so I'll make it up to you one day, okay?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"No, it's okay! Please don't worry about it...!"
Shizune Hiiragi
"No, I insist. I won't feel at ease unless I do something. If there's anything I can do for you, please just tell me."

Nozomi Anesaki
"Please, don't worry about it… You've already taken care of my injury, and that's more than enough."
Shizune Hiiragi
"This doesn't really count as an apology. Is there anything else I can do?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh… um… Oh, then may I ask you something?"
Shizune Hiiragi
"Yes, go ahead!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Shizune-san… what skincare products do you usually use?"

Her skin is so fair, and so smooth… I couldn't help but wonder what the secret to her beautiful complexion is.

Shizune Hiiragi
"U-um… I'm a little embarrassed to admit it, but… I don't actually use any skincare products like that…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh…? Y-you don't use any…?"
Shizune Hiiragi
"Yes… My skin is very sensitive, so such products don't really work for me…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"…Wh…"

Whaaaaat?!
She has such flawless skin without doing a single thing?! And she's not even wearing makeup?! How is that fair?! That's totally cheating!

Nozomi Anesaki
"D-do you at least take supplements or something…?"
Shizune Hiiragi
"? Do you mean pills?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Y-yes… supplements for beautiful skin…"
Shizune Hiiragi
"Um… I don't understand your question…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Y-you're really able to maintain such beautiful skin without any special care…"
Shizune Hiiragi
"…Oh, but there is one possible reason that comes to mind."
Nozomi Anesaki
"!!! What is it?! Tell me!"
Shizune Hiiragi
"Whenever I eat the vegetables my grandma sends me, my skin seems to look better the following day."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."

I see.

Shizune Hiiragi
"Come to think of it, my grandmother sent me a bunch of fresh vegetables the other day. I'll share some with you, Nozomi-san."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Th-thank you very much..."
Shizune Hiiragi
"...Oh, we've been chatting for quite a while, haven't we? Mizuho-kun is probably tired of waiting, so perhaps we should get going."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I agree."

After accepting the vegetables from Shizune-san, I stepped outside and found Hoshina-senpai waiting by the gate.
And beside him stood Hozumi-san, who appeared to be in a foul mood.

Mizuho Hoshina
"...Oh, there you are. Have you finished tending to the injury?"
Shizune Hiiragi
"Yes. Sorry we kept you waiting."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Have you been waiting here all this time...?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"No, I've only been here for a minute."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...I waited for five minutes, though."

Hozumi-san quietly muttered the words, obviously intending it as a jab toward me.
Senpai shot Hozumi-san a sideways glare, clearly disapproving of him.

Mizuho Hoshina
"Hozumi, isn't there something else you should say?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Tch."

Hozumi-san walked over with a bored, sluggish gait.
He stopped in front of me and reluctantly started talking.

Hozumi Hoshina
"I'm sorry."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."

I don't believe him…

Hozumi Hoshina

"…Why are you making that face? …I said I was sorry, didn't I?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"It didn't sound genuine."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Please forgive me…"

…I'm still not buying it…
...But I don't want to deal with him any longer.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...No… don't worry about it."

When I replied as calmly as I could, Hozumi-san snorted and walked away.

Mizuho Hoshina
"Now then… How should we get you home?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"…Ah, since Shizune-san lent me some crutches, I can make it home on foot."
Mizuho Hoshina
"Hmm... but that would probably be quite tough. Maybe I could take you home on the bike?"

Senpai put the bike right in front of me.
Riding double while Shizune-san is watching… I feel kind of uneasy about it…

Hozumi Hoshina
"...Hey."

Suddenly, Hozumi-san stepped forward.

Hozumi Hoshina
"This time I'll ride."
Mizuho・Nozomi
"Huh?"

What's gotten into him all of a sudden…?

Hozumi Hoshina
"Got a problem with that?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"...Well... what do you think, Anesaki-san...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh… er… umm…"

There was no way I could refuse in front of Hoshina-senpai. He was his younger brother, after all.

Nozomi Anesaki
"I don't really mind…"

After I reluctantly said it, Hozumi-san promptly hopped onto the bicycle.
With no other choice, I sat down on the bike's rear rack. I felt a completely different kind of tension than when I'd ridden with Senpai.

Mizuho Hoshina
"Be sure to ride safely, okay? If anything happens to Anesaki-san again, an apology won't be enough."
Hozumi Hoshina
"I know, I'm not stupid."

Hozumi-san replied with an annoyed tone and immediately set the bike in motion.
I decided to avoid putting my hands around his waist. I had a feeling he'd just snap, "How dare you touch me?"
As I clung awkwardly to the bicycle and struggled to keep my balance, Hozumi-san suddenly turned around.

Hozumi Hoshina
"..."

But in the end, he didn't say a word and simply turned his attention back ahead. I honestly couldn't tell what he was thinking.
We arrived at my house without any incident.
He asked me for directions a few times, but otherwise the ride back was a tense, oppressive silence devoid of any conversation.
He didn't seem very remorseful, so I couldn't understand why he volunteered to ride me home.
Honestly, Hozumi-san had already lost a ton of points in my book by then.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Thank you very much."

Nevertheless, I still thanked him when I got off his bicycle.

Hozumi Hoshina
"..."

Hozumi-san glanced over at me for a moment, but then simply left without saying anything.
Is he just not the sociable type, or does he actually have something against me…?
Either way, he left a bad impression all the way through. I still couldn't wrap my head around the fact that he was Senpai's younger brother.
…Well, I probably won't ever see him again, so whatever.
I pushed those thoughts aside and made my way to the gate, supporting myself with crutches.

Shun Anesaki
"Sis!!!"

Shun came rushing outside in a panic.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Whoa, you startled me… I'm back."
Shun Anesaki
"Where were you? Hold on… What happened to your leg?!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ah... this is... a long story..."
Shun Anesaki
"…No way… Did the shady student council president do it?!"

...Seems like I've made Shun see the world through an anime lens too...

Nozomi Anesaki
"I'll tell you the details later, but just so you know, he was actually my prince in shining armor."
Shun Anesaki
"Huh…? Also, Sis, what are you holding?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ah, I was given some vegetables."
Shun Anesaki
"Vegetables? From whom?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"The goddess of beauty herself."
Shun Anesaki
"Whaat? Who's that?"

Shun cocked his head in confusion. Meanwhile, I straightened my posture.
I turned my toes slightly inward, gently pressed my fingertips together, and tilted my head a little.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Shun-kun... you're such... a wonderful person…"
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"Did you hit your head?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"What did you think of it?"
Shun Anesaki
"That was gross."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I know, right?"

A personality like that isn't something you can just put together overnight…

It probably has a lot to do with the environment someone grows up in, but I can't help feeling that innate differences matter a great deal too.
I know that if I tried to copy it, it would just feel awkward and forced.
Those two… they're such a perfect match…
They look just like the main protagonist and heroine of a story.
I knew it…
But I couldn't help but feel jealous.

Chapter 10: The next day

Female student
"Nozomi, good morn– What happened to your leg?!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Good morning. I got a little injured."
Male student
"Huh? Anesaki-san, did you break your leg?!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"No, no, it's just a sprain."
Male student
"Do you want me to carry your bag?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"No, I'm fine, thank you."
???
"I'll carry it."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh?"

Before I knew it, a hand reached out from the side and picked up my bag.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Oh, Hoshina-senpai."
Mizuho Hoshina
"Good morning."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Good morning. Um, it's okay, I can carry my own things. Also, your classroom building is in the other direction…"
Mizuho Hoshina
"I'm heading to the staff room anyway, so don't worry about it."

That bright, innocent smile immediately put me at ease.
Yep, this is the Hoshina-senpai I know. Thank goodness he's not actually some manipulative mastermind after all…
As we walked down the hallway together, I could feel everyone staring at us.

Female student
"President Hoshina is carrying her bag for heeer. So sweeeet."
Female student

"They're totally maaade for each other."
Male student
"That's nice."

…Right, how could I forget.
That was how people at this school perceived me and Hoshina-senpai…
I used to feel a sense of superiority about it sometimes, but now it didn't make me feel good in the slightest.
Meeting Shizune-san yesterday made me realize it all too well.
Someone like her was the kind of person who truly belonged by Senpai's side, not a fake like me.
After all, part of me had always known I'd have to give up on my feelings for Senpai. But…

Mizuho Hoshina
"Anesaki-san, is your leg okay? Does it hurt?"

Every time Senpai showed me this kindness, my heart inevitably skipped a beat.
I couldn't help but fall for him again and again.
Honestly… a handsome guy with a kind heart is a dangerous combination.

Nozomi Anesaki
"It's fine for now. I'm planning to go to the hospital after school today to get it checked, just in case."
Mizuho Hoshina
"I see… Yes, that's the right thing to do. There's a chance it's not just a simple sprain."
Nozomi Anesaki
"True, but I think it'll be fine."
Mizuho Hoshina
"Anesaki-san, how many classes do you have today?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I finish school after fifth period today."
Mizuho Hoshina
"Are you planning to walk there?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes, it's not that far."
Mizuho Hoshina
"…I see, please be careful."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Of course."
Mizuho Hoshina
"Oh, and one more thing… Anesaki-san, what do you like doing in your free time? Are there any hobbies or things you enjoy?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ah? Things I enjoy?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"Yeah. I realized I don't know much about what you like. I thought I could use your answer as a reference for when we go out next time."
Mizuho Hoshina

"I also want to apologize for the trouble my younger brother caused."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ah…"

I'd completely forgotten about it… Right, I was supposed to go out with Senpai at the end of this month…
I should be happy… but…
Shizune-san's face lingered somewhere in the back of my mind, leaving me with a strange feeling I couldn't quite put into words.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Um... are you really sure about this...?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"Huh? What?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I think there is someone else you should be inviting…"
Mizuho Hoshina
"Ahaha, it wouldn't mean anything if it were someone else. It has to be you, Anesaki-san."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh…"

My heart skipped a beat, but when I thought about it more carefully, this was just to make up for what happened, right…? In that case, I guess it does have to be me.
Still, the way he phrased it just now was too much for my heart to handle. It almost made me get the wrong idea.

Mizuho Hoshina
"I want to make sure it's something you'll enjoy, so if there's anywhere you'd like to go or anything you'd like to do, don't hesitate to tell me."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Y-yes, I'll think about it..."

Mizuho Hoshina
"Okay then, I'll head to the staff room."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ah, yes. Thank you for carrying my bag."
Mizuho Hoshina
"No, don't worry about it. Please let me support you as much as I can until you're healed."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Thank you very much…"
Mizuho Hoshina
"See you."

There was something comforting about that simple gesture.
Sigh… he's so wonderful… he's basically the real-world version of Lord Wald…
Being able to spend time alone with someone like this feels almost too good to be true.
Now, he asked me about what I like to do and what I enjoy… Nothing immediately comes to mind…
My hobbies are just otome games, anime, internet browsing, and stuff like that… a painfully obvious otaku hobby list.
I feel like there's nothing I enjoy that I could share with Senpai.
Actually, if I revealed something like that, he'd be totally weirded out. Absolutely not.
...So I should probably just stick to the standard, universally popular date stuff... but I have no idea what that actually is.
Maybe movies?
If that's the case, what should we watch…? It should be something Senpai can enjoy.
I wonder what he likes.
……
Now that I think about it, I hardly know anything about Senpai's interests either.

After school, I carefully made my way to the entrance with my crutches, only to find Shun waiting in front of the second-year students' shoe lockers.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Shun?"
Shun Anesaki
"Ah, Sis, there you are."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hm? Did something happen?"
Shun Anesaki
"I mean, you're going to the hospital now, right? I'm not tagging along or anything... I'll just carry your things for you."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ooh."

I was a little touched by this gesture.

Nozomi Anesaki
"You've really become the textbook little brother character..."
Shun Anesaki

"Huh...? What are you talking about?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hehe, can you take care of this?"

I didn't hesitate to hand the bag I was carrying over to Shun. The two of us then left the school entrance together.

Female student
"Nozomi, is your leg okay?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah, it's fine. See you later."
Male student
"Vice Prez, let me carry your stuff!"
Male student
"No, let me do it."
Male student
"Let me carry it!"
Shun Anesaki
"I'm already carrying it…"

I headed toward the school gate, waving at the students who came over to me.
Then I noticed a strange crowd gathered near the entrance.

Shun Anesaki
"Huh? What's that?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I have no idea… Wait, could that be…?"

I took a closer look.
At the center of the crowd was a tall, slender figure straddling a bicycle.
His handsome face looked almost identical to Hoshina-senpai's, but his cool, piercing eyes gave him a completely different impression.
He was very handsome at first glance, but…

Hozumi Hoshina
"...What the...? Quit staring at me..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"…Shit… Why do I have to do this…?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Hurry up and get over here, you stupid girl…!"

…Yeah.
See? What a turn-off.
This must be what people mean by a "wasted pretty face."

Shun Anesaki
"Huh…? That guy looks way too similar to Prez, doesn't he…?"
Nozomi Anesaki

"Only appearance-wise."
Shun Anesaki
"...Oh! Wait, is he the twin brother you mentioned yesterday...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes, that's correct."
Shun Anesaki
"What is he doing here?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Dunno...? He looks pretty angry though, so let's just sneak by quickly."

We kept a little distance from the crowd and passed through the gate.

Female student
"Ah! Vice President Anesaki!"

A girl I happened to make eye contact with called out to me.
The crowd's attention shifted from Hozumi-san in my direction.
A moment later, I found myself making eye contact with Hozumi-san too.
Ah… just my luck… I have a feeling this is about to become a huge hassle…

Female student
"I think that guy was looking for you..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh? For me…?"

So the "stupid girl" he was talking about was actually me?
Grrr… Why am I getting called stupid by some random guy who doesn't even know me?

Hozumi Hoshina
"Hey, you."

Hozumi-san got off his bicycle and approached me.
I forced myself to keep a composed expression.
I couldn't exactly let myself look like some kind of demon in front of all these students watching.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...May I help you?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"...You're going to the hospital now, right?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Uh… that's true..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Get on."

He pointed at the bicycle with his chin.
WHAAAT???
I held back that reaction and replied calmly.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...You mean on your bike?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Well, obviously."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Um... so you're saying you'll give me a ride to the hospital?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Yeah."

...What's going on?
I didn't think Hozumi-san could be so considerate... He didn't show any signs of remorse yesterday.
I have to admit… I see him in a slightly different way now.

Nozomi Anesaki
"No thanks."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Huh?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I'll just walk. I appreciate the offer, but it's not necessary."

After firmly but politely declining, I turned to leave.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Wait."

He tightly grabbed my wrist.
Ow! I had the same thought yesterday, but this guy seriously has no idea how to treat girls!!!

Nozomi Anesaki
"Pardon…?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Just get on. We're only wasting time arguing."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...As I said, I appreciate the offer, but I have to decline."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Listen. I couldn't care less about you, but Mizuho's been nagging me nonstop."
Nozomi Anesaki
"…Huh? Hoshina-senpai?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Yeah. Mizuho's the one who asked me. He told me to take you to the hospital."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Ah…"

I see… So this was all Senpai's doing. I was an idiot for thinking better of this person, even for a moment.

Hozumi Hoshina
"So just get on. I want to get away from here as soon as possible."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...No… but..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Oh, for crying out loud, you're so slow! Get over here!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Wai–!"

He dragged me over to the bicycle.
Unbelievable... Seriously, what's wrong with this guy...?
I really wanted to smack that insensitive hand away with a karate chop. If there weren't people watching, I would've done it without a second thought.

Shun Anesaki
"Hey!"

Shun stepped forward, looking visibly irritated.

Shun Anesaki
"I'm taking her to the hospital."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Huh? Who the hell are you?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...He's my younger brother."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Brother? ...Ah, I see. Then I'll give you this."

Hozumi-san roughly shoved the paper bag that had been in the bicycle basket against Shun's chest. Shun's eyebrow twitched a little.
Yeah, he's definitely annoyed. I know exactly how you feel, my little brother…

Shun Anesaki
"What did you give me…? I don't need this–actually, maybe I do. What is this? Looks tasty."
Hozumi Hoshina
"It's a box full of sweets."
Shun Anesaki
"Aah, thanks for going out of your way–wait, that's not the point!!! Give my sister back!!!"
Hozumi Hoshina
"I'll make sure she gets to the hospital, so don't worry. …Hey, let's go, you slowpoke."

……
Rage started bubbling up within me.
Clenching my trembling fist, I struggled to maintain my usual perfect image of "Nozomi Anesaki."
...Anyway, let's try to resolve this peacefully.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...All right. Please take me there."

I maintained my polite demeanor, bowed, and climbed onto Hozumi-san's bicycle.
To be honest, I wasn't looking forward to this at all.
But Hozumi-san appeared determined to get me to the hospital no matter what, and I couldn't bring myself to turn down Hoshina-senpai's kindness.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Shun, please return my bag."
Shun Anesaki
"Hey... are you sure...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Well… it'll be fine. Shun, go home ahead of me."
Shun Anesaki
"..."

Shun hesitated, but eventually handed the bag back to me.
As soon as I took it, Hozumi-san began pedaling away without giving me any warning.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Whoa?! Wait a minute…!"

I nearly lost my balance.
I reluctantly clung to Hozumi-san's back, and he turned around to say just one sentence.

Hozumi Hoshina
"...You're really a total klutz, huh..."

……
……
…Just you wait... Hozumi Hoshina…

Chapter 11: I strike back

Image:
International exchange center "White Bridge"

He took a detour from the regular school route, leading us onto a quieter street.
Surprisingly, despite his impatient personality, Hozumi-san wasn't a reckless rider and kept to a fairly comfortable pace.
We didn't really talk about anything.
The breeze gently caressed my skin.
…Now then. It's about time.
I clung tightly to Hozumi-san's back once again.
Here we go…

Nozomi Anesaki
"How. Dare. You."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Call me a stupid girl?!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"A slowpoke, too!!!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"You shithead!!!"

I delivered a powerful karate chop to Hozumi-san's back.
...Good, I felt solid impact on all three hits.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Huh…?"

Hozumi-san turned around, looking dazed.
I didn't even bother pretending anymore; I spat it out with a downright villainous expression.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Face forward, you scumbag. Don't get us into another accident."
Hozumi Hoshina
"..."

Hozumi-san looked straight ahead in silence.
After a short pause, he turned his head back to me.

Hozumi Hoshina
"...H-hey."
Nozomi Anesaki
"What?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"...You're acting completely different..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"So what? Got a problem with that?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"...No... I mean... ah, whatever."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Hmph."
Hozumi Hoshina
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Yeah, no, I take that back."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I told you to look straight ahead. You're gonna put us in danger."
Hozumi Hoshina
"I'm paying attention, it's gonna be fine."

Nozomi Anesaki
"Stop looking at me. And don't talk either."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Huuh?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"You have the exact same face as Senpai, but your way of speaking... It's awful. It gives me the ick."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...You're… seriously... a little shit..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Don't say things like that!"

Not with Senpai's face!!!
I impulsively swung my leg upward.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Ouch!!!"

A sharp, intense pain shot through it. I forgot I sprained it…

Hozumi Hoshina
"Haha, you really are an idiot."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Don't insult me with a face like that!"

I unleashed a series of karate chops.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Ouch, stop it...! It hurts!!!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I've been in way more pain than that since yesterday, you know!!!"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Ow, ow, ow, ow!!!"

An eye for an eye. A tooth for a tooth.
I continued to vent my pent-up frustrations onto Hozumi-san's back.

Image:
Sasajiin Orthopaedic Clinic; Closed on Sundays, public holidays, and Thursday afternoons.

By the time we arrived at the hospital, Hozumi-san's stamina bar appeared to be completely depleted.

Hozumi Hoshina
"We've arrived... look..."

He meekly handed me my bag and crutches with a surprisingly obedient attitude.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Thank you."

I slowly took them from Hozumi-san, then promptly turned away from him and headed into the hospital entrance.
……
Hehe…
Muahahahaha!!!
I DID IIIIT!!!
Take that, Hozumi Hoshina!!!
Ah, that felt so good...!

Chapter 12: Relationship advice

30 minutes later…

Nozomi Anesaki
"..."

I was overwhelmed with self-loathing.
As I underwent tests at the hospital, I slowly came back to my senses.
I writhed in agony when I looked back on what I had done 30 minutes earlier.
At the time, I was blinded by anger, and revenge against Hozumi-san was the only thing on my mind, but…
Now that I'd cooled off, I realized just how big of a mistake that was.
For all his faults, Hozumi-san was still Hoshina-senpai's brother.
It was hard to believe, but it was an undeniable fact.
I'd thrown insults at Senpai's younger brother and delivered karate chops to him.
Hozumi-san might tell him about what I did today... which would mean…
My image of "Nozomi Anesaki," a kind, elegant beauty... would be ruined…

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Aaaaah…!"

What on earth… have I done...?
If Hoshina-senpai finds out about what happened today, he'll definitely hate me... Actually, my entire blissful school life is on the line…

Nozomi Anesaki
"...*Sigh*..."

I trudged along on my crutches.

Hozumi Hoshina
"...Oh, you're done."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Huh?!"

Why is he still here? No way... Is he planning to ride me home?!

Hozumi Hoshina
"So? What did the tests show?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Uh… Ah… Well…"

I couldn't quite bring myself to face him.
Considering his connection to Hoshina-senpai, I can't exactly keep acting toward Hozumi-san the way I did before... but switching back to being polite would feel weird as well.

Hozumi Hoshina
"? What? ...Wait, no way... Is it a fracture or something?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...It's nothing to worry about. It's just a sprain. It should heal in about one or two weeks if I keep my leg at rest."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Hmm... I see. ...Well, get on. I'll take you home."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...O-okay…"

I climbed onto the back of the bicycle again.
This time, Hozumi-san actually waited for me to get myself situated properly.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Can I start? Are you ready?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"…Yeah."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Hold on tight. You'll lose your balance if you don't."
Nozomi Anesaki
"What? Ah…"

I timidly wrapped my arms around him.
Once Hozumi-san made sure I was ready, he slowly pushed off.
His movements were incomparably more considerate than they had been earlier.
This... I'm sure my outburst had something to do with it…
Whether that's for better or worse…

Hozumi Hoshina
"You said it would take one to two weeks to fully heal, right?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Yes."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Are you going to keep going to the hospital until then?"
Nozomi Anesaki

"...Not that often. I think it'll only be a couple of times..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"We'll take care of the medical fees, so don't worry about the cost. Get yourself properly treated."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Huh? No, there's no need."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Just go along with it. My mom and Mizuho both insist."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...*Sigh*... Thanks…"
Hozumi Hoshina
"..."

Hozumi-san turned around with a puzzled look on his face.

Hozumi Hoshina
"...What? Why are you suddenly acting so docile? Are you emotionally unstable or something?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."

And just like that, I'm annoyed again.
...But I'll grit my teeth and let it slide.
I can't undo what I've already done. At least I need to count my losses.
...It might be too late, though.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...No, it's not that… Um, I'm sorry about earlier."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Huh? About what?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"About hitting you and stuff…"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Aah… Huh? You're actually apologizing...? That's creeping me out. What happened to all that confidence you had earlier...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"About that…"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Hm?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...C-could you... just pretend that never happened...?"

I figured I might as well ask. I had nothing to lose.
My pride had been completely thrown out the window, but my life was at stake here, so I had no choice but to endure it.

Hozumi Hoshina
"What? You want to pretend it never happened?"

Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah, pretend I never hit you... or called you stuff like 'shithead' and 'scumbag'..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Thinking back on it is kind of making me annoyed again..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"You're the one who started it, though."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Yeah... I know that. So you don't have to act like it never happened. I'm not mad or anything."
Nozomi Anesaki
"It's not your opinion I care about."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Huh?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"D-don't tell anyone about what happened today… especially Hoshina-senpai."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Mizuho? Why?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Aaaah... yes, yes... I see, I see..."

Hozumi-san shot me a nasty grin.
Ahhh, that's so annoying...!
I really wanted to smack him in the face with a karate chop, but I forced myself to hold back.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Oh, so that's what this is about... Huh... Interesting..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Ohhh... Well, weeeell... I get it now… Hahahaha!"

……

Nozomi Anesaki
"...You're so annoying!!!"

I finally reached my breaking point and let my true feelings show. Hozumi-san's shoulders trembled with suppressed laughter.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Whoa, are you sure about that? What if I tell Mizuho what you're really like?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"!!! Please, don't...! I won't ever do anything to you again, and I'll forgive you for the whole injury thing... Just please forget what happened today!"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Hm, I'm not suuuure."

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Nnngh..."

This is a disaster... There's no way Hozumi-san would do me a favor.
If anything, he'd probably enjoy watching me suffer. Ahhh... farewell to my blissful school life...!

Hozumi Hoshina
"Can I ask you something?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Wh-what…?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"You and Mizuho aren't together, are you? You two looked pretty close."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...We're not dating. We're just the student council president and vice president."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Thought so."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"I just don't think you're cut out to be his girlfriend."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"....Uh, why did you get so sad…? Knock it off."
Nozomi Anesaki
"…Because you're right."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Do you want to date Mizuho?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh?! No… well…"

Do I…?
I like Senpai, of course... but if you asked whether I actually wanted to date him, I honestly couldn't say... Still... I think it would be wonderful if that ever happened...
As I tried to sort out my feelings for Senpai, I found that I still couldn't come to a clear conclusion.
But... There's one thing I know for sure.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Even though I like Senpai... I could never be his girlfriend."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Why do you think that?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Because we're not a good match."
Hozumi Hoshina
"That's probably true."
Nozomi Anesaki

"..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"But I think you have a chance."
Nozomi Anesaki
"…Huh?"

What did he just say?

Nozomi Anesaki
"A chance?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Yeah."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Are you talking about me and Senpai...?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Obviously."

……

Nozomi Anesaki
"No, no, there is no way."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Isn't that the part where one's supposed to be excited? Usually?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"You're just going to reveal later that it was all a joke and go, 'As if that could ever happen, lol.' I'm not falling for that."

...I almost fell for it for a second.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Do you... really think I'd tell such a lame joke?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I do."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Man, you really lack faith in people."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Not people. Just you."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Well, it's none of my business. If you want to think I was just joking, it's fine by me."

Hozumi-san said it in a monotone voice before abruptly turning to face forward.
Something about the way he said it...

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Did you mean it?"

…Made me a little curious.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Even if I said I did, you'd just refuse to believe me anyway."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Wh-what proof do you have?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"My intuition."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"What's with that weird look on your face?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I was stupid for actually taking you seriously."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Are you insulting my intuition?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I can hardly believe it's more accurate than an otome gamer's[my] intuition..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"So you really think there's no chance at all?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes."

No matter how kind he was to me, I couldn't sense even the slightest romantic interest from him.

Hozumi Hoshina
"...You know, you've probably missed a lot of chances because of this mentality."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Excuse you. I'm a seasoned expert in romance."

※That only applies to the 2D world.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Seriously? You're a slut, then."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Wha–?! No, that's not true!!! I'm a virgin!!! Seriously, don't say things like that with a face like yours!"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Well, you're attractive, after all."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hey, are you even listening to me?! W-well... I won't deny that, though!"
Hozumi Hoshina
"I guess Mizuho got fooled by your pretty face."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Hey... do you really think I have a chance…?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"I've been saying that this whole time."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Why do you think that?"

Hozumi Hoshina
"I told you, it's just a hunch. That's the impression I get from watching Mizuho."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Senpai treats everyone the same, no matter who he's with."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Maybe that's how it looks to you, but I can pick up on the little differences."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...How so?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Because we're twins."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."

O-oh... he's actually starting to make a convincing argument.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Do twins... really know what each other is thinking?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"More or less. It's just a gut feeling, so I can't really put it into words."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Oooh."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Do you believe me now?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Hmm… I don't know... Do you really think Senpai likes me...?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Why would I lie about something like this? I wouldn't get anything out of it."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hmm... That's true, but... it still doesn't quite feel real to me..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Besides, he's already been giving you pretty obvious hints."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh? Like what?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"He asked you out on your day off recently, didn't he?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Oh... that…? But it really seemed like he was just inviting me as a friend."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Even then, he wouldn't go out of his way to invite you unless he liked you at least a little bit."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Well... that's true... hmm..."

Hoshina-senpai actually likes me...? Seriously...?
But Hozumi-san is his twin. If he's saying it... maybe there really is something to it...?

Mizuho Hoshina
"Ahaha, it wouldn't mean anything if it were someone else. It has to be you, Anesaki-san."
Mizuho Hoshina

"I like that about you, Anesaki-san."

...Now that I think about it, maybe Senpai really has been treating me differently...?
W-wait, seriously...? This... could it really be...? C-could Senpai actually–

Hozumi Hoshina
"Ah, but I think he's only at the stage where he's just a little curious about you."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Wait, so he doesn't actually like me?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"I don't think he's quite there yet. He just needs a little push."
Nozomi Anesaki
"A push? Like what?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"You've never made a move on Mizuho yourself, have you?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Hmm… Yeah, I guess so."

I'd never even thought about that.
I did admire Senpai, but I never believed I could truly make him fall for me.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Shouldn't you make your feelings for Mizuho a little clearer?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...What could be an obvious clue that I like him?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Give him a present or something. It's a classic move."
Nozomi Anesaki
"A present, huh…"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Bonus if you make it yourself."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hmm, hmm."
Hozumi Hoshina
"For example, you could make a lunch box."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I see, a lunch box... Oh."

That was when I remembered something important. And just like that, my excitement faded away.

Nozomi Anesaki
"No, it's impossible after all."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Huh? Why?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Because of Shizune-san…"

With a perfect childhood friend like her by his side, there's no way I could ever hope to find a place in his heart.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Shizune? …What's she got to do with it?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I don't stand a chance against her..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Mizuho is interested in you, you know?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"That... I still feel like that's not right... I think Senpai actually likes Shizune-san..."

I mean, with a girl that gorgeous right next to him, could any guy really not be swayed?

Hozumi Hoshina
"Are you stupid?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"What?!"
Hozumi Hoshina
"If Mizuho were interested in Shizune, they would've gotten together by now. Do you realize how many years they've been friends?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Now that you mention it, it is a bit strange that they're not dating already..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Right?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"But..."

Shizune-san is definitely in love with him.
Knowing that, making a move on Senpai feels… really wrong.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Are you worried about Shizune?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Yes…"
Hozumi Hoshina
"You're really stupid."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...What is your problem? You've been so rude this whole time."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Hear me out. Suppose, just hypothetically, that Mizuho and I were both interested in you– Don't interrupt me. It's only a hypothetical."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I get it."
Hozumi Hoshina
"What would you think if Mizuho backed off and gave up on you just because of me?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"That'd be horrible. I'd curse you."

Hozumi Hoshina
"...Do you understand now? Think about his feelings too."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hmm... yeah..."

It still didn't quite sit right with me, but I decided to force myself to accept it.
For all my doubts and everything I've said, knowing that Senpai likes me... makes me happy.
If there's even a chance Senpai likes me, then maybe I should... try harder too... and give this everything I've got.

Nozomi Anesaki
"A little push..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Oh? Feeling motivated now?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Would a homemade lunch box be too much...?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Trust me, if a guy likes someone, he'll be happy with anything she gives him."
Nozomi Anesaki
"But Senpai always makes his own lunch, right?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Oh... then I'll let Mizuho know that he doesn't need to make lunch tomorrow."
Nozomi Anesaki
"What, tomorrow?!"
Hozumi Hoshina
"You should do it while you're still motivated. If I left it up to you, you'd probably put it off forever."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Uh…"

That's true…When Senpai shared his lunch with me that day, I wanted to make him a lunch box as a thank-you…
But I never got around to it. This might be a good opportunity.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Okay then… I'll try giving it to him tomorrow...!"
Hozumi Hoshina
"...By the way, how good are you at cooking?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Average."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Average, huh..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Shizune-san's lunch box was amazing…"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Cooking is her hobby."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I think Senpai likes cooking too..."

Hozumi Hoshina
"That's right."
Nozomi Anesaki
"*Sigh*..."

Even their hobbies are the same. They're practically made for each other...
No matter how many times he tells me Senpai is interested in me, I still can't believe it.

Nozomi Anesaki
"I'm so jealous of Shizune-san..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Do you admire her?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I think every girl would dream to be like her."
Hozumi Hoshina
"I think you're doing pretty well for yourself."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh... R-really...?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Appearance-wise."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Ah, well... you're probably smarter than her too."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Is that not a good thing?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Girls are cuter when they're a little dumb."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Damn it…"
Hozumi Hoshina
"As for your figure..."

Hozumi-san turned around, his gaze slowly moving over me from head to toe.
Then, without saying a word, he faced forward again.

Hozumi Hoshina
"...Well... that one's a matter of taste."

That's not really helping.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Ugh... Shizune-san's figure is amazing..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Well, yeah."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Seriously, you have no tact at all. How shameless."
Hozumi Hoshina

"I think you're just as bad."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Nhgh…"
Hozumi Hoshina
"The real problem is your personality... If Mizuho ever found out about this, you'd be done for."
Nozomi Anesaki
"P-please don't tell him..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"I won't."
Nozomi Anesaki
"…Really?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"I won't gain anything from it."

...Wait… is there actually a good side to him…?
Hozumi-san earned a few points in my book. ...Though that only means he went from the negatives to zero.

Nozomi Anesaki
"But why? You were so cold yesterday, and now you're suddenly being supportive."
Hozumi Hoshina
"I'm not completely without remorse, you know. I do feel bad about getting you hurt."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hmm…"

Don't tell me my karate chop actually worked on him…?

Eventually, we arrived in front of my house.
When I got off the bicycle, Hozumi-san quietly reached out to steady me.
My opinion of Hozumi-san has improved a little more.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Well, good luck tomorrow."
Nozomi Anesaki
"All right. Thanks for today."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Yeah..."

Hozumi-san raised his hand, then looked at my face intently.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...What?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Well, I was just thinking that you can't judge a person by their looks."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Likewise."

We exchanged grins, and somehow, it felt like we were beginning to form an unusual camaraderie.

Hozumi Hoshina
"See ya."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Bye."

I waved goodbye to Hozumi-san, then slowly made my way along with my crutches.

Nozomi Anesaki
"I'm home."

The moment I stepped inside, Shun came down the stairs.

Shun Anesaki
"Welcome back. ...How did it go?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"The injury is just a sprain. It should heal in a week or two."
Shun Anesaki
"Oh, that's good. ...What about him?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"You mean Hozumi-san?"
Shun Anesaki
"Yes. Did he do anything?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"No, there wasn't anything to worry about."

Who would've thought I'd end up getting relationship advice from him?

Shun Anesaki
"Hmm... I see. ...I hate that guy."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...He wasn't as bad as I thought."
Shun Anesaki
"Really...? You looked like you really didn't wanna go with him though."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Talking with him made me realize there was more to him than I'd thought."

He told me that Senpai might have feelings for me. He even gave me the push I needed.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Okay! I'm going shopping now!"
Shun Anesaki
"What? Right after you came back? What are you going to buy?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ingredients for a lunch box."
Shun Anesaki

"There is still plenty of frozen food left in the fridge, though."
Nozomi Anesaki
"That's not good enough."

It has to be good enough to stand alongside something Shizune-san would make.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Anyway, I'm off!"
Shun Anesaki
"Oh…"

Chapter 13: Lunch box

4:00 AM. I woke up an hour earlier than usual.
I went to bed early last night, but I couldn't fall asleep for a while.
So now I'm completely wiped out…

Nozomi Anesaki
"..."

Ah! That was close, I almost passed out…
Okay, let's get up…
After getting ready, I headed into the kitchen.
As I laid out the ingredients I'd bought yesterday, my focus naturally sharpened.
My goal is to make a lunch box as good as Shizune-san's... No, even better!
I put the "How to Make a Fancy Lunch" recipe I'd printed out beforehand beside me and got to work.
Tap, tap, tap…
Tap, tap, tap…
……
While I was cutting everything into strips, I started getting sleepy...
……

Nozomi Anesaki
"Ouch…!"

I accidentally nicked my index finger. Blood slowly began to seep out.
Oh man... I have to pull myself together.
Shk, shk, shk…
Shk, shk, shk…
...A slicer really is handy. It makes quick work of an onion.
But it really stings my eyes… My vision is getting blurry from all the tears...

Nozomi Anesaki
"Ack!"

I sliced my thumb. Blood started slowly welling up again.

That's twice now... I guess I'm not doing so well today.
Okay, next up is the rolled omelet.
I'm pretty sure Senpai isn't fond of sweet flavors. I wonder if this amount of salt is enough.
Hmm... My rolled omelet came out a little uneven…
Shizune-san's would have made it much prettier.
...Well, I have no other choice. I'll redo it.
I lifted the frying pan…

Nozomi Anesaki
"Ow, it's hot?!"

I accidentally touched the base of the handle.
I quickly cooled my hand under running water, but my fingertips were still red.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...*Sigh*..."

Is this my unlucky day...?
But despite various troubles…

Nozomi Anesaki
"I did it...!"

I successfully finished the lunch box.
I think it turned out pretty well, if I do say so myself. At first glance, it should be able to hold its own against Shizune-san's lunch box... I think.
I think this should make Senpai happy.
As I packed the leftover fillings into Shun's and my own lunch boxes,
I heard footsteps coming from the living room.

Shun Anesaki
"Good morning."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh, Shun? What's up? It's not like you to get up on your own. It's only 7 a.m., you know?"
Shun Anesaki
"I just happened to wake up early today."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Oh, sorry, was I being too loud?"
Shun Anesaki
"No, that's not really why—wait, what's with that lunch box...?"

Shun's eyes fell on the lunch prepared for Hoshina-senpai. I proudly puffed out my chest.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Well? Isn't it amazing?"
Shun Anesaki
"Yeah, it's impressive, but… is there some special occasion today...?"
Nozomi Anesaki

"Ah, this one is for Senpai. Yours is over there."
Shun Anesaki
"...Aww... Mine doesn't even compare..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Don't complain. This is way fancier than what you normally get."
Shun Anesaki
"Anyway, why are you making lunch boxes for him all of a sudden?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"The time has come. I'm going all in."
Shun Anesaki
"...Really…?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah. …By the way, could you take a bite of this pork fillet cutlet for me?"

I stuffed the leftover pork cutlet into his mouth.

Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Well?"
Shun Anesaki
"...It's very tasty."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Really?! Yay…!"
Shun Anesaki
"Give me more."
Nozomi Anesaki
"No."

I lightly slapped Shun's hand as he reached for the pork cutlet again.

Nozomi Anesaki
"It's for Senpai's lunch box."
Shun Anesaki
"Aw… That's not fair. He already has more stuff than me."
Nozomi Anesaki
"This one I'm really proud of, so I want Senpai to enjoy plenty of it."
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Jeez... Fine, I'll give you the rolled omelet leftovers."
Shun Anesaki
"Aw... That's all I get…?"

Even though he pouted his lips in dissatisfaction, Shun didn't hesitate to sneak a bite of it.

Shun Anesaki
"...Whoa, it's not sweet at all."

Nozomi Anesaki
"I made it with salt today. How is it? The seasoning, I mean."
Shun Anesaki
"It's good."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Is it delicious?"
Shun Anesaki
"Yes."

He nodded in approval and reached for another piece.
Hehe, it really does look delicious. I'm relieved. I feel like I can give it to him with confidence now.
After parting ways with Shun at the entrance hall, I spotted Hoshina-senpai's back just as he was heading toward the third-year classroom building.
I took a deep breath and followed him.

Nozomi Anesaki
"S-Senpai...!"
Mizuho Hoshina
"Ah, Anesaki-san. Good morning."

...Senpai is acting as usual.
Hozumi-san really kept his word and didn't say anything about yesterday. Thank goodness…

Mizuho Hoshina
"How did things go yesterday? I hope Hozumi didn't cause any trouble..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Oh, no, it was fine. I'm sorry you had to go out of your way and ask him to do it..."
Mizuho Hoshina
"Hozumi never properly apologized to you, after all. I wanted him to do something to make amends."
Mizuho Hoshina
"I'm sorry if that was too much."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Not at all! You were a huge help!"
Mizuho Hoshina
"Oh, I see. That's good then."
Nozomi Anesaki
"S-so, um..."

Okay... let's get down to business.
Aah, I'm kind of nervous... What if he won't accept it?
...No, Senpai is interested in me, so there's no way he'd reject it…

Nozomi Anesaki
"Senpai... did you bring your lunch today?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"My lunch box? I did."

…What?

Nozomi Anesaki
"You did…?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"? You meant my lunch box, right?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes…"
Mizuho Hoshina
"Yes, I have it with me."

Whaaat…?
Hozumi-san, weren't you supposed to tell Senpai that he didn't need to make a lunch box...?
…Hm?
My eyes suddenly fell on Senpai's hands. A cute paper bag was hanging from them.
…Ah, I see what happened…

Nozomi Anesaki
"Did Shizune-san make it…?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"Yeah, that's right."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I-I see…"
Mizuho Hoshina
"? Did something happen to your lunch?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"No, it's nothing... Well then, I'll be taking my leave now..."
Mizuho Hoshina
"Okay…? See you?"

I turned away from Senpai, who seemed puzzled by the whole exchange.
As I walked away on my crutches, my shoulders gradually slumped.
I... couldn't give him the lunch box after all…
I think Senpai would have accepted it anyway.
…But I just couldn't bring myself to do it.
Because my lunch box couldn't compare to Shizune-san's. Because I couldn't compare to Shizune-san.
I just didn't have any confidence in myself.

Chapter 14: In his own way

Female student
"See you, Nozomi!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah, bye-bye!"
Male student

"Vice President Anesaki, is your leg okay?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"It's okay, thank you for your concern."
Female student
"Oh, Nozomi. Some guy at the school gate said he was waiting for you."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh?"

Could it be…?
When I made my way to the school gate, I found Hozumi-san waiting there on his bicycle, exactly as I thought. Did Hoshina-senpai ask him to help me again?
Regardless, I wasn't particularly eager to face him.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Yo."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Hello."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Hm? You're kind of quiet today. Did something happen?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"It's nothing... Actually, what brings you here today?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Stop being so polite, it's creeping me o– Ah, I get it. It's because everyone's watching. Get on."

Hozumi-san snatched my belongings and threw them into the basket of his bicycle.
Whoa, the lunch box's going to get all messed up.
...Actually, whatever. I'm the one eating it anyway.
I sat down on the back of the bicycle and wrapped my arms around Hozumi-san's waist.
Once we were a short distance away from the school, Hozumi-san glanced at me sideways.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Looks like people at school see you and Mizuho as a couple."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh? How do you know that?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"I heard someone talking about that while I was waiting."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Well, it's true that rumors like that are going around..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"They said you two were apparently 'made for each other.' They even called you 'innocent and pure.' I nearly cracked up."

Hozumi-san's shoulders shook with laughter.
Grr... Actually, no, I'm not even annoyed anymore. I think I've gotten used to it somehow.

Hozumi Hoshina
"So it's not just Mizuho. The whole school fell for it."

Nozomi Anesaki
"Well, yeah."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Don't you get tired?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh?"

My heart skipped a beat. He suddenly hit the nail right on the head.

Nozomi Anesaki
"No… Not really?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Hmm."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...By the way, why did you come again? Did Hoshina-senpai ask you?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"No, that's not it. I just decided I'd give you a ride home until your leg heals."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ohh... That's surprisingly considerate of you."
Hozumi Hoshina
"I was bored anyway."
Nozomi Anesaki
"So you're just killing time, huh?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"By the way, did you give him the lunch box?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Aah…"

A sigh escaped my lips before I knew it.
I don't really want to talk about it... I feel like Hozumi-san would just make fun of me.

Hozumi Hoshina
"...What's wrong? Did you mess up the lunch box?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...No, the lunch box was perfect. ...Probably."
Hozumi Hoshina
"? Did you not ask Mizuho whether he liked it or not?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...I didn't give it to him."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Huh?! But why?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"He already had a lunch box."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Huh? I definitely told him not to make it."
Nozomi Anesaki
"He received it from Shizune-san."
Hozumi Hoshina

"...Huh…? Really…?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"…Yes."
Hozumi Hoshina
"You should've just given it to him anyway... Mizuho definitely would've accepted it."
Nozomi Anesaki
"But… her lunch box is just better..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...You get strangely hesitant sometimes. Why are you so hung up on Shizune?"

...No. Shizune-san wasn't the only reason I couldn't hand over the lunch box.
Deep down, I think I still have doubts.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Is Senpai… really in love with me?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Huh? Are you still doubting me? I've repeated it so many times already."

But ultimately, I think Senpai likes the "pure and innocent" version of me that everyone at school knows. Not the calculating, selfish person I actually am.

Nozomi Anesaki
"*Sigh*... Anyway, it's fine. I'm giving up on the lunch box."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...What are you going to do with it?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I'll eat it myself."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Hmm…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...I'm hungry."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I see."
Hozumi Hoshina
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...I'm really hungry, you know."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I heard you."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...I kinda want to eat something."
Nozomi Anesaki
"You should get something from a convenience store then."
Hozumi Hoshina

"...You're... really hopeless."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Is that really all you have to say?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...? What do you mean?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Ah, damn it. You're so slow. Just give me your lunch box. I'll eat whatever."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh? My lunch box?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Yeah. I'll eat it."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Why are you ordering me around?"

I pretended to be indignant, but once I finally realized what Hozumi-san meant, a smile crept onto my face.
It seems Hozumi-san was trying to comfort me in his own way.

Nozomi Anesaki
"You know, if you don't learn to be a little more tactful, girls won't like you."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Shut up. Mind your business."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Well... I guess it fits you."
Hozumi Hoshina
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I guess I'll let you have it just once. As an exception."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...That's kind of an annoying way to put it."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...I'd be happy if you tried it..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Gross."

As Hozumi-san and I continued bantering, he stopped the bicycle in front of a park.
He probably intended to have lunch here.
I sat on the bench and placed the lunch box in front of him.
But before I opened the lid…

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Have you gotten a lunch box from Shizune-san before, Hozumi-san?"

I asked because I was suddenly curious.

Hozumi Hoshina

"Well, a couple of times."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Hmm..."

...Now the standards were much higher.
While I sat there hesitating over the lunch box, Hozumi-san looked at my hands with a confused expression.

Hozumi Hoshina
"What happened to your hand...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hm? My hand…?"

I shifted attention to my hands.
My eyes fell on the bandages wrapped around my fingers, and a sudden rush of shame welled up inside me.
Getting this badly hurt just from making a lunch box makes me look like a total klutz.

Nozomi Anesaki
"I just... wasn't paying attention and got hurt, that's all."
Hozumi Hoshina
"While cooking?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Just so you know, I'm pretty decent at cooking. I do have experience with it."
Hozumi Hoshina
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Wh-what's with that expression...? I'm serious... This lunch box turned out pretty great, actually. Look."

I took a deep breath and opened the lid.
...Ah, thank goodness. It doesn't look nearly as jumbled as I expected.
Looking at it now, I think I did a pretty good job.
...Which makes me a little sad that Senpai never got to try it.

Nozomi Anesaki
"…Well? Isn't it amazing?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Yeah... I have to admit, it's genuinely impressive..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"! I know, right?!"
Hozumi Hoshina
"…Yeah…"

Despite saying that, Hozumi-san didn't seem particularly interested.
He stared at the lunch box with a serious expression and remained quiet.

Nozomi Anesaki

"...What?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Nah... forget it. I'm fine without it."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh? Why?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"..."

Hozumi-san remained silent, looking like he was searching for the right words. Was there something wrong with my lunch box?

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Did I put something you don't like in it?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Huh? ...No, that's not the reason…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"If it's the flavor you're worried about, I had my brother taste it beforehand, so I think it should be okay."
Hozumi Hoshina
"No, that's not it."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Then... are you worried about whether it's safe to eat? I kept it with a cold pack, so I don't think it went bad."
Hozumi Hoshina
"That's not the problem."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Then what?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Forget it, I just don't need it."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huuh?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"I don't really feel like eating anymore."

He said it in such a dismissive tone that it kind of rubbed me the wrong way.
…What's going on? He complimented the appearance of the lunch box, and yet... Is he being wary of something?
Do I really look like I'm that terrible at cooking? Is it because I'm injured?
It's true that things didn't go smoothly today, but the result itself should be perfectly fine. It's upsetting that he decided it's bad before even trying it.
…I have no other choice.
I picked up my chopsticks and grabbed the pork cutlet.

Nozomi Anesaki
"This is something I'm really proud of."

I held the pork fillet cutlet out right in front of Hozumi-san.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Uh…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Try it."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...I told you, I don't need it."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I know it's good, I swear. Just try this one piece, please."
Hozumi Hoshina
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Come on, come on."

I waved the fillet cutlet in front of Hozumi-san's mouth as he continued to resist.
After hesitating for a while, Hozumi-san finally gave in and let me feed it to him.

Hozumi Hoshina
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Well?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Yeah, it's delicious."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Right?!"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Give me more."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Sure, sure."

I grabbed the pork cutlet and pushed it into Hozumi-san's mouth.

Hozumi Hoshina
"...It's really good."
Nozomi Anesaki
"See, I told you! There's still plenty left, so eat up!"
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Give me more then."

For some reason, Hozumi-san reminded me of Shun. Seeing him enjoy it this much made all the effort I put into making it worthwhile.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Okay."

I held the fillet cutlet out in front of Hozumi-san's face again.

Hozumi Hoshina
"..."

Nozomi Anesaki
"...? Open your mouth."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Uh, how long are you gonna keep doing this?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh? …Uwaah!!!"

Oh no...! Wait, what was I even doing?! That was so embarrassing...!
I hurriedly placed the chopsticks on top of the lunch box. Hozumi-san looked completely dumbfounded.

Hozumi Hoshina
"You're just noticing that now...? Wait... do you just naturally treat people like this?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"N-no, it's just... You kind of reminded me of my younger brother... so I just did it without thinking..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Your younger brother… But I'm older than you."
Nozomi Anesaki
"That's true…"

Being with Hozumi-san feels a lot like spending time with Shun.
It's probably because I can be myself without putting on an act.

Hozumi Hoshina
"You're pretty close with him, huh."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Well, we get along well enough. ...It seems like you and Senpai aren't very close, though."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Well, yeah."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I just can't imagine not getting along with Senpai."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...You idolize Mizuho too much."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Am I wrong?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"No... he's seriously incredible. He can do literally anything, he's kind and so damn earnest. You don't come across people like him very often."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hmm…"

It was a little unexpected. I never thought Hozumi-san would praise Senpai so honestly.

Hozumi Hoshina
"...I used to envy him."

He murmured it so softly I almost didn't catch it, then picked up the chopsticks and started eating the lunch box.
Next up is the rolled omelet.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Well?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Mm… It's good."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Really?"

His reaction seemed a little lukewarm for someone who said he liked it.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Yes, it's really tasty. But I prefer it sweet."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Oh, is that so? Hozumi-san, do you like sweets?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Well, yeah."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ooh... I didn't expect that."

I mean, it doesn't really match his looks... or rather, it doesn't match his personality.

Nozomi Anesaki
"So I guess twins don't necessarily have the same tastes."
Hozumi Hoshina
"? What do you mean?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Senpai said he doesn't like sweets."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Aah… Yeah, Mizuho really hates them."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I see."
Hozumi Hoshina
"But he probably gets homemade sweets from girls all the time, right?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah, that happens pretty often at school."
Hozumi Hoshina
"He's really earnest, so he always makes himself eat every single one. Sometimes he's practically in tears, and it's honestly hilarious."
Hozumi Hoshina
"It gets especially bad on Valentine's Day. He even threw up once."
Nozomi Anesaki
"That's not really something you should laugh about..."

It's more pitiful than anything.
If he hates sweets that much, he shouldn't accept them.

...But that's exactly what I like about Hoshina-senpai—the fact that he would never do something like that.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Senpai is really kind…"
Hozumi Hoshina
"This trait puts him at a loss though."
Nozomi Anesaki
"That's exactly what makes it so admirable."
Hozumi Hoshina
"…Uh-huh, sure…"

Hozumi Hoshina
"Ah, I'm so full."

Hozumi-san slouched lazily and rubbed his stomach. ...Looking at him, I couldn't help thinking his whole image had completely fallen apart.

Hozumi Hoshina
"? What are you staring at?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"It's nothing... I was just wondering if twins can really be this different from each other."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Sorry I'm not like Mizuho, I guess."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I'm used to it already."

At first, the huge contrast between his looks and personality was a major turn-off, but after spending more time with him, I stopped caring about it.
If anything, Hozumi-san turned out to have many more good qualities than I expected.
...The lunch box sat there completely empty. Not a single grain of rice was left behind. He had eaten every last bit of it.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Hehehehe."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Why are you smiling like that...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I was just thinking about how thoroughly you ate everything."

It's funny, considering how suspicious he was of it at first.

Hozumi Hoshina
"...Well… I was really hungry…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I guess so."
Hozumi Hoshina
"..."

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Thank you for eating it."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Huh?!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Woah, what happened?!"
Hozumi Hoshina
"...No... I just didn't see that coming..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huuh…?"

Hozumi-san fell silent. He looked somewhat embarrassed.

Hozumi Hoshina
"...I know It's kind of pointless to ask now that I've already eaten it, but was it really okay for me to have it?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"What?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"…Maybe you should have given it to Mizuho after all?"

...I was surprised. I never thought Hozumi-san was this considerate.
A warm feeling welled up inside me, and before I realized it, I was smiling.

Hozumi Hoshina
"…? Why are you smiling?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Well... it's fine. I'm more than happy just knowing I got to show someone how good this lunch box really is."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Hmm…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I'll try again with Hoshina-senpai someday."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...You really like Mizuho, huh."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I-is that bad…?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"No, not really."

Hozumi-san sighed. What on earth was that about...?

Hozumi Hoshina
"Ready to go?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah…?"

Chapter 15: Just the way he is

Hozumi Hoshina
"...Ah."

As soon as we left the park, Hozumi-san put one foot down on the ground and stopped the bicycle.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...What happened?"

I leaned forward to get a better look.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Oh…"

It was Shizune-san. She was always so adorable, no matter how many times I saw her... While I was thinking that, she noticed us and hurried over.

Shizune Hiiragi
"Hello, Nozomi-san, Hozumi-kun...!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hello."
Hozumi Hoshina
"..."
Shizune Hiiragi
"What a coincidence, meeting you here."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Indeed. Are you on your way home from school, Shizune-san?"
Shizune Hiiragi
"Yes. And you two...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"We…"

I glanced at Hozumi-san.

Hozumi Hoshina
"..."

Hozumi-san stayed silent. I wonder why.... He's acting strangely cold.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Um... my sprain still hasn't healed, so... he's giving me a ride home."
Shizune Hiiragi
"Oh, really? ...Hozumi-kun, that's so kind of you."
Hozumi Hoshina
"..."
Shizune Hiiragi

"..."

...Wait, what is this uncomfortable tension?
This feels incredibly awkward... Why is Hozumi-san staying quiet...?

Shizune Hiiragi
"...Ah, right…"

Shizune-san nervously opened her bag. From inside, she pulled out a small package wrapped in flower-patterned paper.

Shizune Hiiragi
"We made madeleines at my club today. If you don't mind, I would like you to have some..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Oh, are you sure?"
Shizune Hiiragi
"Yes. Here."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Waah... Thank you very much."

I accepted the package from Shizune-san. Despite myself, my heart skipped a beat.
I am a girl, and even I was this affected... I can't imagine what it must feel like for guys.
Hoshina-san has more than likely experienced this before. Is he made of steel or something...? I can't understand how he hasn't fallen in love with her yet.

Shizune Hiiragi
"I have some for you too, Hozumi-kun– uh…?"

Shizune-san's hand, which had been rummaging through her bag, suddenly stopped moving.
Then she began searching through her bag again with renewed urgency. Her expression fell.
...However, she quickly composed herself, and before long, she pulled out another floral-patterned package.

Shizune Hiiragi
"Here, Hozumi-kun."

She gave him an angelic smile.

Hozumi Hoshina
"I don't need it."

My affection rating for Hozumi Hoshina went down by 10.

Shizune Hiiragi
"You don't... like madeleines...?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"I don't really dislike them."

Shizune Hiiragi
"Then why... won't you accept it...?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"...I just don't need it. Give it to someone else."

Shizune-san's expression grew gloomier and gloomier in response to Hozumi-san's cold tone.

Shizune Hiiragi
"What happened...?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Huh?"
Shizune Hiiragi
"You used to be kind... like Mizuho-kun..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"..."

The air grew tense. I saw Hozumi-san's grip on the handlebars tighten.

Hozumi Hoshina
"You were just mistaken about me."

Hozumi-san quietly spat out the words,
then kicked off the ground and started pedalling.
I hurriedly clung to Hozumi-san's back.
The bicycle picked up speed rapidly, and when I looked back, Shizune-san was already nowhere to be seen.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Hey."
Hozumi Hoshina
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hozumi-san."
Hozumi Hoshina
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hozumi-san!"
Hozumi Hoshina
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Scumbag."
Hozumi Hoshina
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Shithead."
Hozumi Hoshina
"..."

This is hopeless. His mind is somewhere else entirely.
…I have no other choice.
I clung tighter to Hozumi-san's back.
And then…

Nozomi Anesaki
"Tickle, tickle, tickle."

I tickled Hozumi-san's stomach.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Fuah?!"

He responded with a weird gasp.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Gross..."

I grimaced and removed my hand from Hozumi-san's stomach.

Hozumi Hoshina
"What are you doing, you moron?!"

He finally turned around.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Hozumi-san, you're the worst."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Huh?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Shizune-san was deeply hurt by that."

Hozumi-san clicked his tongue softly and faced forward without answering.
...Ah, I see. Something about it just clicked.

Nozomi Anesaki
"I wonder why Shizune-san gave me madeleines."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...I doubt she had any particular intention behind it."
Nozomi Anesaki
"But now she won't have any for Senpai."
Hozumi Hoshina
"She's a bit of an airhead, you know."

...Confirmed. My suspicions were right. Hozumi-san is actually very socially inept.

Nozomi Anesaki

"You can't do that."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Huh?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"If you just say, 'I don't need it', people will misunderstand you."
Nozomi Anesaki
"When it comes to girls, you need to be direct and kind."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...What are you even talking about?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"You should have put it more gently and suggested giving them to Senpai instead."
Hozumi Hoshina
"..."

Hozumi-san made a strangled noise and turned around.
When I grinned at him, he looked away, looking uncomfortable.

Hozumi Hoshina
"It's not like that. I just didn't want them because I was full, that's all."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Oh, really? I'm sure you would find some place in your stomach for sweets."
Hozumi Hoshina
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...That's why girls are cuter when they're a little dumb…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I didn't quite catch that?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"You're not cute at all."
Nozomi Anesaki
"You need to add a little note saying 'except for her face.' "
Hozumi Hoshina
"So you're admitting everything else..."

Well... even I have to admit that my personality isn't exactly cute.
A girl like Shizune-san is what "cuteness" is all about.
Speaking of which…

Nozomi Anesaki
"Shizune-san doesn't know that Senpai hates sweet things, does she?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Mm, yeah, that's right."
Nozomi Anesaki
"It's so frustrating to watch... I kinda feel sorry for both of them..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Well, Mizuho is okay with receiving sweets, so I guess it's fine."

Nozomi Anesaki
"You're not going to tell Shizune-san that Senpai doesn't like sweets?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"...She's been giving Mizuho sweets for years already, you know? It's too late to tell her now... I mean, she'd be pretty crushed."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh... well, I guess so…"

That really would be hard for her to hear. I could understand why that would hurt her. She'd be shocked if she learned that everything she'd done with best intentions had only caused trouble for the person on the receiving end.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Well, watching Mizuho force himself to eat them is pretty hilarious too."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Don't tell me that was your true motive all along..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Nah."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hmm… or maybe…"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Hm?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"You're actually helping her."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Helping? With what?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Her relationship with Hoshina-senpai?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"...If you're talking about what happened earlier, I really didn't need them."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...If that's how you want to see it, that's fine."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Besides, I'm not helping you either."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh, but didn't you encourage me and give me advice?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"That wasn't my intention. I was just stating facts and my thoughts."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hmm…?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Well, I hope it goes well for you."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Why?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Why, you ask...? Why are you picking on that part specifically?"
Nozomi Anesaki

"I mean, even if things went well between Senpai and me, there's nothing in it for you, is there?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Yeah, nothing at all."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Then why do you care whether things work out between us?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Come on... Is it really so strange for me to care without a personal benefit? I'm just genuinely rooting for you."

"Rooting for me"... Why does it somehow sound so unconvincing coming from Hozumi-san?
I couldn't shake the feeling that there was some ulterior motive behind it, but I didn't see how it could hurt me, so I just let it slide.
But there was something else that was bothering me.

Shizune Hiiragi
"You used to be so kind… like Mizuho-kun..."

Shizune-san's words…
And the cold way Hozumi-san responded afterward left me feeling unsettled.
His oddly distant attitude before that was on my mind, too. You'd think childhood friends would be a lot more comfortable around each other.
I wonder if something happened between them... The thought left me feeling uneasy.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Hozumi-san."

Just as I started to speak, the bicycle stopped. We had already reached my house.

Hozumi Hoshina
"We've arrived."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ah… Yeah, thanks."

I took the crutches from Hozumi-san and got off the bicycle.

Hozumi Hoshina
"What were you trying to say?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Nothing, really."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Hmm… Well, see– Ah."

Suddenly, Hozumi-san turned to face me.

Hozumi Hoshina
"The lunch box…"
Nozomi Anesaki

"Yeah?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Th…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Th–"
Nozomi Anesaki
"What?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"...No, never mind. See ya."

Hozumi-san swiftly turned his bike around, gave me a little wave, and rode away.
...I think he probably wanted to say "thank you." He's really, truly terrible at expressing his feelings directly.
He could learn a thing or two from Hoshina-senpai.
...Well, on second thought, that would be unsettling in its own way.
I realized that I was finally able to separate Hozumi-san's face from the image of Hoshina-senpai.

Chapter 16: The worst way to wake up

Nozomi Anesaki
"*Yaaawn*…"

As I pressed the buttons on the game console, I let out a big yawn.
I glanced at the alarm clock sitting beside me. It was still a whole hour before my usual bedtime.
Come to think of it, I woke up at 4 AM today, so I haven't gotten much sleep.
It was still a little early, but I decided to go to bed.

Wald
"Hey."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh?"
Wald
"Wake up, you."
Nozomi Anesaki
"L-Lord Wald…?"
Wald
"Whatcha need?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"D-did something happen…?"
Wald
"Huh? Why?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"It's just that you seem… different from usual…"

Wald
"Haha, you really are an idiot."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Gah?!"
Wald
"This is the real me."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh…"
Wald
"It wasn't revealed in the original, but I'm actually a twisted, manipulative character."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh… Huh…? What?!"
Wald
"This will be the plot of WataPuri's sequel."
Nozomi Anesaki
"No way?!"
Wald
"You'd better savor this gap moe, you little shit."
Nozomi Anesaki
"As if…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"As if I'd EVER find that appealing!!!"

I snapped my eyes open and screamed.
Bright light shone through the curtains. It was morning.
I instantly realized it was a dream, and let out a sigh of relief.
That was truly… a nightmare…
Lord Wald doesn't need some "secret manipulative" side... Honestly, if they did that to his character in the sequel, there'd be an uproar.
I sat up while rubbing my eyes.
Then I noticed my alarm clock and cell phone were ringing.
Having two alarms going off is a little excessive.
I slowly turned off the alarm clock.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Huh?"

Something feels off. Now that I think about it, I never set an alarm on my phone.
Feeling confused, I picked up my phone and checked the screen.
It was a call from Shun.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes, hello-hello?"

I absentmindedly picked up the phone. Actually, why did Shun call me in the first place?

Shun Anesaki
“Ah, y-you picked up…!”

Nozomi Anesaki
"Hm? Yeah? Why are you calling?"
Shun Anesaki
“Why, you ask...? Where are you right now, Sis?”
Nozomi Anesaki
"Where? Well, at home."
Shun Anesaki
“Huh?! Still at home?!”
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh? …Uh…?"

Only then did my brain finally start working properly.
There is no way…
I frantically checked the clock, and at the same time, Shun started shouting.

Shun Anesaki
“It's already past 8:10!!!”
Nozomi Anesaki
"...WHAAAAAAT?!?!"

I quickly got out of bed and opened the closet door wide. Shun was muttering something on the other end of the phone.

Shun Anesaki
“Jeez… You seriously just woke up…? What the heck were you doing…?”
Nozomi Anesaki
"Why didn't you wake me up?!"
Shun Anesaki
“I did try to wake you up! I tried really hard! But you got mad at me, Sis!”
Nozomi Anesaki
"I didn't!!!"
Shun Anesaki
“You totally did!!! You even hit me in the face!”
Nozomi Anesaki
"S-seriously...? I'm sorry about that."
Shun Anesaki
"*Sigh*... Well, at least you're awake. You've got less than 20 minutes left, can you still make it?”
Nozomi Anesaki
"Don't ask me obvious questions…"

It takes 15 minutes to run from here to school.
Even if I spent no time getting ready at all, there was no way I could make it in time with how slowly I move on crutches.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Ugh... I'll be late... it's such a huge blow to my image..."
Shun Anesaki

“Well, I guess there's no helping it. Just hurry up. I'm hanging up now.”
Nozomi Anesaki
"Okay…"
Shun Anesaki
“Don't spend too much time getting ready, okay? See ya.”

As soon as the call ended, I threw my phone down and hurriedly put on my uniform.
It may be a futile effort, but I have to do whatever I can to be a little less late…!
Ten minutes left. I gave up on my face mask and massage, and only did the bare minimum to get ready, but…

Nozomi Anesaki
"..."

I looked myself over in the mirror, and an indescribable sense of unease washed over me.
I wonder if I look good today.
Maybe it's because I skipped my face mask, but my skin feels a little less moisturized than usual. And because I didn't have enough time to blow-dry my hair properly, it's not as sleek and straight as I'd like.
If my usual appearance level is in A tier, then today I'd say I'm about a B-minus…
I envy those naturally beautiful girls whose looks are always in S-tier without even trying.
...Someone like Shizune-san.

Chapter 17: Unexpected turn of events

I trudged out of the house, leaning on my crutches.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Oh, there you are."

I couldn't believe my eyes.

Nozomi Anesaki
"H-Hozumi-san?! What are you doing here?!"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Come on, hop on. You're running late, aren't you?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh, what...?"

I couldn't process what was going on.
While I stood still in confusion, Hozumi-san briskly took my bag from me and put it in his bicycle basket.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Hurry up."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Y-yes!"

Urged on, I climbed onto the rear rack, and Hozumi-san immediately set off on the bike. The scenery was flying by at an unbelievable pace. If I weren't careful, I could easily fall off. Clinging tightly to his back, I asked Hozumi-san a question.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Did you need something from me?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Huh? Not really."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh, then why were you outside my house?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"I happened to run into your brother."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"And overheard your phone call."
Nozomi Anesaki
"You actually came to my house because of that...?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"...It would take too long on crutches. And I'm responsible for your injury, so... I had no choice."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ooh…"

I was touched. He was being far more considerate than I ever thought possible when I first met him.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Wait, are you sure this is okay? You go to Higashi High, right? Isn't this a huge detour?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"I'm fine. They're pretty lax about being late and stuff."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Really…?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"More importantly, you've got about seven minutes left, right? That's cutting it close. Should I take a shortcut?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Wait, there is one?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Yeah. I'm gonna go faster, so hang on tight."
Nozomi Anesaki
"O-okay…!"

The bike veered away from the usual route to school and entered a narrow alley. The road was full of bumps since it wasn't properly paved.

Nozomi Anesaki

"My ass! My ass hurts!!! The bouncing is insane!"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Don't say 'ass.' "
Nozomi Anesaki
"M-my bum hurts!"
Hozumi Hoshina
"You mean your butt, right?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"My butt hurts!"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Actually, it's buttocks."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes, my poor buttocks!!!"
Hozumi Hoshina
"We're almost done, so hang in there."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Really?!"

After leaving the alley, we returned to the usual path to school. From here, I should arrive at school in another minute or two.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Looks like you'll make it."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I think I injured my buttocks..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Do you want me to caress them or something?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"…Maybe if you give me 30,000 yen?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Whaat? A butt's only worth maybe 10,000 yen at best."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...So you'd actually pay 10,000 yen... for a butt..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"I'm not paying, obviously. I'm only talking about the market price."
Nozomi Anesaki
"What market is that…?"

Three minutes left. I arrived at school just barely in time.
I got off the bicycle and took my bag from Hozumi-san.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Thanks for the ride!"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Yeah."
Nozomi Anesaki
"See you later!"

I waved to Hozumi-san and turned away.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Huh?! Hey...!"

When he called out to stop me, I turned around and saw Hozumi-san beckoning me over, his gaze flickering away awkwardly.

Nozomi Anesaki
"What?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Can I touch your butt?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Wh-what?"

Where did that come from all of a sudden?
Is this just a continuation of what we were talking about earlier? Did he seriously just stop me because he wanted to touch my butt?

Nozomi Anesaki
"Are you really that obsessed with butts...?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"No, that's not–actually, whatever. Just let me touch it."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Why are you ordering me around?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Please... allow me to touch your butt..."

...Ew, what a creep.

Nozomi Anesaki
"No, not even for 50,000 yen."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Tch… For a slut, you sure are stingy with your butt."

…I don't even want to argue with him anymore.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Either way, the answer is no. Don't act like touching a woman's butt is no big deal."

After I bluntly turned him down, Hozumi-san dramatically shrugged his shoulders.

Hozumi Hoshina
"I was just trying to spare you the embarrassment..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Huh? What do you mean?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Your skirt's flipped up, and your underwear is fully visible."

Nozomi Anesaki
"!!!"

I hurriedly pulled my skirt down and clearly felt the resistance of the fabric. It really had been flipped up quite a lot.
I stood there frozen in embarrassment, keeping one hand on my skirt, when Hozumi-san gently patted my shoulder.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Relax. No one else saw anything."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Th-that's not the issue here...!"
Hozumi Hoshina
"It's no big deal to me, so forget about it."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...That's somehow not making me feel any better..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Nice panties."
Nozomi Anesaki
"What the hell are you saying, you pervert?!"
Hozumi Hoshina
"What is it now…? I'm trying to be nice here."
Nozomi Anesaki
"You have a very strange way of showing it..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"You have two minutes left by the way."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Whoa... oh no...!"

I started to rush through the gate, but then turned back to Hozumi-san again.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Hm? What?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"H-hey... are things okay now?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"What do you mean?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Do I look strange at all…?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"I can't see your panties anymore."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Anything other than that?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Not really?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"S-so you think everything's okay...?"
Hozumi Hoshina

"Only appearance-wise."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I see! Thanks, bye!"

I felt a little more confident.
I straightened my back, spun around, and walked through the gate with a light step.

Hozumi Hoshina
"...Uh... that wasn't meant to sound like a compliment..."

Chapter 18: A blossoming romance?

I made it to homeroom on time, preserving my perfect record of never being late.
I've been through a lot since this morning, but somehow I'm in a good mood.

Miho Orikasa
"Nozomi, you're looking awfully cheerful today."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh? Really?"
Miho Orikasa
"Did something gooood happen today?"

She gave me a knowing, teasing smile, but I had no idea what she was getting at.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...What? There's nothing going on between me and Hoshina-senpai. At least, not right now."

…Unfortunately.

Miho Orikasa
"Hehehe... Yes, I suppose there's nothing going on with him after all."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Yeah?"
Miho Orikasa
"But it seems like you're pretty close with his lookalike, aren't you?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh?!"

The "lookalike" she mentioned was undoubtedly Hozumi-san.
I wouldn't exactly say we were close, but I was caught off guard that Miho brought him up in the first place.

Nozomi Anesaki
"How do you know...?"
Miho Orikasa
"What do you mean, 'how'? It's been the talk of the school since yesterday. People are saying you have been walking home with him, looking aaaall buddy-buddy."

Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh…?"

It's true that a few students saw Hozumi-san and me walking home together, but I never thought people would start gossiping about it.

Miho Orikasa
"Oh? You weren't aware? Being the school's Madonna means having a swarm of paparazzi following you around."

I couldn't argue with that. I guess that's just the price of being popular. That's exactly why I can't let my guard down at school.

Miho Orikasa
"By the way, who exactly is this lookalike? Some people are saying he's Hoshina-senpai's twin."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah, they're right. He's his younger twin brother."
Miho Orikasa
"Oh, so that was true. Wow... I can see why you'd be tempted."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...What do you mean?"
Miho Orikasa
"He looks like Hoshina-senpai, doesn't he? Wouldn't that make you fall for him?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hahaha."

I couldn't help but laugh.

Nozomi Anesaki
"No, definitely not. It's just their faces that are similar. They're totally different people."
Miho Orikasa
"Oh yeah... Now that you mention it, I heard he had a bit of a bad-boy reputation."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I can't stress the 'bad' part enough."
Miho Orikasa
"Hmm... But you don't actually hate him, do you?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh?"
Miho Orikasa
"You looked like you were having fun."
Nozomi Anesaki
"R-really…?"

When I absentmindedly touched my cheek, Miho had the look of a paparazzo who had just scored a huge scoop.

Miho Orikasa

"Well, well... I have a feeling this is going to be interesting."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...What exactly is going to be interesting?"
Miho Orikasa
"Maybe the Hoshina twins will end up fighting over you?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Haha, not happening."

Hozumi-san said he is rooting for my romance.
Besides, he seems to think I'm a "little shit," so I doubt things would ever go that way.

Miho Orikasa
"But you never know what might happen when it comes to looooove."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Still…"
Miho Orikasa
"I mean, Nozomi, you and Hoshina-senpai aren't dating yet, right?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh… Well, yeah..."
Miho Orikasa
"Don't get too comfortable just because everyone thinks you're already a couple. Someone else might beat you to it."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."

Shizune-san's face instantly popped into my head.
But strangely enough, feelings of anxiety or urgency didn't really well up inside me.
...Is it because Hoshina-senpai is already interested in me?
...Am I being too conceited?

It happened as I was heading to the entrance after the final homeroom ended.

Mizuho Hoshina
"Ah, Anesaki-san."

I ran into Hoshina-senpai just as he was coming down the stairs.
Of course, he was just as handsome as ever. I could feel my heartbeat quicken.

Mizuho Hoshina
"How is your leg?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I think I'm recovering well. The pain has started to go away, too."
Mizuho Hoshina
"I see, that's good."

No matter how many times I see this smile of his, it still makes my heart flutter. I'm reminded over and over again just how much I like him…

Mizuho Hoshina
"Anesaki-san, are you heading home now?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Y-yes. And you, Hoshina-senpai…?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"I still have classes."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Oh, really?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"Yeah. It's like a special exam-prep course."

Taking a closer look, I saw that Senpai was carrying several advanced-looking study guides. He must be aiming for a university with very competitive exams. I'd expect nothing less from him.

Nozomi Anesaki
"I wish you good luck."
Mizuho Hoshina
"Thank you. ...Um, by the way…"

Suddenly, Hoshina-senpai lowered his voice.
He glanced around cautiously, then moved his face a little closer to mine.

Mizuho Hoshina
"I know this might sound… a little strange, but…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Y-yes?! What is it…?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"What do you think of Hozumi, Anesaki-san...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Um… Hozumi-san…?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"Yeah…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh…"

"A kind shithead" would fit him perfectly, though I probably shouldn't actually say that…

Nozomi Anesaki
"I think he's really kind."

I decided to remove the "shithead" part. I felt like I'd erased a crucial detail of his character.

Mizuho Hoshina
"Ah... um..."

Senpai looked like he wanted to press further. My earlier response hadn't quite given him the answer he was looking for.

Mizuho Hoshina
"Can I ask you something directly?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"...Do you like him?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"?! A-absolutely not…!"

He caught me off guard. So that was the meaning behind his question.
But why would he ask something like that...?
I gave Senpai a puzzled look, and he responded with an awkward, forced smile.

Mizuho Hoshina
"I guess it really was just a misunderstanding. Some strange rumors had been going around, so I was a little worried."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Strange rumors…?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"I heard that you and Hozumi are dating..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ah…"

Apparently, even the third years have heard about it. Those paparazzi are truly terrifying...

Nozomi Anesaki
"That's not the case... We've been going home together because of my injury..."
Mizuho Hoshina
"Yeah, you're right. Sorry for asking something weird out of the blue. …Ahh, I'm glad."

The words he quietly muttered made my eyes widen.
…Why is he glad?
Is he glad that Hozumi-san and I aren't dating...?
That almost makes it sound like Senpai has feelings for me.
…So this is true? He really likes me…?

Nozomi Anesaki
"..."

What should I do...? My heart is beating so fast…
I almost felt like I should just go for it and make my move already.
However…
…Not yet.
Not yet. I can't.

Mizuho Hoshina
"Okay, well, I'm off now. See you tomorrow."

Nozomi Anesaki
"Y-yes... Goodbye."

I watched Senpai walk away, then headed to the entrance on shaky legs.

Chapter 19: Information gathering

Hozumi Hoshina
"Yo."

Hozumi-san was waiting by the school gate again today.
Not wanting to attract the paparazzi's attention, I immediately got on the bicycle.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Hmm... I think my butt's still a little sore."
Hozumi Hoshina
"I'd be happy to give you a massage."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Maybe if you give me 5,000 yen."

This was an incredibly good deal.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Huh… Are you serious…?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hehe... I'm in a good mood today."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Did something happen?"

Hozumi-san turned around with a puzzled expression.
I recalled my conversation with Hoshina-senpai earlier and couldn't stop myself from grinning.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Now I actually believe that Senpai has feelings for me."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Huh? Why?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"He asked me whether I liked you. When I denied it, he seemed relieved. ...That means what I think it means, right?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"..."

Hozumi-san furrowed his brows, and his focus subtly shifted elsewhere. He appeared to be deep in thought.

Nozomi Anesaki

"...Hozumi-san?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Hmm... Ah, no... Yeah, that's good."
Nozomi Anesaki
"That sounded forced."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Hearing other people brag about their romance is extremely boring."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Didn't you say, 'I hope it goes well for you'?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"But if things really go well, it kind of ruins the fun."
Nozomi Anesaki
"You scumbag…"
Hozumi Hoshina
"...So? What are you going to do now?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Well… I was thinking I'd make my move once we become a little closer..."

I still couldn't bring myself to do it.
If I could become closer to Senpai, maybe whatever was weighing on my heart would finally go away.

Nozomi Anesaki
"That's why I want you to tell me more about Senpai."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Like what?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Um... like his hobbies? Things he doesn't like?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"You should ask him stuff like yourself. I mean, how do you not even know something that basic?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Because... My only point of contact with Senpai is the student council. We don't really talk outside of it."
Hozumi Hoshina
"I'm surprised you still fell for him despite that."
Nozomi Anesaki
"It's because he's handsome."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Just that?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"He's also kind."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Kind, huh... I guess that's the kind of thing girls fall for."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Are you looking down on me or something?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Nope. If that's what you like, I guess it's fine."

For some reason, I got annoyed.
I actually think Hozumi-san is kind too, but he's getting on my nerves, so I'm not going to say it.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Either way, just tell me whatever you know about Senpai. Anything will do."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...I don't think it'll help though."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hm? Did you say something?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"No? ...Mizuho, huh? Let's see... You already know that cooking is his hobby, right?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah, that much I know."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Other than that... Oh, he likes things that require using his brain. Like reading."
Hozumi Hoshina
"He's really into mystery novels and reads them pretty often. I'd say that's probably his favorite pastime."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Oh ho..."

Mystery novels... Of course someone as smart as Senpai would be into something like that.
But...

Nozomi Anesaki
"I don't know anything about mystery novels…"

True to the otaku stereotype, the only kind of books I read are light novels.
Even among them, the only ones I read are things like romantic comedies and action stories.
I've never even picked up anything from the mystery genre.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Do you know any specific mystery novels...? Like the names of the books or the writers?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"[omitted]"

He listed quite a few, but I couldn't recognize a single one.

Nozomi Anesaki
"This is hopeless... I don't know any of these..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"I gave you some of the popular titles too, but you still don't know any of them?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Literature just isn't my thing..."
Hozumi Hoshina

If you want to get closer to Mizuho, you should probably get familiar with them. He's a hardcore mystery otaku."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Otaku…"

For some reason, I felt like there was a gap I couldn't bridge.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Hm… Oh, I know. I could lend you some books if you want."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"I've got a few of his favorites too. Why don't you try reading them?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Are you sure? Actually... are you into mystery novels too, Hozumi-san?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Nah, I can't stand reading. I'm more into Shonen Zump."

...I felt a little relieved.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Then why do you have them?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Well, just for reference? I tried reading them once, a long time ago."
Nozomi Anesaki
"And how did it go?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"...They're probably more interesting if you can follow the plot. If you're able to, that is."
Nozomi Anesaki
"That sounds kind of hard for an amateur..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"I mean, you should try one. It'll give you something to chat about with him."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Assuming I can actually read it."

We ended up stopping by the Hoshina household to get some of Hozumi-san's books.

Hozumi Hoshina
"I'll grab them real quick, so wait here a moment. Oh, actually, you can wait inside. It's pretty hot out here."

The direct sunlight was definitely painful on my skin. However…

Nozomi Anesaki
"...I'll pass."
Hozumi Hoshina
"You're really on guard, huh... Well, whatever."
Nozomi Anesaki

"I'll remind you that you were seriously considering paying 5000 yen to touch a butt."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Just so you know, I'm not into butts. I'm definitely a boobs guy."

Hozumi-san delivered that line with a ridiculously cool expression before heading inside.
He's truly a lost cause.
A few minutes later.
I suddenly heard people talking near the entrance.
No... this wasn't just people talking. It was probably yelling. Whatever was happening, it didn't sound very calm.

Hozumi Hoshina
"You're noisy... I said I get it. I'm leaving now."

The door opened just a bit, and Hozumi-san's voice came through clearly.

Woman's voice
"Wait, Hozumi! I want a proper explanation for why you were late!"
Hozumi Hoshina
"I already told you, I just took a detour. Why are you making such a big deal out of it?"
Woman's voice
"How many times do you think this makes now?! Try putting yourself in my shoes when I have to get calls from your teacher!"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Okay, okay, I get it, I'm sorry."
Woman's voice
"What is that attitude of yours?! Why can't you be a little more like Mizuho?!"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Okay, I get it. See ya."
Woman's voice
"Where do you think you're going?! You have exams soon, remember?! Quit messing around and study properly!!!"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Study properly? You want me to get into the same university as Mizuho?"
Woman's voice
"That's not too much to ask, is it?!"
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Screw that."

I heard his muttered retort, and then Hozumi-san roughly opened the door and stepped outside.

Hozumi・Nozomi
"..."

Our eyes met. I must have had a pretty strange look on my face.
Hozumi-san awkwardly scratched the back of his neck and walked over to me.

Hozumi Hoshina
"...I brought you a few books."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Thank you…"
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Okay, let's get going."
Nozomi Anesaki
"S-sure…"
Hozumi Hoshina
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."

Neither of us said anything for a while.
I could sense that Hozumi-san was tense, and I hesitated to say anything.
But I couldn't stop thinking about that conversation I'd just overheard.
It sounded like he got scolded for being late, and I was partly to blame for that.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Um… Hozumi-san…"
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Hm?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...I'm sorry."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Huh? What are you apologizing for?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...You were late because of me."
Hozumi Hoshina
"That was my decision. It has nothing to do with you."
Nozomi Anesaki
"If helping me was just going to get you in trouble, you should've ignored my problem."

Hozumi-san said his school was "lax" about being late, but judging from the conversation I just overheard, that clearly wasn't the case.

Hozumi Hoshina
"I'm used to that kind of thing. It's no big deal."

Even after everything that happened, he still acted like that so I wouldn't blame myself.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...I see. Thanks, then."

Keeping his feelings in mind, there was only one thing I could say.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Having a sibling…"

After a while, Hozumi-san spoke again.

Hozumi Hoshina
"...kind of sucks sometimes, doesn't it?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Uh?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Especially when you've got a monster of a sibling like Mizuho. People can't help but compare us and expect me to be just like him."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Since we look identical, it only makes things worse."
Hozumi Hoshina
"People say 'everyone is different' and 'everyone has their own strengths,' but when it comes down to it, there are only certain qualities they actually value."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"My bad. I ended up rambling."
Nozomi Anesaki
"No, not at all…"

It wasn't that I didn't understand.
If anything, his words were something I could deeply relate to.
But I didn't know how to respond.
Hozumi-san was different from me.
He had probably already taken the step forward I couldn't.
I envied him a little bit.

Hozumi Hoshina
"...Anyway, it sure is hot today."

Hozumi-san spoke in his usual casual tone, as if trying to dispel the gloom that had settled between us.
I also put my feelings aside and decided to play along.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Are you thirsty?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Yeah, I'm parched. I really want a soda."
Nozomi Anesaki
"There's a vending machine up ahead. Let's stop for a second."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Okay."

Chapter 20: Photoshoot

He stopped the bicycle in front of a vending machine and we decided to take a short break.
Hozumi-san silently drank his soda.
...Hmm... If only he kept quiet like this, he'd be a flawless prince…

Hozumi Hoshina
"Why the hell are you staring at me?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"No reason."

Yeah, once he opens his mouth, the image falls apart.

???
"U-um…"

Suddenly, a timid voice spoke up from beside me.
I looked over and saw two middle school girls standing there, nervously holding their phones.
They kept casting excited glances at Hozumi-san.

Middle school girl
"U-um, excuse me... would it be okay if we took a picture of you...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh?"

A picture of me?
I was taken aback, but the girls were clearly looking only at Hozumi-san.
...That explains it. They want a picture of Hozumi-san, not me. Still, that's amazing... I guess this sort of thing happens when you're a handsome guy.
Curious about what Hozumi-san would say, I looked over to see his reaction.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Huuh?"

...Business as usual.

Middle school girl
"Uh… ah… um…"

The girls flinched and shrank back when Hozumi-san glared at them.
Looks like two more people were fooled by his looks.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Hozumi-san."
Hozumi Hoshina
"What?"
Nozomi Anesaki

"Let them take a picture."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Why?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"They're not going to use it for anything bad... right?"

I looked over at the girls for confirmation, and they both nodded eagerly.

Middle school girl
"Y-yes, of course not! We just want to keep it to look at...!"
Middle school girl
"B-because you're so handsome... we'd really appreciate it...!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Well then, just this once!"
Hozumi Hoshina
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Well?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"...*Sigh*..."

Hozumi-san put on an exaggerated sigh, but still stood there without protest. I took that as agreement.
I encouraged the hesitant girls to go ahead.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Seems like he's okay with it, so go ahead and take your pictures."
Middle school girls
"Y-yes!"

The girls lifted their phones.

Hozumi Hoshina
"...Hey."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hm?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Why are you taking a picture too?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Well... with the way things were going, I thought I might as well join in."
Hozumi Hoshina
"What kind of logic is that?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Come on, come on... Smile for the picture!"
Hozumi Hoshina
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"You're not smiling at all... and besides, look at the camera."

Hozumi Hoshina
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Don't glare at me."
Hozumi Hoshina
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Stay awake."
Hozumi Hoshina
"What the hell?! You're so annoying."
Nozomi Anesaki
"What's one plus one?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Window!"
Nozomi・Middle school girls
"Aw…"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Looks like you got the picture, so we're done, right?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"No... yeah, this one won't do."
Middle school girl
"You're right... this is a little..."
Middle school girl
"It does have a certain intensity, though..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah, a smile would be definitely better."
Middle school girl
"I agree…"
Middle school girl
"A handsome face is even better with a smile..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"All right, then, one more time!"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Man, this is seriously a pain in the ass..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"If you want this to be over quickly, then smile. One plus one is 'ni', right? Why would you say 'window'? Are you an elementary school kid or something?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Weeeell, what is 1 plus 1?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Niiii?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki

"Niiii? Niiii?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Niiii!!!"
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Bwah!"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Hahahahahaha!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"!!! Now!!!"
Nozomi・Middle school girls
"Oooh."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Is this good enough?"
Middle school girl
"It's amazing."
Middle school girl
"He's a legendary-tier hottie."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...We're done, right?"
Middle school girls
"Yes, thank you very much!"

The girls left, giggling and chattering excitedly.

Nozomi Anesaki
"See? You can do it when you try."
Hozumi Hoshina
"It's because you made me laugh."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I wish you always had this expression."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Why would I smile when I'm not enjoying myself? It'd just wear me out."

That's true, but…

Nozomi Anesaki
"I really like seeing you smile like this, Hozumi-san."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Because it reminds you of Mizuho?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I'm afraid not. Senpai's smile is way more princely."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...I see."

Senpai and Hozumi-san may look exactly alike, but they're actually quite different.

Hozumi-san's smile isn't the kind that makes your heart skip a beat, but I like it because it's so him.
If only he smiled like this all the time…

Hozumi Hoshina
"By the way."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hm?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Your smile is pretty creepy, you know. Especially that one."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."

Yeah, never mind. I don't need your smile or anything. Just keep quiet.

Chapter 21: Valued qualities

I had finished my homework for tomorrow's classes, and normally I would be immersed in an otome game at this hour.
But instead I was struggling through the mystery novel I borrowed from Hozumi-san.

Nozomi Anesaki
"..."

Grrr…
I'd only read 10 pages so far, but the language was so difficult I was already feeling discouraged…
Given that I consistently rank at the top in modern Japanese, it's a little upsetting that I'm struggling this much to get through it.
I couldn't help but admire Senpai's incredibly powerful brain for being able to enjoy a book like this. I don't think I have any chance of keeping up.
Maybe I should just look up the plot summary and the ending online…
I almost reached for my laptop, but I withdrew my hand, clinging to the scraps of pride I had left.
Since it's something Senpai loves, I want to be able to love it too. I want us to have something in common that we can talk about. I want to have fun conversations with him.
I somehow worked up the motivation to keep going and turned the page of the novel again.
An hour later, I finished one of the chapters and closed the book.
I think I managed to read about a third of it. For me, that was quite an achievement.
I'm tired, so I'll read the rest tomorrow.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Phew…"

I sprawled out on my back on the bed and slowly exhaled.
...Another reason I had trouble getting through the book was that I just couldn't focus.

Hozumi Hoshina
"People say 'everyone is different' and 'everyone has their own strengths,' but when it comes down to it, there are only certain qualities they actually value."

The words Hozumi-san said in an unusually dejected tone lingered with me, like a small fish bone caught in the back of my throat.
It felt like something that had been weighing on my heart ever since I started becoming aware of my feelings for Senpai had suddenly been stirred up.
This won't do... I'm getting depressed.
When I feel like this, I play a game to lift my spirits.
I booted up the game and replayed my favorite events.
As I looked at Lord Wald's face, my cheeks naturally began to relax into a smile...
But then the realization hit me…

Nozomi Anesaki
"*Sigh*..."

And I suddenly lost all interest.
I quickly closed the lid and returned the console to my bedside.
...I've known for a long time that neither these kinds of games
nor the fact that I enjoy them
are things people would accept.

Chapter 22: Cloudy, followed by rain

By the time homeroom was over, the sky was slowly becoming overcast.
I didn't bring an umbrella with me today. Hopefully it won't start raining until after the student council meeting is finished…
Hozumi-san's face suddenly flashed through my mind.
Come to think of it, for the past few days he's been giving me rides back and forth even though we never made any arrangements prior. I wonder if he'll come again today.
If he ended up waiting for me because he didn't know I had a student council meeting, I'd feel terrible.
I don't have Hozumi-san's phone number, though... Maybe I should ask Hoshina-senpai to let him know.
When I arrived at the student council room, Hoshina-senpai was already working by himself.
Apparently, the treasurer and secretary still hadn't arrived.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Hello."
Mizuho Hoshina
"Ah, Anesaki-san. I'm glad you came."
Nozomi Anesaki
"? Did something happen?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"Actually, the treasurer and the secretary can't make it to the student council meeting today either."

Nozomi Anesaki
"Oh, are they feeling unwell?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"No, they have make-up classes today. They are both taking this subject."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I see…"

It's just me and Senpai again, huh... Part of me was happy, but another part of me was so nervous I didn't know what to do. I was torn.

Mizuho Hoshina
"But we don't have much work today, so I think we'll be able to finish it quickly. Anesaki-san, please take care of the journal as usual."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes, understood. U-um…"
Mizuho Hoshina
"Hm?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I'm worried that Hozumi-san might come to pick me up, so would you mind letting him know that he doesn't need to wait for me today?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"Oh, yeah. I'll take care of it."

Senpai immediately took out his phone and started calling Hozumi-san.

Mizuho Hoshina
"...Ah, hello-hello? Where are you now?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"Ah... so you really were waiting. We have student council meeting today, so Anesaki-san asked me to tell you to head home."
Mizuho Hoshina
"Yeah. ...Hmm? Anesaki-san? She's here."
Mizuho Hoshina
"Uh? Okay, I guess..."

Senpai pulled the phone away from his ear and held it out to me.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"Hozumi said he wanted to talk to you."
Nozomi Anesaki
"*Sigh*..."

…What does he want?
I took the phone and put it to my ear.
Since Hoshina-senpai was here, I had to watch how I talk. I picked up the phone and spoke more formally than usual.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Yes, hello-hello?"
Hozumi Hoshina
“What is 1+1?”
Nozomi Anesaki
"Niiii."

……
The call ended.
...Huh... What was that just now...?
Oh no, I just made a really stupid face in front of Senpai...!

Mizuho Hoshina
"Pfft...!"

Even worse, he found it funny.

Mizuho Hoshina
"What...? What did Hozumi say?"
Nozomi Anesaki
" 'What is 1 plus 1?'..."
Mizuho Hoshina
"Ha... haha, so that's why you answered 'ni'...! Hahaha!"

Gaaaaaaaahhh, this is so embarrassing...! Hozumi Hoshina...! Just you wait!!!

Mizuho Hoshina
"Haha, wow, that was hilarious."

…Oh well.

Mizuho Hoshina
"...Well, now that we've had our laugh, let's get this work done."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ahaha... yeah, of course..."

I think that actually helped me relax a lot. I'll give him credit for that, at least…
We finished the student council duties earlier than usual today.
Unfortunately, the rain started pouring down while I was preparing to go home.

Mizuho Hoshina
"Ah... it really did start raining..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...I didn't bring an umbrella..."
Mizuho Hoshina
"Oh, I see. ...Ah, then do you want to share mine?"
Nozomi Anesaki

"Huh?!"
Mizuho Hoshina
"Anesaki-san, you're on crutches, after all. I'll walk you home."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uhhhh…"

That's... what they call the classic "sharing an umbrella" romantic trope, isn't it...? I-is this really okay? Is it all right for us to do something like this...?

Nozomi Anesaki
"B-but I don't want to trouble you..."

For some reason, I couldn't bring myself to simply say "yes, please," and backed away a step.
No, I really am happy... I am happy about this, aren't I...?
A strange feeling of guilt lingered inside me, though I couldn't say what it stemmed from.

Mizuho Hoshina
"You're not troubling me whatsoever. ...Ah, unless you'd rather not..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh?! No, no, no, no, of course I don't mind…!"
Mizuho Hoshina
"Then let's head home before the rain gets any heavier."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Y-yes, please..."

And so, here I am.
Right now, I'm sharing an umbrella with Senpai, but...

Mizuho Hoshina
"Anesaki-san, are you okay? Am I fully covering you?"

Senpai tilted the umbrella and moved closer to me. Wh-whoa... he's so, so close...!

Nozomi Anesaki
"I-I'm fine...! More importantly, Senpai, now you're not fully covering yourself...!"
Mizuho Hoshina
"Don't worry, I'm fine. ...Wait, Anesaki-san, you're outside the umbrella again."

It seemed I had unconsciously moved away from him. Senpai smiled wryly and moved closer again to make up for the distance.
The truth is, we've been going through this same thing over and over for a while now.
I really appreciated Senpai's thoughtfulness, but for some reason, I couldn't relax.
The way I walk, where I put my arm, the way I carry myself... I end up worrying about every little thing, and it's kind of exhausting.

Mizuho Hoshina

"Looks like the rain is going to get heavier from here. I'm glad we were able to finish our student council tasks early."
Nozomi Anesaki
"That's true. I'm grateful for how quickly you always get your work done, Senpai."
Mizuho Hoshina
"No, I should be the one saying that."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"You always handle whatever I ask you to do right away, and you never make any mistakes. That's what lets me concentrate on my own responsibilities."
Nozomi Anesaki
"N-no, not at all…"
Mizuho Hoshina
"The teachers and my friends are always saying how capable you are, Anesaki-san. And I totally agree with them."
Nozomi Anesaki
"No... really... that's not true at all..."
Mizuho Hoshina
"Ahaha, don't be so modest."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."

I'm happy whenever Senpai praises me.
But each and every word from Senpai presses down on me with a heavy weight.
I feel like he's giving me way too much credit…
I'm not just downplaying myself. From Senpai's point of view, I'm a person who lives up to that praise.
But this is not… who I really am.
The things people commend me for don't come from genuine kindness.
Unlike Senpai, everything I do is calculated.
But he probably didn't doubt me for even a moment.
He must believe we're the same.
And I found that difficult to bear.

Mizuho・Nozomi
"..."

A silence followed.
Whether during student council meetings or outside of them, we never really had casual conversations.
We either talked about student council business or briefly drifted off-topic before circling back to it.
I don't think we've ever had a conversation where we really got to know each other.
If I were to start dating Senpai, would anything change?
Or would things always be like this?
...If someone asked me whether I was enjoying myself, I don't think I could honestly say yes.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Um…!"

I gathered my courage and finally spoke up. If things don't feel fun, then it's up to me to make them that way.
I have to get us talking about something we both enjoy...!

Nozomi Anesaki
"S-Senpai... do you like reading...?"

I'll start with a small icebreaker.

Mizuho Hoshina
"Reading? Yeah, I read a lot. It's my favorite hobby."

...Good. That was the answer I expected.

Mizuho Hoshina
"Are you into reading too, Anesaki-san?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh? Um… y-yes, a little..."
Mizuho Hoshina
"Really? What genre do you prefer?"

Light novels.
...I can't say that. Since my goal is to make Senpai like me more, there's only one answer I can give.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Lately... I've been getting into mystery novels..."
Mizuho Hoshina
"Oh, awesome! I read mystery novels a lot too."

Oh, Senpai's getting excited. I'd like to keep the conversation going from here, but…

Mizuho Hoshina
"There are all kinds of mystery novels. Which ones do you like? Do you have any favorite authors?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh... well... I only just started reading them recently, so... I'm not knowledgeable about them or anything..."

I felt pathetic that this was the only kind of answer I could give. I was completely unprepared. I should've put more effort into reading yesterday…

Mizuho Hoshina
"I see. What are you reading now?"
Nozomi Anesaki

"Um... I'm reading 'The Dining Table at 1 AM.' "
Mizuho Hoshina
"! That's great! This is actually my favorite book."

Senpai got even more excited. I think this might be the first time I've seen him look so genuinely happy.
Having a shared topic really does make things better. I'm glad I borrowed that book from Hozumi-san.

Mizuho Hoshina
"I love how, in the latter half, the tricks are slowly revealed little by little. But just when you think you've solved everything, there's another twist at the very–"
Mizuho Hoshina
"...Wait, you haven't finished reading it yet, have you?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Y-yes... I've only read about a third of it so far..."
Mizuho Hoshina
"You're just about to reach the exciting part. Even up to that point, though, it's packed with little bits of foreshadowing that make it such an engaging read."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...I-I see…"

Oh no... I didn't notice any of the foreshadowing at all…

Mizuho Hoshina
"I'm really glad you're reading this book, Anesaki-san. I rarely come across anyone who's read it."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Really?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"Yeah. I think Shizune is the only person I know who's read it."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh...Shizune-san has read it too...?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"Shizune likes mystery novels too. She's read quite a few of them. And among those, she says this book is one of her favorites."

W-wait, what...? Shizune-san is a mystery novel fan too...?
Just how many things do they have in common...? They're such a perfect match that I'm starting to get jealous…

Mizuho Hoshina
"...Oh, that reminds me. Next weekend, how about we watch a movie?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Y-yes... that sounds good. What would you like to watch?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"Apparently, another novel by the author of 'The Dining Table at 1 AM' was made into a live-action movie, and it's playing in theaters right now."

Mizuho Hoshina
"I like that one too, and I've been wanting to see it. If you're interested, would you like to go together, Anesaki-san?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes...! I think that sounds great...!"

I have no problem with that at all. I should go along with what Senpai likes.

Mizuho Hoshina
"I'm looking forward to it."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Me too…!"

I have to study up so I can enjoy it together with Senpai.

Chapter 23: Doubt

After that, Senpai and I continued our conversation about mystery novels.
...Though, to be honest, I was mostly just nodding to his words and hardly understood half of what we were talking about.
Even though my part in the conversation felt rather shallow, it was the first time I'd had such an enjoyable chat with Senpai, and I was honestly happy about it.
I felt like I'd narrowed the distance between Senpai and me, even if only a little.
Still, something was weighing on my mind.

Mizuho Hoshina
"...Hm?"

Suddenly, Senpai fell silent and stopped walking.

Nozomi Anesaki
"? What's wrong?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"...Wait, hold on... Is that Hozumi and Shizune?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh?"

I looked in the same direction as Senpai.
Hozumi-san and Shizune-san were talking just outside the entrance to the park.
Hozumi-san sat on his bicycle, not even bothering with an umbrella.
Shizune-san was angling her umbrella toward Hozumi-san to keep the rain off him.

Mizuho Hoshina
"...What are they up to?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...I wonder..."

We walked over to Hozumi-san and Shizune-san, wondering what was going on.
Once we reached a point where we could clearly hear the two of them talking, Senpai and I both instinctively stopped walking.
I could feel the awkward tension hanging between them.

Hozumi Hoshina
"...So it's none of your business."

Hozumi-san said that in a sharp voice, then placed his foot on the bicycle pedal.
Shizune-san stepped forward, trying to stop him from leaving.

Shizune Hiiragi
"W-wait, please...! At least let me treat your injury...!"
Hozumi Hoshina
"I told you, I don't need it."
Shizune Hiiragi
"Besides, if you keep getting soaked like that, you'll catch a cold...!"
Hozumi Hoshina
"I'm fine. Seriously, this has nothing to do with you. Stop getting involved in my problems."
Shizune Hiiragi
"Wh-why are you saying such horrible things...?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"..."
Shizune Hiiragi
"Did I... do something to upset you, Hozumi-kun...?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"..."
Shizune Hiiragi
"You used to be so kind... I loved spending time with you..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"..."
Shizune Hiiragi
"...That's why I... Back then... Hozumi-kun, I really..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Shut up."

Hozumi-san coldly cut her off.
Looking stunned, Shizune-san fell silent as tears gradually welled up in her eyes.

Shizune Hiiragi
"...Th-that's cruel..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"..."
Shizune Hiiragi
"I... I don't like the person you've become...!"
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Whatever."

Hozumi-san scoffed and tightened his grip on the bicycle handlebars.

Hozumi Hoshina
"I'm the same person I've always been."

Hozumi-san swung his bicycle around, the tires scraping against the pavement.
When Hozumi-san pushed off the ground and began riding forward, he ended up coming face-to-face with us.

Hozumi Hoshina
"...!"

The moment our eyes met, Hozumi-san froze in place.
There was a faint trace of blood at the corner of Hozumi-san's mouth. His left arm had a few scrapes on it as well.
...I wonder what happened.
Unable to find the words to say, I remained silent. Hozumi-san responded with a cynical laugh.

Hozumi Hoshina
"...Well, aren't you two close."
Mizuho Hoshina
"Hold on, Hozumi."

With an unusually serious look on his face, Senpai stepped toward Hozumi-san.
He took the umbrella with him, letting the rain fall on me. I was rooted to the spot.

Mizuho Hoshina
"Why would you say something like that?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"...I only said what I honestly felt."
Mizuho Hoshina
"Go apologize to Shizune right now."
Hozumi Hoshina
"I don't have anything to apologize for."
Mizuho Hoshina
"...Why...? Didn't you also..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Tch."

Hozumi-san clicked his tongue in irritation and forcefully pushed down on the pedal, as if taking his anger out on it.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Every single one of you has fucking lost your mind."

Hozumi-san spat the words out under his breath and began riding his bicycle again.
Our eyes met for just a second as he passed by.

But Hozumi-san only slightly furrowed his brow and quickly left without saying a word.

Mizuho Hoshina
"...Good grief..."

Hoshina-senpai sighed. He sounded completely worn out.
Then, as if he'd just remembered I was there, he moved the umbrella back over me.

Mizuho Hoshina
"Sorry...! You got wet…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...N-no, it's not important right now…"

I turned around again.

Shizune Hiiragi
"..."

At some point, Shizune-san had quietly come to stand beside us.
She looked at us in surprise, tears still welling in her eyes.
Current situation:
Shizune-san: heartbroken. Hoshina-senpai and I: sharing an umbrella.

Mizuho・Shizune・Nozomi
"..."

Ah... this is... unbelievable…
It was so awkward that I could barely stand it. Or rather, this was exactly the kind of situation where people were bound to get the wrong idea...

Shizune Hiiragi
"..."

Shizune-san looked down and ran past us.

Mizuho Hoshina
"Shizune…!"

Senpai looked back with a panicked expression.
I quickly slipped out from under Senpai's umbrella.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Um...! I'll be fine on my own from here."
Mizuho Hoshina
"Huh…? No, I can't let you do that. The rain is getting heavier..."

Senpai moved the umbrella toward me again, but I retreated another step.

Nozomi Anesaki
"No, I'll be fine... You should go after Shizune-san instead."
Mizuho Hoshina
"But..."

Senpai looked conflicted. ...He really is a kind person through and through.
I couldn't say for certain what Senpai was feeling.
But I could sense that Shizune-san was on his mind, and at this moment, I wanted him to put her before me.

Nozomi Anesaki
"I'll take shelter from the rain and ask my brother to come get me."

If I put it this way, Senpai will probably agree.

Mizuho Hoshina
"...Really…?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes. Thank you for walking me this far. I'll see you on Monday."
Mizuho Hoshina
"...Okay, got it. Make sure you don't catch a cold, okay?"

A look of relief crossed Senpai's face, and he hurried after Shizune-san.
...Well, then.
I've already gotten pretty wet, so taking shelter from the rain now feels a little pointless.
I resigned myself to getting drenched and started heading straight home, when I suddenly remembered the shortcut I took yesterday.
The path was definitely in rough condition, but the sooner I got home, the better.
The moment I strayed from the regular route and stepped onto the shortcut, Hozumi-san's image surfaced in my mind.
I wonder what he is up to... He looked injured... I hope he's okay.
And also…

Shizune Hiiragi
"...That's why I... Back then... Hozumi-kun, I really..."
Mizuho Hoshina
"...Why...? Didn't you also..."

It was easy enough to infer that the word left unspoken by both of them was "like."
I wonder if Hozumi-san and Shizune-san have feelings for each other...
…No.
Shizune-san said "back then," so I guess it's all in the past.
Thinking back on everything Shizune-san has done so far, there's no doubt that the person she likes is Hoshina-senpai.
But what about Hozumi-san?
Is he in love with her?
...It wouldn't be that surprising. Anyone would fall for a childhood friend like her.

Perhaps Hozumi-san's harsh treatment of Shizune-san was merely the other side of his feelings for her.
Considering how poor he is at expressing himself, it does seem possible.
Wait...
Could it be that the reason Hozumi-san wants Senpai and me to get together is because he doesn't want to lose Shizune-san to him?
Was he trying to get Shizune-san to look his way again by pushing Senpai and me together…?
...That could be possible too. His claim that he was simply "rooting for me" had always seemed a little suspicious.
If that were true...
...I don't think I could be mad about it.
Whatever Hozumi-san's motives may have been, my feelings for Senpai remain the same.
If anything, Hozumi-san's encouragement gave me the push I needed to be more proactive and helped me grow closer to Senpai.
You could say that our goals happened to coincide.
But for some reason...
I couldn't shake this uneasy feeling.
A strange, inexplicable restlessness nagged at me as I made my way down the rain-soaked, muddy path.
With the crutches so prone to slipping, I had to take each step with extra care.
Maybe I should've just taken the regular road home after all…
And then I happened to look up.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Uh…"

A silhouette appeared in front of me, and I stopped walking.
…It turned out to be Hozumi-san.
Beneath the eaves of the abandoned house, he stood leaning against the wall, staring blankly into space. Is he waiting out the rain?

Nozomi Anesaki
"..."

A vague sense of unease continued to grow as I started moving forward again on my crutches.

Hozumi Hoshina
"...!"

It wasn't until I was only a few meters away from him that Hozumi-san finally noticed me.
I stopped for a moment, then took a step toward him.

Hozumi Hoshina
"...Why are you here?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I should be asking you that."

Hozumi Hoshina
"...Weren't you sharing an umbrella with Mizuho?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I asked Senpai to walk Shizune-san home."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...You're the type who always leaves things half-finished, aren't you?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"That's rude. I always make sure things go according to plan."

I always make a save before any important decision.

Hozumi Hoshina
"According to plan, huh..."

Hozumi-san echoed my words, as if they carried some hidden meaning. It really seemed like there was something on his mind.
...So, what now? Should I just ask him outright...?

Nozomi Anesaki
"Hey."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Hm?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh…"
Hozumi Hoshina
"...What?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Um... how did you get hurt?"

I didn't know why, but I couldn't bring myself to ask what I truly wanted to know, so I quickly moved on to another question.
Blood was still oozing from the injury at the corner of Hozumi-san's mouth and the scrape on his arm.

Hozumi Hoshina
"...It's none of your business."

He coldly turned away from me.
It was just what I expected from him, but it still left a nagging feeling in my chest.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Well... I guess that's true..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"..."

Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...What do you want?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Do you need something from me?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...No… Not really…"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Then get going already."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh…"

Am I bothering him…?
...It's not like I have any real reason to stay. But somehow, I don't feel like leaving just yet.
When I refused to move, Hozumi-san quietly clicked his tongue.

Hozumi Hoshina
"I'm in a bad mood right now."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Well... I can tell."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Then take a hint."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Am I not allowed to take shelter from the rain? I just want to wait until it calms down a bit."
Hozumi Hoshina
"But you've been standing in the rain this whole time."

…Well, that's true.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Then can I take shelter under there with you?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"No."
Nozomi Anesaki
"What is that supposed to mean...? It's not like this is your private property."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Just get out of here. Go home."

Good grief. He's older than me, yet he's being so childish.
Maybe this was why... I just couldn't bring myself to leave him alone.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Fine. I'll go home."

Seems like I shouldn't pry any further. I turned around and took a step forward.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Gah!"

And then I tripped.
My crutch slipped on the wet ground.

Hozumi・Nozomi
"..."

Despite the rain, the air somehow felt dry as I slowly got back to my feet.
Thankfully, all I got was a minor scrape on my knee. However, the mud smeared across my uniform left me in a rather pitiful state.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Are you… an idiot? Or some kind of pervert?"

As if that wasn't bad enough, I wound up showing him my panties twice.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Hmph..."

I felt like getting embarrassed would mean admitting defeat, so I brushed off my skirt with a smug grin.

Hozumi Hoshina
"*Sigh*..."

Hozumi-san gave me a pained look and raised the kickstand of the bicycle he left under the eaves.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Get on."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"You'll just fall again. It's honestly painful to watch."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...What? You were acting all cold and hostile just a moment ago."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Seeing your ass kind of killed the mood."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Could you stop wording things like that? It sounds really misleading."

I got on the bike as we exchanged meaningless banter.
When I wrapped my arms around Hozumi-san's waist, it felt damp and sticky.

Nozomi Anesaki

"...Gross..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"I'm gonna throw you off."

Chapter 24: An incident

We arrived at my place without saying much of anything.
The rain showed no sign of letting up; if anything, it was coming down even harder.
Once I was off the bicycle, I wavered for a moment before turning back to Hozumi-san.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Hozumi-san, are you going home now?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Hmm... Well, I'll figure it out."

His answer was vague. Was he planning to kill time somewhere else?

Nozomi Anesaki
"Um... why don't you take shelter from the rain at my place?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Huh?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"The rain is pretty intense. Maybe you should wait until it calms down a bit?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Ah… No, I'll pass."

Again, he wasn't being very forthcoming.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Is there some reason you're hesitating?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"It's not that I'm hesitating... I'm just worried about what might happen to me..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Why are you, of all people, wary of me?"
Hozumi Hoshina
" 'Cause you're a pervert."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Idiot."

Even amid this pointless banter, I had a pretty good idea what Hozumi-san was thinking.
He wanted to be left alone.
We hadn't exchanged a word on the way here because Hozumi-san stubbornly refused to talk to me.

Nozomi Anesaki
"I'm not going to ask what happened. I won't pry."
Hozumi Hoshina

"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"You don't have to say anything at all if you don't want to."
Hozumi Hoshina
"..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...All right. I'll take you up on that."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I'm home."

……
Huh? No response. It looks like Shun isn't home yet.
He is probably at a friend's place or somewhere like that. He is often out like this.

Hozumi Hoshina
"...Thank you for inviting me."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Wait here a moment. I'll bring you a towel."

I returned to the front door with a bath towel and some clean clothes.
When I handed them to him, Hozumi-san looked bewildered.

Nozomi Anesaki
"First of all, dry yourself off. And change into those clothes."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...It's okay... I don't need to change."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Are you uncomfortable with that? My brother doesn't wear these anymore, so you don't need to worry."

Hozumi-san is taller than Shun, but they should still be wearable.

Hozumi Hoshina
"...Sorry about all the trouble."

Hozumi-san wiped himself down with the bath towel, removed his shoes, and entered the house. He seemed a little awkward, as if he didn't know what to do with himself.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Should I change clothes… here?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"You can use the changing room. I'll change in my room."

After guiding Hozumi-san to the changing room, I began changing in my own room.
Just as I had taken off my uniform and camisole, I heard some kind of noise coming from downstairs.

Shun Anesaki

"I'm home."

It sounded like Shun had come home.

Shun Anesaki
"...Huh? Is someone here? Sis? Are you there?"

Since Shun was calling out so loudly, I figured I should quickly get dressed and head downstairs.
I hurriedly dried my whole body with the bath towel, when…

Shun Anesaki
"UWAAAAAH!!!"

A terrifying scream rang out.
I froze and strained my ears. A moment later, Shun's panicked voice echoed through the house.

Shun Anesaki
"Wh-who the hell are you?! Why are you naked... no, wait, what are you doing in my house—"
Shun Anesaki
"Wh-where's my sister?! Sis!!! SIIIIIS!!!"

Heavy footsteps came rushing up the stairs.
This is bad. I've got a really bad feeling about this.
By the time I realized that, it was already too late.

Shun Anesaki
"Sis!!!"

Shun flung the door open and stormed in.
I didn't react quickly enough, so all I had to cover myself with was my underwear and a bath towel draped over my shoulders.

Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Shun・Nozomi
"UWAAAAAH!!!"

I screamed on instinct.
And then…

Hozumi Hoshina
"Hey, what—"

Hozumi-san poked his head out from behind Shun.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Whoa… cool."

...What's so cool about this?
Actually, that's not important right now!

Shun・Nozomi
"Get out!!!"

Shun grabbed hold of Hozumi-san.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Actually, that included you as well, Shun…"
Shun Anesaki
"Did you do it?! Did you actually do it?!"
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Yes."
Shun Anesaki
"Nooooo!!! It can't be trueeeee!!!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Can you just leave the room for now?"
Shun Anesaki
"Who the hell are you?! What's your relationship with my sister?!"
Hozumi Hoshina
"That's a good question... Who am I to her? I wonder."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Will you two just get out already?"
Shun Anesaki
"D-don't tell me you're her boyfriend?!"

...This is hopeless. This guy's completely lost it. He's not even listening.

Hozumi Hoshina
"...So what if I was? Got a problem with it?"

Hozumi-san was taking the joke too far.
Well, whatever... I'll quickly change while those two are busy talking.
Hiding behind the closet, I hurriedly slipped my arms through the sleeves of my T-shirt.

Shun Anesaki
"I'll never accept you as her boyfriend!!!"
Hozumi Hoshina
"I don't think you have any right to say that."
Shun Anesaki
"Sis... already has a boyfriend!!!"

Wait, what?

Hozumi Hoshina
"Huh...? Who?"
Shun Anesaki
"It's…"
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"...LORD WALD!!!"
Hozumi Hoshina
"...? …Who?"
Shun Anesaki
"He has a lean, muscular build and stands 181 cm tall while weighing 67 kg. His hobbies are horseback riding and fencing, and his skills in these are unmatched."
Shun Anesaki
"... with a tolerance wider than the universe, he continues to love Sis devotedly and faithfully—a super-ultra-handsome blond, blue-eyed dreamboat!!! Got it?!"
Shun Anesaki
"You...YOU THINK YOU CAN SURPASS LORD WALD?!"
Hozumi Hoshina
"..."

Shun was making a fool of himself.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Shun."

After I finished changing, I stepped in between the two of them.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Good job."

I patted him on the shoulder.

Shun Anesaki
"..."

Shun finally realized how badly he'd embarrassed himself and looked down, his face turning red.
I feel sorry for him, let's just leave him be.

Nozomi Anesaki
"You can leave now."

I gave Shun a gentle pat on the back and nudged him toward the door.

Nozomi Anesaki

"Phew…"

Once he was gone, the room suddenly became quiet.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Your brother is funny."
Nozomi Anesaki
"He's not usually this amusing."
Hozumi Hoshina
"By the way, what is this Lord Wald thing?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ah... don't worry about that. It's nothing important..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Hmm."

Hozumi-san stepped into the middle of the room and glanced around.
Come to think of it, I wasn't really prepared to have Hozumi-san in my room. I hope I don't have anything embarrassing lying around…
It's going to be okay... right...?
My otaku goods were hidden away in the dresser and closet, so…
…Hold on!
The game console… I'd left it out beside my bed...!
Naturally, WataPuri was the game I'd been playing.
I hadn't left the game running, had I...? The console was definitely off, right...?
...No, wait.
I think I'd simply closed the lid after playing last night and left it like that...
Don't tell me it's just sitting there in sleep mode...? That's a problem, right...?
Come to think of it, just having a game console lying around... isn't that already a bad look for me? Doesn't that go against the image I'm trying to maintain?

Hozumi Hoshina
"Oh."

Hozumi-san stopped, his expression suggesting he had noticed something.
His eyes were… fixed on the side of the bed.
He saw the game…!

Hozumi Hoshina
"Have you been reading the book I lent you?"

...Or so I assumed. Turns out, I was wrong.
Apparently, what had caught Hozumi-san's attention was the book beside the game console instead. Phew…

Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah, I have. I'm not very far into it yet, though."
Hozumi Hoshina
"How is it?"

Nozomi Anesaki
"Hmm... honestly, it's quite challenging..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Aah, I figured. I gave up on it halfway through too."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...But I'm going to finish reading them all the way through. Every book you lent me."
Hozumi Hoshina
"For real? Did you like it?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Well... I don't really get the appeal yet. But I want to learn to like the things Senpai likes... I mean, I just want us to have something in common..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Hmm..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Today, I got to have a really nice little conversation with him about mystery novels."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Still, I wasn't knowledgeable enough to fully participate in the conversation, so I thought I should read more."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Hmm…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"That's why I'm going to keep trying. I'll read them all the way to the end. Can I hold onto the books for a while longer?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"I guess that's fine..."

Hozumi-san fell silent, giving me an ambiguous look.

Nozomi Anesaki
"…What?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"...No, I was just thinking you're pretty determined."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Well, yeah..."

If I had hobbies that already lined up with Senpai's, like Shizune-san did, I wouldn't have to work this hard.
The reason I was this "determined" was because I didn't believe I could win by being myself. If I wanted to be liked by others, I had to become the kind of person they would like.

Hozumi Hoshina
"...I gotta say, you're pretty admirable."

Even though he was praising me, somehow, it didn't make me feel good.
Hozumi-san quickly looked away before turning his attention back to the bedside.

Hozumi Hoshina
"By the way… are you into games?"

Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh?!"

I didn't expect that.
I calmly nodded, trying not to let my inner panic show.

Nozomi Anesaki
"S-sort of…"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Huh... I wouldn't have guessed."

I thought so…

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Are you into games as well, Hozumi-san?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Yeah, to some extent."
Nozomi Anesaki
"What games do you usually play?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Things like fighting games."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ah... that makes sense."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...What was that supposed to mean? Then what kind of games do you play?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh… Um…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Stuff like brain-training games."

Of course I was lying. But Hozumi-san seemed to completely buy it.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Ah, yeah, I can totally see that. That's such a Sasajiin student thing."

He accepted my answer with a somewhat disinterested look.
Part of me was relieved, but I couldn't help feeling conflicted. Apparently, Hozumi-san thought I was the kind of person who played brain-training games.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Are these games fun?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh, well... they're interesting."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Oh? Let me try it."

Hozumi-san reached for the game console.

Nozomi Anesaki
"No!"

I involuntarily cried it out. Hozumi-san jolted in surprise.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Uh... Why?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...I-I don't think you'd find it very interesting, Hozumi-san...!"

It was something I blurted out without thinking; there was no deeper meaning behind it.
However, Hozumi-san seemed to take it the wrong way.

Hozumi Hoshina
"...What? Are you saying that I'm too dumb for them?"

Yes, exactly.
He had twisted my words so badly that I almost felt like saying that. Before I knew it, he'd grabbed the game console.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Uwaaah!!! Stop!!!"

The instant Hozumi-san opened the console's cover, I launched myself at him.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Whoa?!"

Hozumi-san fell down, while the game console was tossed onto the bed.
Unfortunately, it happened to land right where Hozumi-san could see it…
And then, to my utter disbelief, he flung the lid wide open without a care in the world, proudly revealing the screen.
And thus, Pandora's box was opened.
The game console, awakened from its sleep, revealed…

Wald
"I love you, Nozomi…"

……
Of all scenes, it had to be this one?!
It was my favorite part, but it was also the one I least wanted anyone else to see!!!
And to make matters worse, I'd actually changed the name settings!!! It was calling me by my real name!!!
This was humiliating!!! Absolutely humiliating!!!
I'm so sorry, Lord Wald...! I'm so embarrassed about you right now...!

Hozumi Hoshina
"..."

Hozumi-san looked completely stunned as he stared at the game.
After that, he slowly pointed toward the screen.

Hozumi Hoshina
"...Is this brain-training?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...It is."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Really?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Really."
Hozumi Hoshina
"There is no way."
Nozomi Anesaki
"No, it's true."
Hozumi Hoshina
"What part of this is supposed to train your brain?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...I-it's... training your imagination."
Hozumi Hoshina
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Seriously...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah…"
Hozumi Hoshina
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Is that pushing it?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"...It really is."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...It's an otoooome game!!!"

I shouted, completely resigned to my fate.
Whatever. It was Hozumi-san, and we'd already reached the point where I didn't need to keep up appearances around him.

Even if Hozumi-san ended up looking down on me, that would be okay... right?
It wouldn't matter if he came to dislike me... right?
……
No... actually, I don't want that...!

Hozumi Hoshina
"Otome game..."

Hozumi-san's face was tense with thought.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Wait, you're an otaku? Ew..."

I'm sure that's what he's thinking. Aah…

Hozumi Hoshina
"Do you like them?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Huh…?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"These kinds of games."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Uh… well… um… yes… I love them…"

I couldn't possibly bring myself to deny loving Lord Wald.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Seriously...? You're kinda pervy."
Nozomi Anesaki
"H-huh?! Why?!"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Well, that's a lewd game, isn't it?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Wha— It's not lewd! It's for all ages!!!"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Oh, really? Then let me give it a try."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh?!"

That's your reaction?!
While I stood there stunned by his response, Hozumi-san took the game console, looking genuinely intrigued.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Whoa, wait, wait, wait, no, you can't do that...!"

I hurriedly snatched the game console from Hozumi-san's hands.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Ah—hey, what are you doing?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"No! Don't touch it!"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Why? It's not a big deal."
Nozomi Anesaki
"It's not the kind of game you should be playing, Hozumi-san...!"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Why?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Why...? Because, for starters, you don't even know what kind of game this is..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"No, I more or less get it. It's one of those games where you seduce men, isn't it?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"You make it sound kind of bad... though technically, you're right..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"In that case, let me give it a shot."
Nozomi Anesaki
"No! Actually, why do you want to play it so badly?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Because it looks interesting."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I don't think you'd find it interesting."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Nah, it looks pretty interesting to me."

Hozumi-san was grinning. I knew it. This guy definitely intended to make fun of me.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Absolutely not."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Why though?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Because you'll make fun of me..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"I won't."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I can't really believe you when you say that while grinning like that."
Hozumi Hoshina
"No, seriously, I'm genuinely just interested."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...This game is Lord Wald's and my little love nest. If I let someone else see it, he'll be upset with me."
Hozumi Hoshina
"That's kind of cringe..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"See, I knew you'd make fun of me."

Hozumi Hoshina
"Damn it... you set me up..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I'm definitely not letting you play it."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Come on, just a little."
Nozomi Anesaki
"No!"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Just a little bit. Just let me do it for a little bit!"
Shun Anesaki
"What are you doing?!"

Suddenly, the door flew open, and Shun rushed into the room.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Ugh... It's this annoying guy again."

As Hozumi-san grumbled under his breath, I let out a relieved sigh.
Shun, you're a lifesaver. You showed up at exactly the right moment.

Shun Anesaki
"What the hell are you trying to do to her?!"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Wha...? Oh, that?"
Shun Anesaki
"Aaaaaaahhh!!! Noooooooooo!!!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Shun, calm down. Hozumi-san, quit teasing him."
Shun Anesaki
"Actually! How much longer are you planning to stay here?!"
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Until the rain stops?"
Shun Anesaki
"When will it stop?!"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Hey, how should I know?"
Shun Anesaki
"...!"

Shun gave me a desperate look.
You can look at me like that all you want, but I don't know when the rain's going to stop either.

Hozumi Hoshina
"I'll go home after I play an otome game."

And just like that, the topic I had finally managed to steer away from came right back around.

Shun Anesaki
"...Huh? Otome game?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"I've been asking her to let me play this whole time, but she won't give it to me."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Because you'll make fun of me."
Hozumi Hoshina
"I told you, I won't. I just want to see what it's like to make a guy fall for me."
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"Are you… a homo...?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Uh…"

Hozumi-san looked like he had suffered a critical hit.
I seized the chance and hid the game console away on the shelf.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Nice job, Shun."
Shun Anesaki
"Huh?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"You were pretty lame earlier, but this one was good."
Shun Anesaki
"Ah… Really?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Thank you. You can go now."
Shun Anesaki
"All right, I'll go make dinner."

With the satisfied look of someone who had just completed a mission, Shun confidently left the room.

Chapter 25: Those few words

...So, that's what happened.
Somehow, I'd managed to stop Hozumi-san from getting his hands on the otome game.
Unfortunately, there was no hiding the fact that I was an otaku anymore.

Hozumi Hoshina
"I've never actually met a female otaku before."

Unable to endure Hozumi-san's curious stare, I lowered my gaze.

Nozomi Anesaki

"D-don't tell... Anyone..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Huh?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Please don't tell Senpai that I'm an otaku... No matter what."

This was already the second time I'd asked Hozumi-san to keep something from Senpai.
I'd practically let him see the real me by now.

Hozumi Hoshina
"I'm not gonna say anything. I wouldn't get anything out of it anyway."

Hozumi-san's response was the same as always.
I was reassured by how little he seemed to care about it, yet I couldn't help wondering what he really thought of me.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Hozumi-san... What do you think of it...?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"About what?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Well... about my hobby..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"I don't think anything of it."
Nozomi Anesaki
"You're not put off by it? You don't think it's gross...?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Think about everything you've said and done. You've called me a 'shithead' more times than I can count. You really think I'd be put off by your hobby at this point?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh…"

...I guess that's true. He thought I was a "little shit" from the very beginning...

Hozumi Hoshina
"I'm actually surprised that you're worried about this stuff."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Because... other people are different from you..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"? Different?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...I mean, you said it yourself. 'There are only certain qualities people actually value.' "
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Aah."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Well... I think you're right."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...People would never accept neither my hobbies nor my actual personality."

People who are universally liked are probably people like Hoshina-senpai or Shizune-san...
Or someone like the "Nozomi Anesaki" I've created at school.
I've never once shown my true self to anyone.
They only like me because I pretend to be someone I'm not.
The truth is, I'm not some kind, considerate person. I'm calculating, self-absorbed, an otaku, crude, lazy, and disgusting. I'm not cute at all. I'm actually a little shit. That's the real me.
I know that hardly anyone would accept a person like this.
And I have proof of that.

Nozomi Anesaki
"In the past, nobody liked me at all."

When I was being my true self, I was completely alone.

Hozumi Hoshina
"..."

Hozumi-san just listened in silence.
I was a little surprised. I thought he'd just brush me off like he always did. I never knew he could look this serious.

Hozumi Hoshina
"So…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"So you want to be liked by everyone?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Of course."

It's only natural that I'd want as many people as possible to like me. Isn't that how everyone feels?

Hozumi Hoshina
"So that's why you're putting on an act?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Yeah."
Hozumi Hoshina
"…Eventually, it'll all start to feel pointless."

…He was right.
Whenever I was showered with praise at school, I felt a reassuring warmth in my chest, almost indistinguishable from a sense of superiority.
But at the same time, I couldn't deny that I was consumed by guilt and an overwhelming sense of emptiness that I had no way of releasing.

Nozomi Anesaki

"...But I don't have a choice."
Hozumi Hoshina
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"…Because if I don't do this, people won't like me."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Well, true, 'everyone' probably won't."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Forget about everyone. I don't think there's even a single person who would like me."
Hozumi Hoshina
"People have different tastes."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"You can't please everyone."
Hozumi Hoshina
"But there's bound to be at least one person who will like you."
Nozomi Anesaki
"…Even though I'm an otaku with a terrible personality?"

I couldn't help but scoff.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Yeah."

Hozumi-san nodded without hesitation.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Well, I…"
Hozumi Hoshina
"I don't hate you."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."

I was speechless.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Huh…?"

Hozumi-san seemed a little taken aback.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Why are you blushing...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh?! No, I'm not blushing."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Your face is red."
Nozomi Anesaki

"Not true!"

I hurriedly pressed my hands against my cheeks.
Now that he mentioned it, my face did feel a little warm. ...What is happening? This is so embarrassing.

Hozumi Hoshina
"…All I said was that I don't hate you."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I-I know…"
Hozumi Hoshina
"I never said I liked you or anything. ...Seriously, don't get the wrong idea."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I get it, I get it."

I answered in my usual prickly tone, but inside, I was practically floating.
Hearing Hozumi-san say, "I don't hate you"... it simply made me happy.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Ah... I think I'll go home now…"

Hozumi-san looked out the window.
The rain was still coming down hard.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Are you leaving already?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"...No... actually... forget it."
Hozumi・Nozomi
"..."

What is with this strange, awkward tension...?
Besides, Hozumi-san was acting so restless that it was making me feel unsettled too.

Hozumi Hoshina
"...Hey."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Wh-what?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Let me play the game."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh...? That again? I said no."
Hozumi Hoshina
"But I'm bored."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uhh... Ah, then let's treat your injury."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Huh, now? The bleeding's already stopped."

Nozomi Anesaki
"It's better to clean it with fresh water first. Stay here, I'll be right back."

I returned to the room carrying a towel dampened with water.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Sit down there."

When I pointed to the floor, Hozumi-san obediently followed my instruction.
I sat down in front of him and reached out to press the towel against the wound on his face.

Hozumi Hoshina
"...!"

Hozumi-san suddenly recoiled, as though he'd been shocked.
Before I could react, he snatched the towel right out of my hand.

Hozumi Hoshina
"...I can do it myself."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Really?"

Hozumi-san put a little distance between us and began wiping the wound with the towel.
He was wiping it rather roughly. I just hope he doesn't reopen the wound...

Hozumi Hoshina
"Ugh... I got blood on it."

...Just as I thought. The towel was already stained.

Nozomi Anesaki
"You can't just wipe it like that. You need to be gentler."
Hozumi Hoshina
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Leave the towel pressed against the wound for now."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Okay."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Really though... how did you get that wound?"

I asked without a second thought, but the moment the words left my mouth, I froze.
I'd promised him I wouldn't pry, hadn't I...?

Nozomi Anesaki
"Sorry. Just pretend you didn't hear that."

I hurriedly added that, but Hozumi-san only frowned and looked away.

After a few seconds of silence...

Hozumi Hoshina
"...My dad."

Hozumi-san muttered the words as if forcing them out.

Hozumi Hoshina
"...My dad hit me."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Ah… I see…"

I couldn't think of anything appropriate to say. I never expected him to actually tell me.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...So... you had an argument...?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ah, no... you don't have to talk if you don't want to..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Not exactly... That's not what happened..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...It'd just be me complaining. You'd probably get bored listening to it."

The moment he said that, I wanted to hear it even more. I slightly straightened my posture.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Then tell me."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...What? It's not like there's anything worthwhile in it."
Nozomi Anesaki
"But I think it would be worthwhile for you."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Huh?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"You know, when you vent to someone, it helps get things off your chest."

Earlier, I'd opened up to Hozumi-san about what had been weighing on me, and I'd felt much better afterward.
It wasn't like I was doing this to repay him, but I wanted to do something for Hozumi-san, too.
...Though, realistically, all I could do was listen.

Hozumi Hoshina

"..."

Hozumi-san seemed hesitant for a while, but eventually, he sighed and started speaking.

Hozumi Hoshina
"...It's not really a big deal or anything."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hm?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"After I talked to you on the phone today, I went back home for a bit."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Then my old man, who'd been away on a business trip, came home. We got into a bit of an argument."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Wait... out of nowhere?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"It's nothing new. My dad... well, both of my parents, really... they've always seen me as a burden."

I thought back to the argument between Hozumi-san and his mother at the Hoshina household the other day. He really did seem to have a difficult relationship with his parents.

Hozumi Hoshina
"...Mom must've told Dad all sorts of things about me. About my behavior, my grades, stuff like that. He'd been away from home for almost half a year, after all."
Hozumi Hoshina
"So when he came back today, he wouldn't let it go."
Hozumi Hoshina
"He must've been seriously pissed off, because he hit me. Really hard."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...That's it."

Hozumi-san finished speaking in a matter-of-fact tone, then pulled the towel away from the wound. The bleeding appeared to have stopped already.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Are your grades and behavior really that bad?"

Was Hozumi-san really doing something so wrong that his parents felt justified in hitting him?

Hozumi Hoshina
"...I've been late a few times."
Nozomi Anesaki
"That's it? You don't ditch school to mess around? Like secretly smoking?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Huh? Do I really come across like that...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"No, I was just curious."

Hozumi Hoshina
"I go to school, I attend my classes. …I've never done anything illegal, okay? Seriously."
Nozomi Anesaki
"What about your grades?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Nothing special. They're normal. Right around the middle... well, maybe a bit below average."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hmm..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...You were totally making fun of me just now, weren't you?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"No, I wasn't. I just... I started wondering whether it was really something you should have been scolded that harshly for..."

I couldn't see any major faults in Hozumi-san. What was it about him that his parents found so unacceptable?

Hozumi Hoshina
"It's because Mizuho is the standard my parents judge me by."

Hozumi-san gave a bitter, ironic smile. Somehow, those few words were enough for me to understand.
His parents probably didn't accept Hozumi-san for who he truly was.

Hozumi Hoshina
"...I mean, Mizuho really is incredible. And it's true that there isn't much about me that's worth praising."
Hozumi Hoshina
"I've accepted that."

Hozumi-san said it in a calm, emotionless voice, then threw the towel over to me.

Hozumi Hoshina
"That's the story behind the injury."

This probably wasn't a subject he wanted to dwell on. Hozumi-san smoothly brought the conversation to an end, leaving no room for further questions.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...What about the injury on your arm?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Ah... this one..."

Hozumi-san hesitated, struggling to find the words.

Nozomi Anesaki
"What happened...?"

Hozumi Hoshina
"...I lost control of my bike and scraped my arm against a wall."

……

Nozomi Anesaki
"That's so lame..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...See? This is why I didn't want to talk about it…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Still, I'm relieved it wasn't something someone else did to you."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Why?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh? Why, you ask...? Because I'd hate it if something like that happened to you."

Honestly, learning that he had been hit by his own dad was already pretty awful.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Hmm…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Just give me your arm for now. I'll clean that injury up too."
Hozumi Hoshina
"No... I'll do it myself."
Nozomi Anesaki
"You're way too rough, Hozumi-san. Let me do it."

When I forcibly pulled his arm toward me, Hozumi-san flinched again for a moment.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh...? Why are you so on guard? I'm not going to hurt you."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...I know. Just... get it over with."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Okay, okay... You really are unbelievably bossy..."

I gently held the towel against his wound.
Hozumi-san seemed tense for a while, but I could tell that he gradually began to relax.

Nozomi Anesaki
"By the way..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Hm?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I don't hate you either."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Actually... I like you quite a bit."

I didn't want to just repeat the same thing Hozumi-san had said, so I decided to reveal a little more of what I really felt.

Hozumi Hoshina
"...Huh…?"

Hozumi-san just stared at me, completely dumbfounded. I ignored his stunned expression and kept going, gently wiping his injury with the towel.

Nozomi Anesaki
"I think you have your own strengths, things that Senpai doesn't have."

This was my honest opinion.
Hozumi-san said that there wasn't much about him worth praising, but I didn't believe that at all.
He ate my leftover lunch, gave me rides to and from places, and subtly cheered me up when I needed it.
Even in the short time I'd known him, I'd already found so many good things about him.

Hozumi Hoshina
"..."

Hozumi-san didn't say anything.
I noticed his arm had gone tense again. Is he nervous...?

Nozomi Anesaki
"?"

I glanced up and looked at his face.

Hozumi Hoshina
"..."

O-oh... oh... this is... His face... is bright red...

Nozomi Anesaki
"H-hey... Hozumi-san..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Huh?!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"No, seriously... don't look so embarrassed..."

Now he's making me feel embarrassed as well.

Hozumi Hoshina
"...N-no, I'm not embarrassed...!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh, yeah, your face is totally red."

Besides, that line is a textbook tsundere character's way of hiding their embarrassment.

Nozomi Anesaki
"I did say I like you, but... uh... not in that way, okay? Don't misunderstand."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...I know that already..."

We both abruptly looked away.

Hozumi・Nozomi
"..."

...And just like that, the mood became awkward again.
Um... what should I do...? Is there anything I can talk about...?
……
Nothing comes to mind... This is awkward. I kind of wish Shun would show up again...

Hozumi Hoshina
"...Hey…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hm?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"You're hurting me a little…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh… Ah, sorry…!"

It seems I'd been scrubbing at his wound harder than I'd meant to.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Be a little gentler, will you?"
Shun Anesaki
"GENTLER WITH WHAT?!"

And right on cue, Shun appeared.

Hozumi Hoshina
"...You really never stop running around, do you…?"

Even though he said it with an exasperated tone, Hozumi-san seemed strangely relieved, his shoulders finally relaxing.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Shun, did you need something?"
Shun Anesaki
"Huh? Oh, right. I was just wondering if that guy was staying for dinner."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hozumi-san, what do you think? Want to stay and have dinner here?"

Hozumi Hoshina
"No... I'll head home."

Hozumi-san got to his feet, checking the view outside the window. At some point while we were talking, the rain had let up quite a bit.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...You will actually go home, right?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"I will, I will. ...I feel a lot better now."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...That's good."

If that's the case, then I'm glad. All I could do was listen to him, but... I hope it helped him, even a little.

Shun Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"Feel better...? What do you mean by that...?"
Hozumi･Nozomi
"..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Your brother must be happy I'm leaving..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah…"

It was 2 AM.
After reading nonstop for about four hours, I finally finished the first mystery novel.
It was pretty difficult, but I felt like the latter half was really interesting... or at least, I thought it was.
I wasn't sure if I'd been able to enjoy it the same way Hoshina-senpai did, but I was a little happy to feel like I'd gained another thing in common with him.
I still had three books I'd borrowed from Hozumi-san left to read.
I wonder if I can finish them all before my plans with Senpai next week if I keep reading every day.
Ah, that's right. I also have to read the novel that the movie we're going to watch is based on.
Maybe I'll go buy it at a bookstore tomorrow.

Nozomi Anesaki
"*Yawn*..."

Tomorrow's the weekend, but I've stayed up way later than I should have.
It's not good for my skin, so I should just go to sleep...
Actually, maybe I'll play a little.
Reading something outside my comfort zone took a toll on me, and right now I just want Lord Wald's smile to cheer me up.

I booted up the game and, like always, replayed my favorite scenes.

Wald
"I love you, Nozomi…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Heh... fuh..."

……
I knew this laugh was pretty creepy…
If anyone from school saw me like this, my popularity would hit rock bottom instantly.
But that was okay.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Well, I…"
Hozumi Hoshina
"I don't hate you."

There was one person who told me he didn't hate this side of me.
"I don't hate you" might sound like such an indifferent thing to say, but to me, those words felt warmer than all the "I like you"s I'd ever received from anyone else.

Chapter 26: Things in common

The following day, sometime after noon, I came to the shopping mall alone.
The pain from my sprained ankle had almost completely faded, so starting today, I no longer needed my crutches.
I headed straight for the bookstore and started searching for the book I was looking for.
As I entered the mystery novel section, I spotted two familiar figures from behind.
It was Hoshina-senpai and Shizune-san.
I instinctively ducked behind the neighboring shelf.
Well... I didn't really have a reason to hide.
I could have just walked up and greeted them.
Still… I just wasn't in the mood to see those two together. Not when I was the odd one out.

Shizune Hiiragi
"...How about this one?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"Ah, it's been getting a lot of attention lately, hasn't it?"

I could hear Senpai and Shizune-san's voices as they talked.
...And there I was, shamelessly eavesdropping.
I really am awful, aren't I...? But I couldn't help being curious...

Shizune Hiiragi
"Oh, right. I read the book you recommended to me, Mizuho-kun."
Mizuho Hoshina
"Oh, you did? How was it?"

Shizune Hiiragi
"It was really good. I liked its classic style."
Mizuho Hoshina
"I knew you'd like it, Shizune."
Shizune Hiiragi
"Speaking of this author, I feel like you'd actually like this series better, Mizuho-kun."
Mizuho Hoshina
"Huh... you can tell?"
Shizune Hiiragi
"Hehe, I thought so. You like trying to predict what's going to happen, don't you, Mizuho-kun? Stories with lots of red herrings are right up your alley."
Mizuho Hoshina
"Wow, you saw right through me... I'm kind of embarrassed..."
Shizune Hiiragi
"I want to be able to read the way you do too, Mizuho-kun."
Mizuho Hoshina
"Well... I think reading it straightforwardly is more enjoyable. The way I read is really tiring, you know."
Shizune Hiiragi
"Because everything starts to look like foreshadowing, right?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"I end up becoming suspicious of everything..."
Shizune Hiiragi
"Hehehe. You really are afflicted with it, aren't you?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"I really am."

I heard their gentle laughter.
No matter how you look at it, they're completely in their own world...
Reading just one of Senpai's favorite novels wasn't nearly enough for me to follow along with their conversation.
I envied how naturally Shizune-san could be herself and talk to him so easily.
...I wonder how much harder I'll have to try before I can stand where she does.

Shizune Hiiragi
"...Oh, so they're adapting this one into a movie."
Mizuho Hoshina
"Huh? You didn't know? I'm going to see it next week."
Shizune Hiiragi
"...By yourself?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"No, with Anesaki-san."
Nozomi Anesaki
"!"

My heart leapt for a moment at the sudden mention of my name.

Shizune Hiiragi

"...With Nozomi-san...?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"Apparently Anesaki-san has recently started reading mystery novels as well. I'm glad to have another acquaintance who enjoys them."
Shizune Hiiragi
"...I see…"

...Ahhh… Why do I feel so guilty...?
Shizune-san... For some reason, I feel sorry for her…
I almost feel like I should step out right now, bow, and tell them, "Please, you two should go see the movie together."
Because... that would make so much more sense...

Mizuho Hoshina
"Well... I think I'll go pay for this book now."
Shizune Hiiragi
"Ah, yes. Then I'll also..."

Oh no. I had a feeling the two of them were heading this way.
I hurriedly turned on my heel, when…

???
"Anesaki-san."

Suddenly, someone whispered into my ear.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Hiya?!"

I spun around on instinct.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh?!"

Hoshina-senpai?!
What?! Did he teleport?!

Mizuho Hoshina
"What a coincidence, meeting you here."

It was a bright, princely smile.
Hold on... Was it though...?
…Ah. I see.

Nozomi Anesaki
"It's you, Hozumi-san…"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Wait, you figured it out that quickly...?"

Looks like he was seriously trying to fool me. Too bad for him, his smile just radiates scumbag energy.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Hozumi-san, why are you wearing glasses today?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"I usually wear them on my days off."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hmm…"

So that's why Hozumi-san was wearing glasses when I first met him.
Seeing him like this reminded me once again just how much he looked like Senpai.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Anyway, what are you doing here?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"What about you, Hozumi-san? Did you come shopping with Senpai by any chance?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Huh?"

As Hozumi-san tilted his head in confusion, I sensed someone's presence behind us.

Mizuho Hoshina
"Oh? Hozumi and Anesaki-san…?"

I turned around and found Senpai and Shizune-san standing there with surprised expressions.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Ugh… Why are you even here…?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"I was about to ask you the same thing. ...Did you two come here together?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"N-no... we only just happened to run into each other just now..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Weren't you supposed to be at cram school? Are you skipping classes?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"My cram school doesn't start until three. I left home early to buy some study guides."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Hmm..."
Shizune Hiiragi
"...I... came here to do some shopping... and happened to run into Mizuho-kun..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"..."

…He remained silent. No comment, huh.
Actually, it seemed like he was deliberately ignoring Shizune-san.

Shizune Hiiragi
"..."

Ugh... that sad, disappointed expression… This is rough... I'm starting to feel like I should apologize...

Mizuho Hoshina
"Ah... what about you, Anesaki-san? Shopping?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Y-yes! I was going to buy a book..."
Mizuho Hoshina
"What book are you looking for?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uhh... the novel that the movie we're going to watch is based on..."
Mizuho Hoshina
"Oh, that one! If you want to read it, I can lend it to you."
Nozomi Anesaki
"No... I figured I might as well buy my own copy and read it."
Mizuho Hoshina
"I see. That book is over here."

Following Senpai's lead, I entered the mystery novel section.
I could feel the two people trailing behind us giving me an uncomfortable look.
I could understand Shizune-san's reason, but why was Hozumi-san looking at me like he held a grudge too?
I get that you're in a bad mood, but don't take it out on me...

Mizuho Hoshina
"Here. It's this book, right?"

Senpai handed me the book I came here for.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Thank you very much. I'll go pay for it, then."
Mizuho Hoshina
"Ah, wait. I'm buying a book too, so let's go together."

After saying that, Senpai turned to face Hozumi-san and Shizune-san.

Mizuho Hoshina
"Can you two wait for us here?"
Shizune Hiiragi
"Uhh…"
Hozumi Hoshina
"...What? Why the hell do I have to wait for you two?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"Just do as I say. ...Well then, Anesaki-san, let's go."

Nozomi Anesaki
"Y-yes…"
Hozumi・Shizune
"..."

Feeling the two of them glaring at me again, I followed after Senpai.

Mizuho Hoshina
"Listen…"

Senpai leaned down slightly and spoke to me in a quiet voice.

Mizuho Hoshina
"Anesaki-san, are you busy after this?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"No, not really...?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"Could I ask you a favor...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Favor...? What kind of favor?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"It's about Hozumi and Shizune..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"I want to get those two to make up."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Make up...?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"Things have been pretty awkward after what happened yesterday…"

I glanced back over my shoulder.
Both Hozumi-san and Shizune-san were silent, each facing in a different direction from the other.

Nozomi Anesaki
"You're right about that..."
Mizuho Hoshina
"I have cram school in about an hour. Could you help me get them to reconcile somehow before then?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I don't… mind helping, but..."

From what I've seen, Hozumi-san always treats Shizune-san coldly... So what would even count as them being "reconciled"?

Nozomi Anesaki
"Um... what exactly should I do...?"

Mizuho Hoshina
"...Hmm, well... I guess the first thing I'd like to do is get Hozumi to stop ignoring Shizune..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Isn't Hozumi-san always like that toward Shizune-san...?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"...He just can't bring himself to be honest. I don't think Hozumi's attitude reflects how he truly feels."

...I knew it.
So... Hozumi-san has feelings for her, then?
It wasn't like this came as a surprise, so... I didn't know why I felt this way.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...She doesn't actually hate him either, right...?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"No, that's not the case. She said those things yesterday, but the truth is, Shizune's also..."
Mizuho Hoshina
"...She also wants to get along with him, I'm certain."

For a moment, Senpai hesitated unnaturally.
What was he trying to say after "Shizune's also..."?
Could it be... that she was in love with Hozumi-san...?
But... I thought Shizune-san had feelings for Senpai...
...No, maybe it only seemed that way, and that wasn't actually how things were...?
If that was the case, then Hozumi-san and Shizune-san were in love with each other, I obviously liked Senpai, and assuming that he also had feelings for me...
Then everything would work out perfectly. Everyone would get a happy ending.
...But… Still... I couldn't shake this weird feeling.
For some reason, that conclusion didn't sit right with me.

Mizuho Hoshina
"Anyway, we should arrange things so they have no choice but to talk to each other whenever possible."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Understood."

After paying for my book, we returned to Hozumi-san and Shizune-san, only to find the two of them still standing there in awkward silence.

Mizuho Hoshina
"Sorry for the wait."
Shizune Hiiragi
"Ah... welcome back."
Hozumi Hoshina
"All right, I'm gonna leave then."
Mizuho Hoshina
"Hold on. Since we're all here anyway, why don't we go to a café or somewhere together?"
Hozumi Hoshina

"No."
Mizuho Hoshina
"Why? It's not like you have anywhere else to be, right?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"I'm going to the arcade."
Mizuho Hoshina
"Then let's all go together."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Huh? Why are you guys tagging along?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"Shizune, you're fine with that, right?"
Shizune Hiiragi
"Um... y-yes... I suppose I don't mind..."
Mizuho Hoshina
"How about you, Anesaki-san?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes. I'd like to come along too."
Hozumi Hoshina
"..."

Hozumi-san gave me a suspicious look. I ignored it and pretended not to notice.

Hozumi Hoshina
"...Just go without me."
Mizuho Hoshina
"No... the more people, the better. ...Right, Anesaki-san?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes. I'd be happy if you let us come along, Hozumi-san."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Suit yourself."

After Hozumi-san started walking, Senpai and I followed after him.
Looking somewhat confused, Shizune-san followed a short distance behind Senpai.
…Hmm…
This is hardly the kind of atmosphere where those two could actually talk. It also seemed that Shizune-san was deliberately keeping her distance from Hozumi-san...
I glanced at Senpai beside me, and he responded with a weary smile.

Mizuho Hoshina
"This is tough…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"They are standing way too far apart..."
Mizuho Hoshina
"Right..."

Then, all of a sudden, Hozumi-san turned around.

Hozumi Hoshina

"..."

I was met with a deadpan, accusing stare. He looked absolutely irritated.
Not knowing how to react, I simply looked away.
...Seriously... what have I gotten myself into…?

Chapter 27: At the arcade

Image:
Left: Sakuya from another TetraScope visual novel.
The 3rd day of every month is Crane Game Day—prizes are easier to win!

The moment we arrived at the arcade, the gloomy expression that had been clouding Shizune-san's face completely disappeared.
She stopped in front of one of the crane games and stared intently at the prize inside.
It was a cute little chick keychain, a character that was popular among girls right now.
I figured she was into stuff like this.

Nozomi Anesaki
"This is really cute."

When I spoke to her, Shizune-san nodded repeatedly, looking somewhat excited.

Shizune Hiiragi
"I really like it."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Do you want to get it?"
Shizune Hiiragi
"...Isn't this kind of thing difficult...? I've never tried it before."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I think this one should be fairly easy to win. How about giving it a try?"
Shizune Hiiragi
"Y-yeah... I'll give it my best shot...!"

Shizune-san took out a cute wallet and dropped a 100-yen coin into the game's coin slot.

Shizune Hiiragi
"To start... I press this button, correct?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"That's right. Use that button to move the crane sideways, and then use the button next to it to move it backward."
Shizune Hiiragi
"R-right... okay..."

Shizune-san gathered her courage and pressed the button. The crane arm began sliding to the side.

Shizune Hiiragi
"Ah."

Suddenly, Shizune-san let go of the button.

Shizune Hiiragi
"I overshot it..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Really? I think you can still get it, though."
Shizune Hiiragi
"I really want the pink one..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I see... That might be a bit tricky..."
Shizune Hiiragi
"I'll give it one more try...!"

Shizune-san inserted another coin.
The crane began to move. This time, it seemed like she managed to stop it in a pretty good position, but...

Shizune・Nozomi
"Ahh…"

Almost. The claw got a hold of the prize, but it slid off as it lifted it up.

Shizune Hiiragi
"As I thought... I can't do it after all."

Looking disappointed, Shizune-san tucked her wallet away.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Let me try."

I took my wallet out of my bag and swapped places with Shizune-san.
It was then, as I casually turned my gaze away...

Nozomi Anesaki
"!!!"

A shock went through my entire body.
The prize in the crane game beside us was none other than...
...a WataPuri figure!!!

Shizune Hiiragi
"...Nozomi-san?"

I froze with the coin still in my hand, causing Shizune-san to tilt her head in confusion.
I made myself look away from the neighboring machine and inserted the coin into the slot.

Oh no... The truth is, I want to play the crane game next to me instead...
I mean, it's a Lord Wald's figure!
He is so incredibly handsome... I want it... I really, really want it...
Honestly, I'd gladly drop ten thousand yen on this one...

Nozomi Anesaki
"Ah…!"

Because I was distracted by all those thoughts, I messed up the controls a little.
The claw knocked the chick aside, sending it flying into an awkward position.

Shizune・Nozomi
"Ahh…"

Another fail.
The chick I'd been aiming for had moved to a difficult spot, and it looked like I'd have to give up...

Hozumi Hoshina
"You suck at this."

A voice suddenly came from the side.
I looked up to find Hozumi-san already standing right beside me.

Hozumi Hoshina
"You really are a total klutz."
Nozomi Anesaki
"What…"

I almost retorted, "What did you just say?!" but held myself back.
Since Shizune-san was here, I had to maintain a more refined demeanor.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...My bad."
Hozumi Hoshina
"This one's way easier than the one next to it."

Hozumi-san pointed toward the WataPuri crane game, grinning mischievously.
...He was totally doing this on purpose...
I gave Hozumi-san a slight glare, then calmly looked away from the machine beside us with a composed expression.

Mizuho Hoshina
"If you think it's so easy, why don't you try it, Hozumi?"

Senpai casually stepped in.
I didn't miss the brief glance he sent my way.
…I see.

So that's the plan: Hozumi-san gets the chick → gives it to Shizune-san → they make up. That would be a pretty awesome development.

Nozomi Anesaki
"That's right. Why don't you give it a try, Hozumi-san?"

So I joined in and tried to rile him up a little myself.

Hozumi Hoshina
"...Guess I have no choice..."

To my surprise, Hozumi-san simply nodded, then stepped in front of the machine and inserted a coin.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Does it matter which one?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes, we need the pink chick in the back."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Ah... the one you sent flying into that weird spot, right?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Can you get it?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"It would've been much easier to win from where it was earlier."

Despite saying that, Hozumi-san started operating the crane with a practiced ease.
I stole a glance up at his profile.

Hozumi Hoshina
"..."

He had an unusually serious look on his face.
He looked... kind of attractive. It must be the glasses that made me think that.
He looks thirty percent more handsome simply because he bears such a striking resemblance to Hoshina-senpai.
It's not like I think Hozumi-san himself is attractive or anything. Absolutely not. Not at all.
While I was preoccupied with those thoughts, the crane slowly descended.
The claw slipped underneath the chick's body.
Then, with a perfect sense of balance, it lifted the prize up and returned directly above the prize chute without dropping it.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Huh... He got it on the first try..."

He didn't seem to have any trouble at all.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Easy."

With a smug grin, Hozumi-san retrieved the chick from the prize chute and casually tossed it my way.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Whoa…"

I hurriedly extended my arm to catch it.
Then I held it out to Shizune-san, who was standing nearby.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Here you go. I'm happy for you, Shizune-san."
Shizune Hiiragi
"Huh…?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Huh?"

Both of them frowned at the same time.
Senpai immediately stepped beside Shizune-san and began speaking with a cheerful smile.

Mizuho Hoshina
"Hozumi won it for you. That's great, isn't it?"
Shizune Hiiragi
"B-but... can I really take this...? What about you, Nozomi-san...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"No, it's fine. You were the one who wanted it, right, Shizune-san? I don't really need it."
Hozumi Hoshina
"..."

I could feel Hozumi-san's frightening gaze on me.
Why though...? This was actually working out nicely for him...

Shizune Hiiragi
"...U-um…"

Shizune-san took a deep breath and stood in front of Hozumi-san.
She gently held the chick in her hands and bowed deeply.

Shizune Hiiragi
"Thank you very much...!"
Hozumi Hoshina
"..."
Shizune Hiiragi
"..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Whatever."

Hozumi-san's response was extremely cold and brief.

But compared to how he had been completely ignoring her earlier, this was a major step forward.
Shizune-san was probably glad that he had finally answered her. Her expression finally began to brighten again.

Shizune Hiiragi
"I'll treasure this..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"..."
Shizune Hiiragi
"...And also... I'm sorry about yesterday..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"..."
Shizune Hiiragi
"I said some terrible things to you, Hozumi-kun..."
Shizune Hiiragi
"I never meant to say something like that... I'm sorry..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"…It's fine."

Hozumi-san muttered with a sigh.
His attitude was still rather detached, but he didn't seem annoyed or tense.

Hozumi Hoshina
"...It doesn't bother me."
Shizune Hiiragi
"R-really...? Hozumi-kun, you're not mad...?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"…I'm not mad."
Shizune Hiiragi
"Th... That's a relief... truly...!"

Shizune-san's face suddenly blossomed into a radiant smile.
Guhhh!!! The sheer power of that smile...!
She's too cute!!!

Hozumi Hoshina
"..."

Come on, Hozumi-san, why are you turning your face away? You can't miss out on seeing Shizune-san when she's this adorable.

Shizune Hiiragi
"...I know! I'll attach it to my bag immediately."

Shizune-san attached the chick keychain beneath the handle of her handbag.
That looked… kind of nice. No, not that I want a chick keychain or anything...

Shizune Hiiragi
"Hozumi-kun, thank you so much."
Hozumi Hoshina
"…Yeah, yeah."

Hozumi-san replied as if he didn't care, still facing away.
He probably cared more than he let on. Honestly... he should just admit how he really feels.
...In any case, everything had gone according to plan, and I was relieved that I'd managed to help Hozumi-san and Shizune-san reconcile.
I sent Senpai a look that said, "We pulled it off."

Mizuho Hoshina
"..."

...Huh...? Senpai looks a little conflicted...
He was smiling so happily just a moment ago... I wonder what happened...
...Then our eyes met.
His lips barely moved as he silently mouthed, "We did it," and he smiled warmly.
Something feels off... but I guess it's fine.
I nodded slightly and smiled back at Senpai.

Shizune Hiiragi
"Ah... I should get going already."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Oh, you have to go?"
Shizune Hiiragi
"Yes... I would have liked to stay with everyone a little longer..."
Mizuho Hoshina
"I see. I have cram school too, so maybe we should call it a day here."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes, I suppose so."
Shizune Hiiragi
"Well then..."

After politely bowing her head, Shizune-san once again turned to Hozumi-san.

Shizune Hiiragi
"Hozumi-kun, I'll do something to thank you next time..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Huh? There's no need."
Shizune Hiiragi
"Hehe... Well then, I'll be going."

Shizune-san gave us a little wave before turning around and heading off.

Mizuho Hoshina
"...All right, I'll be heading off too. Anesaki-san, thank you for today."
Nozomi Anesaki

"Of course. You too, Senpai. Thanks for your hard work today."
Mizuho Hoshina
"Oh, before I forget. I'll book the movie tickets."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Oh... thank you. I'll leave it to you."
Mizuho Hoshina
"Okay, let's discuss the details at school. See you."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes, goodbye."

I stood there for a little while, watching Senpai disappear into the distance.
Hozumi-san, standing beside me, also showed no sign of leaving.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Hey."
Nozomi Anesaki
"What?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"You were in on it with Mizuho, weren't you?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...No, I wasn't."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Cut the crap. You're not fooling anyone."

So he did catch on after all... Hozumi-san was staring at us the whole time Senpai and I were talking...

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Even if that's true, so what?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"It's pissing me off. Don't do things behind my back."
Nozomi Anesaki
"But you made up with Shizune-san, didn't you? Isn't that a good thing?"

Besides, he didn't seem to mind it that much.

Hozumi Hoshina
"I just said whatever to get it over with, it was too much trouble."
Nozomi Anesaki
"You're not being honest…"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Huh? What's that supposed to mean?"

You have feelings for Shizune-san, don't you?
...Actually, I don't want to hear it.
It's pretty much confirmed anyway, so I don't really need to ask.

Nozomi Anesaki

"...Just be nice to Shizune-san, okay?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Why do you even care?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Hmm... Seeing her look so sad is hard to bear."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Whatever. Don't ever do anything behind my back again."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I won't."

There's no need to do anything.
If they really do feel the same way about each other...
...then things will work out on their own eventually.

Nozomi Anesaki
"All right then... I should probably get going too."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Do you have plans or something?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"No, nothing in particular."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Hmm... In that case, come with me."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Oh, are you planning to do something?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Just killing time."
Nozomi Anesaki
"You can just do that on your own."

You were giving off the impression earlier that you'd rather be alone, too.

Hozumi Hoshina
"You're free anyway, so what's the problem?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I guess so…"

I may act unwilling, but deep down, I don't mind staying.
I actually like spending time with him.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Well… what are you planning to do?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"This."

Hozumi-san was pointing at…

Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh?!"

Not the crane game with the chick keychains, but the machine beside it...
The one filled with WataPuri figures.

Nozomi Anesaki
"W-wait, this?! You're going to play this?!"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Yes."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh... wh-why…?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"You want this, don't you?"

A nasty, smug grin spread across his face.
Ugh... this was humiliating...
...But...

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Yes."

I nodded slightly. I couldn't resist the temptation.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...W-wait... are you going to get it for me...?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Well, yeah."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...For free?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"I plan on getting it within three tries, so I don't need any money."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...You're not planning to make me do something outrageous in return later, right...?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"You... who do you take me for?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"A scumbag."
Hozumi Hoshina
"You little shit."

No, but really though…

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Really, are you sure? I mean... I don't have any right to ask this of you..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...It's for yesterday."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh?"
Hozumi Hoshina

"...The clothes, the treatment, all of that stuff. It's a thank-you for that."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ah, aah... You really don't have to worry about that."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...I mean, I just want to see if I can get it. It looks pretty difficult, it makes me want to try."

The way he phrased it... He was trying not to make me feel indebted, wasn't he?
This was another thing I liked about Hozumi-san.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Still... This looks really difficult. You think you can get it within three games?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"I'm actually pretty good at these games. It's the only thing I can confidently say I'm better than Mizuho at."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...I see..."

I can't tell whether this is something to admire or feel sorry about.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Don't worry, I've got this. I'll make sure I win it for you."

Hozumi-san's face became serious as he put in the coin.
Hmm... He really is handsome... maybe. His personality is a whole other story, but looks-wise, he's definitely the prince type...

Hozumi Hoshina
"...What?"

Hozumi-san turned to me with a puzzled expression.
I hurriedly looked away and turned my attention to the inside of the glass display case.

Nozomi Anesaki
"It's nothing."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Don't stare at me like that."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Why?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"It's distracting."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hmm… Okay."

As I nodded, the crane started moving.
It moved past Lord Wald's head, then stopped exactly above the adjacent box.

Nozomi Anesaki
"No, not that one!"

Hozumi Hoshina
"Huh?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I don't need this one. I want Lord Wald, the prize next to it."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...What the hell...? Seriously, this 'Lord Wald' thing again..? Who even is he..?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"My Prince."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Tch..."

Hozumi-san gave up on the current attempt and put another coin in.

Hozumi Hoshina
"...This one, right? The blonde one."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah! This one!"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Ah... this one's hard to get... What about the blonde one in the back? Is that one no good?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh? Oh... I like that one too, but he's not my fave."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Oh, okay. ...They all look the same to me..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"You can't get Lord Wald...?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Do you want it that badly?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes…"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Well, I guess I have no choice... It's all or nothing…"

Hozumi-san moved the crane. He then stopped it just a little away from directly above Lord Wald.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Isn't it a little off?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Just wait and see."

The crane descended. The arms slowly spread out,
and WHACK!, it knocked Lord Wald down!

Nozomi Anesaki
"WAAIT!!!"
Hozumi Hoshina
"What happened?!"
Nozomi Anesaki

"What are you doing?! You'll hurt Lord Wald!!!"
Hozumi Hoshina
"He's in a box, so he'll be fine."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Be gentler with him...!"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Man, you're so demanding... Just shut up and watch."

Hozumi-san inserted another coin.
This time, the claw stopped perfectly right above the fallen Lord Wald box.
He really wasn't exaggerating when he said she was good at this; he clearly knew what he was doing.
Then the arms firmly grabbed the box...
and smoothly dropped it into the prize chute.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh, no way! You really got it in three tries!!!"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Piece of cake."

Hozumi-san had a smug, proud look. My affection level for Hozumi Hoshina increased by 100.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Hozumi-san, you're a legend!!! I love you!!!"
Hozumi Hoshina
"...You're so easy..."

Chapter 28: Discrepancy

We spent a little while having fun at the arcade, and then Hozumi-san and I left the shopping mall together.
He offered to give me a ride home on his bicycle.

Hozumi Hoshina
"By the way, has your leg healed?"
Nozomi Anesaki
I don't think it's completely healed yet, but I can walk without crutches now."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Oh... Will you still be going to the hospital?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah, I'm planning to go after the weekend."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Hmm... Well then... I'll come to your school on Monday too."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh?"
Hozumi Hoshina

"I'll give you a ride to the hospital."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh, are you sure? I can walk normally now though…"
Hozumi Hoshina
"I'll do it until it's completely healed, just in case."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...I see, thank you…"

...Now that I think about it, the only reason I've gotten this close to Hozumi-san is because I was injured...
Once I'm fully healed, Hozumi-san won't be picking me up and dropping me off anymore, and with us being at different schools, there won't be any reason for us to see each other. We'll have no points of contact at all.

Hozumi Hoshina
"? Is something wrong?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"You got awfully quiet all of a sudden. What's with the gloomy mood?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Really...?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Yeah. And you were practically bouncing around at the arcade."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Well, of course..."

I lowered my gaze to the bag hanging from my hand. Inside was the Lord Wald figure that Hozumi-san got for me.

Nozomi Anesaki
"I never thought I'd be able to get a Lord Wald's figure in a place like this."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Good for you."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hehehehe."
Hozumi Hoshina
"What a goofy face."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I don't care what you say."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...So, who exactly is Lord Wald anyway? I still don't really understand."
Nozomi Anesaki
"He has a lean, muscular build and stands 181 cm tall while weighing 67 kg. His hobbies are horseback riding and fencing, and his skills in these are unmatched."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...and with a tolerance wider than the universe, he continues to love me devotedly and faithfully—a super-ultra-handsome blond, blue-eyed dreamboat!!! Get it?"

Hozumi Hoshina
"Summarize it in three lines."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Handsome. Kind. Prince."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...So he's like Mizuho?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"That's right! Hoshina-senpai is the real-world version of Lord Wald!"
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Hmm..."

Hozumi-san steered the bike onto a quiet road. After a short silence fell between us, I found myself feeling oddly fidgety.

Hozumi Hoshina
"...What about me?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hm?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"If Mizuho is Lord Wald, then what am I?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh…"

Hozumi-san?
Hozumi-san is…

Nozomi Anesaki
"You're Lord Wald's face."
Hozumi Hoshina
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Well, I see... That's true…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"..."

Silence again. I felt restless.
As I desperately thought of something to talk about, Hozumi-san spoke first.

Hozumi Hoshina
"…Hey."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Hm?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"You…"

Hozumi Hoshina
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...What?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Well... Right... Are you going to watch a movie with Mizuho?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ah, yeah. Next weekend."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Hmm... Are you looking forward to it?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah... obviously."

That's a given. I mean, why is this even a question?

Nozomi Anesaki
"Why do you ask?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"No reason… Do you… actually like Mizuho?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh...? Uh... What is this all of a sudden...?"

What does he mean by "actually"? Is he doubting me…?

Nozomi Anesaki
"...I-I like him…"

…Obviously.

Hozumi Hoshina
"...Seriously?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Seriously."
Hozumi Hoshina
"For real?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"For real."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Why?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Why...? What is with you all of a sudden?"

It sounds like he's practically asking me to say no.
All this time, he's been enthusiastically cheering me on in my love life. I wonder what he's thinking...

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Am I not allowed to like Senpai?"

Hozumi Hoshina
"No... I mean... it's not like that."

Hozumi-san said that in his usual vague manner, and then fell silent.
For some reason, I got the feeling that there was something weighing on him.
Ah, maybe...
Maybe Hozumi-san felt guilty about encouraging my feelings.
Because his support wasn't entirely selfless. He was using me to achieve his own romantic goal...
Even if that were true, I didn't really feel like I was being used.
Because my feelings for Senpai are genuine.
……
...But then why do I still feel unsettled?
Every conclusion I drew felt strangely mismatched.

I spent some time reading before bed again that night.
By the time I reached the halfway point of the second book, I was starting to get sleepy, so I set it aside.
I checked the clock and saw that it was already past 1 AM.
I feel like I could keep going a bit longer, but there's no point reading when I'm tired since I won't really absorb anything. It's probably best to stop here for today.
That leaves four more books to go, including the one I bought today… I'm starting to feel a little worried about whether I can finish them all in one week.
Even if I do get through them all, I don't have much confidence I'll be able to keep up with Senpai while discussing them.
Senpai and Shizune-san at the bookstore today genuinely looked like they were having fun...
I really wonder why the two of them aren't dating.
Does Senpai really have feelings for me...?
Does Shizune-san actually have feelings for Hozumi-san? Not Senpai...?
...I'm not sure.
The fragments of information I've pieced together and my gut feeling keep contradicting each other, leaving me unsatisfied. I can't really convince myself.
And another thing...

Hozumi Hoshina
"You… Do you actually like Mizuho?"

For some reason, this question from Hozumi-san kept popping up in my head.
No... of course I like him, but...

Hozumi Hoshina
"Why?"

After he pushed me on it like this, I didn't know what to think anymore.
I began to doubt myself, and for some reason, I started feeling like I was doing something wrong.
...Ugh, this is so frustrating...!

I feel the same sort of affection for Senpai that I feel for Lord Wald... which means I must love everything about him...!
I forced myself to come to a conclusion and shifted my gaze to the bedside.
That's where I immediately decided to display the Lord Wald figure that Hozumi-san got for me today.
Ah... I feel healed...

Shizune Hiiragi
"Hozumi-kun, I'll do something to thank you next time..."

A thank-you gift, huh...
Hozumi-san got a prize for me too, so maybe I should do something to thank him...?
He said this was a thank-you for what I did for him, but all I did was treat his injury. It feels like far too much for something so small.
...Yeah, I definitely need to do something for him.
I need to think of something that would make Hozumi-san happy.

Chapter 29: Girls' talk

The next day.
I headed to a specialty baking supply store in the shopping mall.
After considering various ways to repay Hozumi-san, I settled on giving him homemade sweets.
He had mentioned that he liked sweets, after all.
Maybe cookies...? If I give him something too fancy, Hozumi-san would probably feel awkward about it…
...Madeleines would be a good choice too. Muffins might be nice as well.
As I browsed the wide selection of ingredients, someone suddenly tapped me on the shoulder.

Shizune Hiiragi
"Nozomi-san."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh? …Shizune-san!"

That caught me by surprise. I never thought we'd run into each other again so soon.
Shizune-san's shopping basket was filled with all sorts of baking ingredients.
I bet she makes sweets all the time. She really is so feminine.

Shizune Hiiragi
"Hehe, what an incredible coincidence."
Nozomi Anesaki
"It really is..."
Shizune Hiiragi
"Nozomi-san, do you bake as well?"
Nozomi Anesaki

"N-no... I don't usually bake, but I suddenly felt like making something for the first time in a while."
Shizune Hiiragi
"I see. What are you going to make?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Well... that's the problem. I can't decide..."

I think he'd be happy with any kind of sweet, but if I'm going to give him a gift, I want to make something he'll really love.

Shizune Hiiragi
"Are you making a present?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh… y-yes...I suppose you could say that..."
Shizune Hiiragi
"It's pretty hard to decide what to give to others, right…? Actually, I'm having the same trouble myself..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Is that so?"
Shizune Hiiragi
"Yes. I've been thinking about how to thank Hozumi-kun..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Oh…"

Ohh... it looks like Shizune-san and I had the same thought...
I guess when you're trying to thank someone, this is one of the most common choices...

Shizune Hiiragi
"...But since Hozumi-kun doesn't like sweets, I guess spicy food would be be—"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh?"

The word slipped out before I could stop myself, interrupting Shizune-san mid-sentence.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Does Hozumi-san hate sweets?"
Shizune Hiiragi
"Yes... I think so, at least..."

...Really...? But...

Nozomi Anesaki
"I could've sworn Hozumi-san said he liked sweets..."
Shizune Hiiragi
"Wait...? He did?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes... Unless I misheard him."
Shizune Hiiragi

"...It happened a long time ago, but... when Hozumi-kun ate the sweets I made, he had this strange look on his face..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh…"
Shizune Hiiragi
"Recently, he wouldn't even accept them from me... so I thought maybe he didn't like sweets... But perhaps he just doesn't like the things I make...?"

Shizune-san looked dejected. I quickly shook my head.

Nozomi Anesaki
"No, no...! I don't think that's the case!"
Shizune Hiiragi
"Really…?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes! I think Hozumi-san is probably just embarrassed...!"
Shizune Hiiragi
"...? Why would he be embarrassed?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Well…"

It's because he likes you, Shizune-san!
I wanted to tell her that, but it wasn't my secret to share, so I bit my tongue.

Nozomi Anesaki
"I think that's simply the kind of person he is...! He's just not used to accepting things from others..."
Shizune Hiiragi
"D-do you really think so...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I do...! I think he really does want them, but he can't honestly admit it."
Shizune Hiiragi
"...Do you think he will accept my sweets next time...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes...! I'm sure he will...!"
Shizune Hiiragi
"Then I'll try making sweet treats as usual...!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I think that's a good idea."

Shizune-san began picking out ingredients with a cheerful expression.
As for me... what should I do?
I'll decide once I see what Shizune-san is going to make. I'd rather not have our gifts overlap...
After we'd bought all the ingredients we needed, Shizune-san and I left the store together.
In the end, I decided to play it safe and make cookies.
Apparently, Shizune-san was planning to make a chiffon cake. I felt reassured knowing I wouldn't have to compete with her over whose dessert had the better texture.

Shizune Hiiragi
"Nozomi-san, is anyone coming for you?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"No? I'm by myself."
Shizune Hiiragi
"Are you heading home now?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes. I got everything I needed."
Shizune Hiiragi
"Would you like to walk home together for a bit?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ah... I'd be happy to."

I strolled home with Shizune-san.
The chick keychain attached to her bag swayed gently in rhythm with her steps.

Shizune Hiiragi
"By the way, thank you for yesterday."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yesterday...?"
Shizune Hiiragi
"Um... you were trying to help me make up with Hozumi-kun, weren't you...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh…"

Shizune-san noticed it too, huh. Was I really being that obvious...?

Nozomi Anesaki
"I wasn't being meddlesome, was I...?"
Shizune Hiiragi
"No, absolutely not...! I really appreciate what you did. I'd been searching for an opportunity to apologize to Hozumi-kun that whole time..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I'm glad to hear that."
Shizune Hiiragi
"I... I keep making Hozumi-kun angry... I'm hopeless, aren't I…?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"No... I'd say Hozumi-san's is the issue..."

I mean, he's really just not able to be honest with himself.

Shizune Hiiragi
"Do you think so...? But I feel like this was my fault..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Shizune-san, did something happen between you and Hozumi-san?"
Shizune Hiiragi
"...I said something really cruel to him that day."

Nozomi Anesaki
"But you already apologized yesterday, right? Hozumi-san isn't mad anymore, so I don't think there's any reason for you to dwell on it."
Shizune Hiiragi
"Is that really so...? But... Hozumi-kun has been so distant this entire time..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Well... isn't that just his personality?"
Shizune Hiiragi
"...Hmm..."

Shizune-san murmured with a troubled look on her face.
Honestly, Hozumi-san… Whether he's just embarrassed or putting on a tsundere act, what's the point if he ends up hurting the person he cares about…?

Shizune Hiiragi
"...But... he wasn't always like this. He used to be so kind..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Huh?"
Shizune Hiiragi
"Some time ago, Hozumi-kun started acting differently... So I suppose I really did do something to upset him..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."

This time, I couldn't offer any advice, because I didn't know anything about their past.
Part of me wanted to dig a little deeper and ask more, but I don't think it's my place to interfere when I have nothing to do with it...

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Honestly, I don't think you need to worry about it...!"

Although what I said was hardly a well-founded reassurance, I delivered it with as much confidence as I could muster.
I was sure that Hozumi-san liked Shizune-san, but I couldn't exactly tell her that.

Shizune Hiiragi
"...Do you really think so...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes! I'm sure he'll be happy to receive the cake...!"
Shizune Hiiragi
"I suppose... you're right... It's decided, then…! I'll try my best to make it...!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes, that's the spirit!"
Shizune Hiiragi
"I'll make some for you too, Nozomi-san, so please be sure to try it!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ah, thank you. Then I'll make you some cookies too, Shizune-san, so please accept them."
Shizune Hiiragi

"Aww, I'm delighted."

At last, Shizune-san's expression brightened.
...But just when I thought that, her expression turned gloomy again.

Shizune Hiiragi
"Nozomi-san, you're planning to give cookies to someone as a gift, right...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh? Ah, yes... I-I suppose so..."
Shizune Hiiragi
"Ah... um... well... the person you're giving them to..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Yes?"
Shizune Hiiragi
"..."

Shizune-san's gaze wavered anxiously.
After hesitating for a while, she slowly began to speak.

Shizune Hiiragi
"...Is it… Mizuho-kun…?"

……
Huh?
The way she reacted... I still had a feeling that Shizune-san liked Senpai.
Maybe the whole idea that she likes Hozumi-san is just something Senpai convinced himself of...?
But... I'm certain that Shizune-san does care about Hozumi-san...
Hmm... I'm not sure...
I shook my head, unable to make sense of it.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...No, it's for another friend of mine."

I'll avoid mentioning that it's Hozumi-san, just in case. If he is the person Shizune-san has feelings for, she probably won't be happy to hear it.

Shizune Hiiragi
"Oh... a friend...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes, it's not for Senpai."
Shizune Hiiragi
"I-I see..."

Shizune-san's face relaxed. She looked relieved.
Maybe I was right after all... Shizune-san might like Senpai...
Hmm... I can't stand this uncertainty. Should I just ask outright…?

Nozomi Anesaki
"Um…"
Shizune Hiiragi
"Yes?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Shziune-san... You have feelings for Senpai, don't you...?"
Shizune Hiiragi
"Huh?!"

Shizune-san's face instantly turned bright red.
Wow, so cute.
…Also, I guess I was right all along.

Shizune Hiiragi
"Wh-wh-wh-why... why… would you think that...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"S-sorry for suddenly asking something strange... I was just a little... curious..."
Shizune Hiiragi
"N-no... well... uh… u-um...!"

Shizune-san's eyes were spinning. She looked completely overwhelmed.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Ah... um... you don't have to answer if you don't want to...!"

Her reaction had already given me my answer. Right now, I was more concerned about how Shizune-san looked like she might faint.

Shizune Hiiragi
"I'm sorry!!!"

Suddenly, Shizune-san bent forward at a 90-degree angle and bowed with all her might.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh?! F-for what?!"
Shizune Hiiragi
"I-I... I do... th-that's right...!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hm? Uh-huh...? I see... so that's how it is..."
Shizune Hiiragi
"Y-yes... I-I'm sooorry..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Wait... Wh-why are you apologizing...?"
Shizune Hiiragi
"I know that you have feelings for Mizuho-kun...!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh?! That's not…!"

Wait, no... I can't really say that's not true. I just remembered, I do like Senpai...
Oh wow... What is going on here?! This suddenly turned into a confession session...!

Shizune Hiiragi
"O-obviously, I know that Nozomi-san is a much better match for Mizuho-kun...!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Wait, wait, wait, wait!!! There are so many things wrong with that statement!!!"
Shizune Hiiragi
"B-but... even so... well… I-I just... can't help loving him..."

Tears welled up in the corners of Shizune-san's eyes.
I quickly took a handkerchief from my bag and wiped them away.

Nozomi Anesaki
"P-please calm down, okay?"
Shizune Hiiragi
"U-uhh... I'm sorry..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"D-don't worry... it's going to be okay, really..."

I had no idea what exactly I was reassuring her about, so for now, I focused on calming her down.
Shizune-san sniffled for a while, then bowed politely once more.

Shizune Hiiragi
"I'm sorry…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"No, no… You have nothing to apologize for…"
Shizune Hiiragi
"I... I know I have to give up... but I just can't bring myself to do it..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"There's no reason for you to give up."
Shizune Hiiragi
"...But… I… I'll only get in your way…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"You're not getting in the way or anything… For starters, Senpai and I aren't actually together..."
Shizune Hiiragi
"But... I'm sure that someday... uhhh…!"

Once again, tears welled up in her eyes.
I smiled wryly and softly wiped them away.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Why are you already giving up...? We don't know who Senpai will choose yet."
Shizune Hiiragi
"...It's definitely going to be you..."
Nozomi Anesaki

"Why do you think that?"
Shizune Hiiragi
"Because you're truly amazing."
Nozomi Anesaki
"No... well... I think you're more admirable, really..."

I feel a little awkward...

Shizune Hiiragi
"Nozomi-san... doesn't it bother you...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh? What does?"
Shizune Hiiragi
"The fact that I like Mizuho-kun..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ah... no, it doesn't bother me at all."
Shizune Hiiragi
"...I-in that case... well..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes?"
Shizune Hiiragi
"Will you forgive me... for remaining Mizuho-kun's friend...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh…"
Shizune Hiiragi
"Ah! I knew it was too much to ask!!! I'm sorry...!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"No, no, no...! I think it's totally fine!"
Shizune Hiiragi
"Huh…?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I don't understand why you even asked."
Shizune Hiiragi
"...But… It just doesn't feel right..."

...Well... I can understand how she feels, at least. I also was hesitant about making a move on Senpai because of her...

Nozomi Anesaki
"I don't think you should give up on your feelings for Senpai because of me."
Shizune Hiiragi
"What…?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Please cherish your own feelings and act as you see fit, Shizune-san."
Shizune Hiiragi
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Well?"

Shizune Hiiragi
"...Are you really okay with that...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes. That's what I want you to do."
Shizune Hiiragi
"...Nozomi-san… will you hate me for it...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Oh, come on, of course I won't. I like you, Shizune-san."

As I gave her a warm smile and nodded, Shizune-san's eyes widened in surprise...

Shizune Hiiragi
"Nozomi-san, I love you so much...!"

She suddenly hugged me. A gentle, sweet fragrance surrounded me.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Jeez... you're confessing to the wrong person."
Shizune Hiiragi
"Hehehe... I like you, Nozomi-san."
Nozomi Anesaki
"O-okay, I get it."
Shizune Hiiragi
"Nozomi-san, you should follow your own feelings too... Don't let me stop you from getting closer to Mizuho-kun...!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh? Y-yes... I will..."

Somehow, things had taken a strange turn...
But... I didn't mind it.
Oddly enough, even after it was confirmed that Shizune-san was my love rival, I didn't feel upset.
On the contrary, I found myself feeling strangely relieved.
...Then Hozumi-san's face came to mind, leaving me conflicted.

Chapter 30: Cookie making

When I got home, it was just about to pass 3:00 PM.
Shun had gone over to a friend's house today.
He'd probably be back by dinnertime, so I needed to make sure the kitchen was free before then.
I decided to start baking cookies right away.

Shun Anesaki
"I'm home."

It seemed like Shun had returned home.

Just then, the oven beeped. The cookies were done at exactly the right moment.

Shun Anesaki
"...Hm? Something smells nice."

Shun came into the living room with a puzzled look on his face.
When he noticed me in the kitchen, he looked even more confused.

Shun Anesaki
"Sis?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Welcome back, Shun."
Shun Anesaki
"What are you up to?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I was making some cookies."

I removed them from the oven and set them on the counter.
They were a perfect golden brown, neither burnt nor undercooked.

Shun Anesaki
"Wow... looks delicious."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hehehe. Want some?"
Shun Anesaki
"I do."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Be careful, they're hot."
Shun Anesaki
"Okay."

Carefully pinching a cookie with his fingertips, Shun popped it into his mouth.
I decided to try one as well.

Shun Anesaki
"...Oh, they're good. Yummy."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Oh, you're right! They came out really well!"

They were nice and crispy, with a rich, delicious flavor.

Shun Anesaki
"...By the way, what'd you make them for?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"It's a gift."
Shun Anesaki
"...Prez?"
Nozomi Anesaki

"No, not him."
Shun Anesaki
"Uh…"
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"...Don't tell me... Homo...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"He's not gay... but yes, it's for him."
Shun Anesaki
"What?! Seriously?! Why him?!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I kind of owe him one."
Shun Anesaki
"Owe him one?!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"He won me a Lord Wald figure at the game center."
Shun Anesaki
"Whoa... that's... uh... wow, really...?"

As Shun continued muttering nearby, I carefully placed the cookies into the gift bag one by one.
Once the bag was packed full, I closed it off with a heart-decorated ribbon.
Ahh... it's so, so cute. I made quite a feminine gift, if I do say so myself.
...Though, I guess Hozumi-san isn't exactly the type who would appreciate a super girly present...

Shun Anesaki
"...Uh… gh…"

Shun was letting out some strange, unintelligible sounds.
I reluctantly stuffed a cookie into his mouth.

Nozomi Anesaki
"There's still some left for you."
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Are they good?"
Shun Anesaki
"...They are…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Do they hold up to the cookies you got from Senpai before...?"
Shun Anesaki
"...Aah, yeah, those were insanely good too."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I knew it..."

Shizune-san's cookies were probably way better than mine...
I knew it was pointless to worry about something like that, but I couldn't help feeling a little self-conscious.

Shun Anesaki
"But these are great too."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Really...?"
Shun Anesaki
"Yeah. Very yummy."
Nozomi Anesaki
"A-all right."

If Shun gave them a passing grade, they should be good enough, right? I hope Hozumi-san will be happy with them too.

Chapter 31: Uneasy

The next morning.
I received a message from Shizune-san, with whom I had exchanged phone numbers the day before.

Shizune Hiiragi
“I have something I'd like to give you, so I'll be waiting for you at the gate of Sasajiin High after school today.”

What could it be? ...Ah, maybe it's a cake.
...I see... So Shizune-san is planning to give Hozumi-san a cake today, too.
I responded with a simple "okay."
……
I'm planning to give Hozumi-san a gift too... I wonder how he'll react.
I felt both hopeful and uneasy. The thought of meeting Hozumi-san today made me a little nervous.
When the final homeroom came to an end, I hurried out of the classroom as usual.

Mizuho Hoshina
"Ah, Anesaki-san."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ah, Senpai. Hello."
Mizuho Hoshina
"Are you going home?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes. You too, Senpai?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"That's right. If you don't mind, would you like to walk home together for a bit?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh... Ah... I'm sorry. I have to go to the hospital today..."

Mizuho Hoshina
"Oh, really? By the way, how's your leg?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"The pain's gone, and I think it's almost healed."
Mizuho Hoshina
"Do you think it'll be fully healed by this weekend then?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes."
Mizuho Hoshina
"That's good to hear."

Caught up in the flow of the moment, I left the school entrance together with him.
The paparazzi were watching us just as intently as ever. I had gotten used to it by now, but I still couldn't help finding it a little bothersome.

Mizuho Hoshina
"Thank you for your help the other day."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Don't mention it. I'm just glad the two of them made up."
Mizuho Hoshina
"Shizune's doing better now too, so I'm relieved."

We approached the school entrance while making small talk.
Then we saw Hozumi-san and Shizune-san standing side by side outside the gate.

Mizuho Hoshina
"Huh...? Isn't that Hozumi and Shizune...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"That's right."

The two of them seemed to be talking about something at the edge of the sidewalk, a little way from the gate.
Shizune-san was holding a cute little package in her hands.
...I see. So Shizune-san is about to give Hozumi-san a cake...
I hope Hozumi-san will accept it without making a fuss...
I watched them anxiously, but Hozumi-san surprisingly accepted Shizune-san's present with a calm, composed expression.
Shizune-san smiled adorably, looking delighted. Hozumi-san had his back to her, wearing his usual cold expression, but he was probably just trying to hide how embarrassed he was.
Ahh... thank goodness... I'm glad things didn't get awkward.
Although I felt relieved, a murky, unfamiliar emotion suddenly welled up inside me. ...This is such a strange feeling.
It was only after we stepped outside the gate that the two of them finally seemed to notice us.

Shizune Hiiragi
"Ah, Nozomi-san, Mizuho-kun."
Nozomi Anesaki

"Hello, Shizune-san. Was it difficult for you to come all the way here?"
Shizune Hiiragi
"Hehe. Not at all. I got to see Hozumi-kun too, so it worked out perfectly."

With that, Shizune-san pulled a small package out of her bag.

Shizune Hiiragi
"Yes, it's chiffon cake. It turned out well, so please try some."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Aw, thank you. I brought something too."

I took the bag of cookies I brought for Shizune-san out of my bag and held it out to her.

Shizune Hiiragi
"Thank you very much…!"

Senpai stood quietly beside Shizune-san as she received it with a happy expression.
I didn't make anything for Senpai because I knew he didn't like sweets... But in this situation, would it be a little rude not to give him anything?
W-well, I guess it'll be fine...

Shizune Hiiragi
"Mizuho-kun, take some too."

Shizune-san took another small package out of her bag and, looking somewhat nervous, held it out to Senpai.
At that moment, it seemed as though Senpai's expression stiffened ever so slightly.

Mizuho Hoshina
"Uh… Ah..."
Shizune Hiiragi
"...Mizuho-kun?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"Oh... no... well... I think I'll pass today..."
Shizune Hiiragi
"...Huh?"

Shizune-san and I both stared at Senpai in disbelief.
There's no way Senpai just refused... Did I hear that wrong...?

Shizune Hiiragi
"…U… Um… you don't want any...?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"...Actually… I'm feeling a bit unwell today… I don't think I can eat anything."
Shizune Hiiragi
"I-I see…"
Mizuho Hoshina
"I'm r-really sorry…"

Shizune Hiiragi
"No, don't worry…! I'll make some for you another day!"
Mizuho Hoshina
"S-sure… thank you."

His smile looked a little forced.
Caught between his aversion to sweets and the sincerity behind the offering, a hint of conflict flickered across his face.

Hozumi Hoshina
"...Hey, Anesaki."

Hozumi-san turned his bike around and tapped the rear rack.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Let's go."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ah, right."
Shizune Hiiragi
"Are you... going somewhere?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I'm going to the hospital for a foot examination."

I sat down on the rear rack and wrapped my arms around Hozumi-san's waist.
...Hmm, I wonder why... I feel a little restless...

Shizune Hiiragi
"U-um…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes?"
Shizune Hiiragi
"..."

Shizune-san glanced back and forth between Senpai and me with a conflicted look on her face.
...Ah, I wonder if she's trying to be considerate of me?
She doesn't need to worry though; they can just go home together.
I smiled at Shizune-san and waved to them.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Goodbye, Shizune-san, Senpai."
Shizune Hiiragi
"Ah… goodbye."
Mizuho Hoshina
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Senpai?"
Mizuho Hoshina

"Uh…? Ah… yes. See you later, Anesaki-san, Hozumi."

...I wonder what's wrong.
He seemed kind of out of it…
And a bit upset...
Just as I was thinking that, the bicycle started moving.
I hurriedly tightened my grip and tried to keep my balance.
After we had been riding for a while, Hozumi-san started to speak.

Hozumi Hoshina
"...Does it bother you?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"What does?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Mizuho and Shizune going home together."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh? Ah... no, not really."

I wasn't pretending to be okay. I genuinely didn't feel anything.
It's true that Shizune-san and I are rivals in love, but... I believe things will work out the way they're meant to, without either of us having to resort to desperate measures.
...I mean, I do like Senpai, though.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Speaking of which, Hozumi-san, today you calmly accepted Shizune-san's gift."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Huh…? How do you know...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I saw it."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Uh... Really...? ...Mizuho too?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Ugh, wow... Seriously...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...? What are you upset about?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"No... It's nothing..."

Hozumi-san looked ahead with a frustrated expression.
Perhaps he's embarrassed that I saw him receiving a gift from Shizune-san.
Hozumi-san is actually pretty shy, huh?

Nozomi Anesaki
"I'm glad you took it without complaining."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...She wouldn't leave me alone until I finally accepted it."

Nozomi Anesaki
"...You really aren't honest with your feelings, are you..."

I know you're secretly happy about it…

Hozumi Hoshina
"Huh? Did you say something?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"No?"

We didn't speak for a while, and I gradually started to feel nervous again.
When should I bring up the fact that I made cookies...?
I probably should have mentioned it earlier, while the conversation was still flowing naturally; once the silence set in, I lost the perfect opportunity.
...Actually, wait.
I'm just giving him a few sweets as a thank-you, so why am I getting so worked up about it?
"YO, I made some cookies. They're really good, you should try them, YO."
I should say something like that.
All right... Here I go!

Hozumi Hoshina
"Hey, we've arrived at the hospital."

The bicycle came to a stop just as I took a breath.
I exhaled and quietly stepped off the bike.
Well... I can just give them to him when we part ways, right?

Chapter 32: Hopeful

When I came out after the examination, Hozumi-san was standing outside, leaning against the hospital wall.
With his hands shoved into his pockets, he looked effortlessly cool.
Honestly... he has no business looking that handsome...

Hozumi Hoshina
"Oh, that was quick."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah. They called me in almost right away."
Hozumi Hoshina
"So? How'd it go?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"They said I'm basically all healed up. I can just go back to my normal life now, and I don't have to come back to the hospital anymore."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...I see. That's good."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes…"

In other words, after today, I'll have no connection with Hozumi-san anymore...

Hozumi Hoshina
"Well then, shall we go home?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Yeah. Let's."

We hardly spoke on the way back.
Come to think of it, what did Hozumi-san and I usually talk about?
I think we only talked about stupid things like butts and asses and stuff.
...And yet, looking back on it now, I realized just how much I'd enjoyed those silly little conversations.

Hozumi Hoshina
"...Oh, by the way."

Suddenly, Hozumi-san broke the silence, as though he'd just remembered something.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Have you been reading the books?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Oh... Yeah, I have. I finished the second book yesterday."

I ended up staying up past one because of that. No wonder I'm feeling a little sleepy now.
I normally try to get to bed by eleven if I have school the next day… Staying up late isn't good for my skin, after all.
But if I slow down now, there's no way I'll finish them all by this weekend...

Hozumi Hoshina
"Huh... I'm surprised you're still keeping at it."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hey, what's that supposed to mean...?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"I figured you'd have given up ages ago."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Could you not lump me in with you? This is nothing. I would endure much more if it meant getting closer to Senpai."

I'm basically grinding my stats.
I need to level up my general knowledge stats to successfully conquer Senpai.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Sounds like you're not really having fun with it."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh... well... I mean, it is pretty hard..."

Light novels are definitely more my thing.

Hozumi Hoshina
"...I don't think there's any need to force yourself to read it."
Nozomi Anesaki
"It's okay. I don't mind studying."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Hmm…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Oh, um, when should I return the books?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Huh? Whenever's fine."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Then... I think I'll finish them sometime this week. Can I give them back to you on Friday?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Yeah, sure. I'll be waiting by the gate on Friday."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Okay!"

Ah... thank goodness. Now I have another reason to see Hozumi-san again.
...Wait, why am I so relieved about that? That's strange...
In the end, I never managed to bring up the cookies, and before I knew it, we'd arrived at my house.
I got off the bike and took my bag from Hozumi-san.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Okay, see you next time."

Hozumi-san waved his hand lightly as usual and put his foot on the pedal.
Oh no... This is bad. If I let this opportunity slip by, I won't get another chance to give them to him.
O-okay!!! Now...!

Nozomi Anesaki
"Wait!!!"

My voice came out much more desperate than I'd intended.
Hozumi-san, who was just about to pedal away, jumped in surprise and lost his balance.
He barely managed to keep himself from falling, though the position he ended up in was anything but graceful.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Wh-whoa... what the heck... You scared me...!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Um, well…"

I took the bag of cookies out of my schoolbag and held it out to Hozumi-san.
Looking at it again, I realized just how ridiculously cute it was… It's kind of embarrassing...

Hozumi Hoshina
"...Hm? What is this?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Um... this is for you."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Huh?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...I made some cookies..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Uh… Ah, right, come to think of it, you gave something to Shizune earlier too."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah... that..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Shouldn't you have given them to Mizuho?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Senpai doesn't like sweets. …Besides, I made these for you, Hozumi-san..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Huh? ...Why?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Well..."

It doesn't matter, does it…!
Just accept them and stop asking questions…! It's embarrassing enough as it is!

Nozomi Anesaki
"Y-you got Lord Wald for me, remember…?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Hm? Oh, that? What about it?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Well... it's a thank-you gift..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Uh…"

He looked startled. Actually... It kind of seemed like he was weirded out.

Hozumi Hoshina
"For that...? I mean... that was my way of thanking you."
Nozomi Anesaki
"L-Lord Wald is on a completely different level. He's worth far more than something so trivial..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...You know... this is kind of cringe…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"W-woah?! I-if you don't want it, then fine! Whatever!"

My embarrassment finally reached its limit and I pulled the cookies back.
But Hozumi-san suddenly grabbed my wrist in a panic.

Hozumi Hoshina
"W-wait, wait...! I want it! I do, okay...!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...You do?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"I do. I want it. Give it to me. ...Please."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Okay…"

I held the cookies out to Hozumi-san again.
He quietly accepted them, then awkwardly rubbed the back of his neck.

Hozumi Hoshina
"...Thanks."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Y-you're welcome…"
Hozumi Hoshina
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Um... well... I guess… I'll head home..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Y-yeah. Bye-bye."
Hozumi Hoshina
"I… I'll see you on Friday."

After saying that in a hurry, Hozumi-san rode off on his bicycle as if he were fleeing.
Wow, he's really fast... I didn't know a bicycle could move that quickly...
...Anyway, I'm just glad I managed to give them to him…
I wonder if Hozumi-san was happy about them.
...Since he likes sweets, surely he must have been.
But... most likely...
The sweets he received from Shizune-san were probably the ones that made him happiest…
That's only natural.
Shizune-san really is an incredibly charming girl.
She's cute, kind, has a great figure, and is so feminine.
Everything I have to work so hard for, everything I have to carefully cultivate and put on an act to achieve... she just has naturally.
That's why her heart must be pure and beautiful, too. She's probably only ever had wonderful experiences in her life.
That's the kind of person she is. That's why so many people are drawn to her.
She can simply be herself, and people will cheer her on for it.
Everything she does is praised.
I like Shizune-san, too.
So it makes perfect sense that Hozumi-san would fall for her.
Maybe there are people like Hozumi-san who wouldn't hate me. People who might even enjoy having me around.

But still... I probably won't ever have someone cherish me more than they cherish Shizune-san...
...At least, that's what I believe.
That's just how the world works.

Chapter 33: The long-awaited...

???
"..."
???
"...san…"
???
"...ki-san…!"
???
"...Anesaki-san…!"
???
"Wake up…!"

Someone shook me, jolting me rapidly back to consciousness.
I reflexively turned toward the voice and found Kuraguchi-kun sitting in the seat beside me, a hint of concern on his face.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Huh…? What…?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"..."

Kuraguchi-kun silently flicked his eyes toward the front.
Following his gaze, I turned in that direction… and locked eyes with the teacher at the front of the classroom.
A moment later, I realized everyone else in the classroom was looking at me too.
...Oh no... Could it be...?
Only then did it dawn on me that I'd fallen asleep in the middle of class.

Teacher
"Are you awake, Anesaki-san?"

The teacher smiled at me awkwardly.
I quickly stood up and straightened my back.

Nozomi Anesaki
"I'm so... so sorry…"
Teacher
"Hahaha, now that's something you don't see every day. Anesaki-san, falling asleep in class?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Sorry..."

Teacher
"Just don't push yourself too hard, okay? If you're tired, make sure you get some rest."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Y-yes…"
Teacher
"You can sit down now."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes…"

I bowed my head as I sat back down.
Maybe it was thanks to the goodwill I'd built up over time, but I wasn't reprimanded. Even so, the embarrassment was unbearable.
Falling asleep in class... What an unthinkable blunder for an honor student.
As soon as class ended, Miho came over with a smug grin on her face.

Miho Orikasa
"Heeey! It's pretty unusual to see you dozing off in class, Nozomi. What happened?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Well... the truth is... I haven't been sleeping very well these last few days..."
Miho Orikasa
"What? Pulling all-nighters to study?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"U-um... yeah, sort of..."

It wasn't quite the same thing, but it took a similar kind of mental effort.
I'd been staying up late every night so I could finish the mystery novels Hozumi-san had lent me.
I somehow managed to get through them all, but by the end, I was utterly exhausted.
...Still, I was feeling a little happier today.
After homeroom ended, I picked up the bag with the books and headed out of the classroom.

Mizuho Hoshina
"Ah, Anesaki-san."

It looked like he had supplementary classes today. Along with his schoolbag, he was carrying a study guide and a notebook.

Mizuho Hoshina
"Perfect timing. I wanted to talk about tomorrow..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ah, yes."

Tomorrow, at long last, is my movie date with Senpai.
Our previous plans fell through, so this will actually be the first time the two of us have gone out together…
I'm really looking forward to it, of course... but I can't help worrying that I'll somehow mess things up.

Mizuho Hoshina
"The movie starts at 1 PM, but we should probably get there about 30 minutes early, right?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Right."
Mizuho Hoshina
"Since we're already going out, why don't we have lunch together too?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Y-yes, that sounds great...! I'd love that...!"
Mizuho Hoshina
"Then maybe we should meet a little earlier. How about 11 AM at the station?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes! That works for me!"
Mizuho Hoshina
"Then let's do that. I'll let you know if anything comes up."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes! Well then, see you tomorrow...!"
Mizuho Hoshina
"Yeah, see you."

Senpai walked away with a smile on his face.
With all the details finally decided, the date (though, strictly speaking, it wasn't exactly a date) was starting to feel real.
Come to think of it... I'd been so engrossed in my books these past few days that I'd neglected just about everything else I was supposed to prepare.
I really need to make sure I take extra good care of my body and skin today.
With that thought in mind, I hurried toward the school gate.
The moment I spotted the person waiting outside, my pace naturally quickened.
My leg was perfectly fine now.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Yo."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hey, Hozumi-san. Long time no see."
Hozumi Hoshina
"It's not like it's been that long."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Yeah, I suppose."

It had only been three days since we'd last seen each other.
Maybe because we'd been seeing each other almost every day before that, those three days had felt strangely quiet... like there was something missing.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Anyway..."

Suddenly, Hozumi-san leaned his face closer to mine.

Nozomi Anesaki

"Wh-what?!"
Hozumi Hoshina
"...You look kind of pale."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh? D-do I...?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Are you feeling okay?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Well... I guess I'm a little sleep-deprived..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"You haven't been sleeping?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I mean, I have... but I've been staying up late a lot lately."

Thanks to that, though, I managed to finish all four books Hozumi-san had lent me.
Savoring my sense of accomplishment, I handed him the bag containing the books.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Here you go. Thank you for lending me the books."
Hozumi Hoshina
"You actually read all of them?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah."

"Hmph!" I puffed out my chest proudly.
However, Hozumi-san didn't seem particularly impressed.

Hozumi Hoshina
"So that's why… you weren't sleeping well."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Yeah, pretty much."
Hozumi Hoshina
"You really went all in on this, huh?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."

That off-hand remark rubbed me the wrong way a little.
Hozumi-san probably didn't mean anything by it, but for some reason, I couldn't help feeling like he was judging me.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Shall we go home now?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh... already?"

…Wait, what am I even saying?

Nozomi Anesaki

"Never mind. Let's head home."

I climbed onto the rear rack of Hozumi-san's bicycle.
As usual, I wrapped my arms around his waist, and Hozumi-san glanced back at me.

Hozumi Hoshina
"...Are you free?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Do you have any plans after this?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"No... not really..."

Although, I really should read the original novel the movie we're seeing tomorrow is based on.
I'm about halfway through... Can I really finish it all today...?

Hozumi Hoshina
"? So you do have some plans after all?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ah, no? It's nothing important."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Then let's just wander around somewhere nearby."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Somewhere nearby? Where exactly is that?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Around here."
Nozomi Anesaki
"You're being pretty vague..."

I acted annoyed, but a laugh escaped from the back of my throat. ...Yeah, this is really kind of fun.

Chapter 34: Preparations for tomorrow

Even though he kept saying vague things like "somewhere nearby" or "around here," there was really only one option.
The only place nearby where we could wander around was the local shopping mall.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Ah."

While walking around the mall with Hozumi-san, I stopped in front of my favorite women's clothing store.

Nozomi Anesaki

"Can I look at some clothes for a bit?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Hm? Sure."

If I find something nice, maybe I'll buy it as an outfit for my date with Senpai tomorrow (technically it's not a date, blah blah).
...Though, when it comes to fashion, I usually rely on Shun to give me advice.
I'm not very confident in my ability to judge what actually counts as a "good outfit" on my own.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...What do you think would suit me?"

I ended up asking Hozumi-san for his opinion. It was a habit I had picked up from shopping with Shun.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Wait, you're asking me? Isn't this more of a girls' thing?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"The truth is... I'm not very confident about my fashion sense..."

Perhaps it was because I was talking to Hozumi-san. I'd forgotten about keeping appearances and just opened up to him honestly.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Huh, seriously? But you always look pretty cu—I mean, you always look fine to me."
Nozomi Anesaki
"That's because my brother picks my clothes."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Hmm. …Then how about this one?"

Hozumi-san flashed me a nasty grin and grabbed an item from the rack right beside us.
It is... way too revealing. What even is this? Is this really clothing? Isn't this basically underwear?
Just looking at the thing made me question the very definition of clothing.

Nozomi Anesaki
"I see."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...W-wait… why are you being so cold…?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"No... I was just thinking that you're a healthy young man, Hozumi-san."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Also, I have to admire how you can stand there looking so proud while holding something like that in a store full of women."
Hozumi Hoshina
"..."

Hozumi-san quickly put the item back on the rack. His cheeks were slightly red, which was kind of amusing.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Anyway, I think I have a pretty good idea of your preferences now, Hozumi-san."
Hozumi Hoshina
"W-wait, wait. Hang on."

Hozumi-san began picking out clothes with a serious look on his face.
After spending several minutes humming and pondering over his choices, he picked up one top and one bottom and held them out to me.

Hozumi Hoshina
"...How about this?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ooh."

This time, what he picked was a completely normal outfit. It was proper, wholesome, and very girly.

Nozomi Anesaki
"It's cute."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Right?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"But it still shows a lot of skin."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Th-there's nothing wrong with showing a little skin!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Okay, okay, I get it. No need to get so worked up."
Hozumi Hoshina
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hmm… So this is what you like..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Why is this even more embarrassing…?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Do you think Senpai would like something like this, too?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"? Mizuho?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Ah... I see. You're… going to the movies tomorrow, right?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Exactly."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Well, for him…"

Hozumi-san put the clothes he was holding back and took out a dress from a different rack.

Hozumi Hoshina
"I think he would like something like this better."

It had a much more elegant design than the clothes Hozumi-san had chosen himself.
I replied:

Nozomi Anesaki
"It looks like something Shizune-san would wear."

The moment I said that, Hozumi-san visibly jolted.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Huh... you think so?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"It's just the impression I got."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Hmm... I can't really tell, but... I think Mizuho would probably be into this kind of thing."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Do you think this would look good on me?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Yeah... I mean, I guess it would."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I see. Then maybe I'll go with this one."

I took the dress from Hozumi-san.
Then I went back and took the two pieces of clothing Hozumi-san had picked out earlier off the rack as well.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Huh…? You're buying these too?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh? Yeah."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Seriously…?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Y-yes…?"

Hozumi-san looked shaken for some reason. Seeing him like that was making me feel unsettled too.

Nozomi Anesaki
"No... I mean, I genuinely liked these clothes..."

After saying that, I quickly took the clothes to the register.

It wasn't like I was choosing them because they matched Hozumi-san's tastes or anything. Absolutely not.
After that, we wandered around for a while, played some games at the arcade, and then left the shopping mall.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Hehehehe."
Hozumi Hoshina
"You're pretty happy today."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Of course! I won another Lord Wald today!"

Today's prize haul from the arcade was a Lord Wald mug.

Hozumi Hoshina
"I was the one who won it though."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes, you're really good at this, Hozumi-san."

Just like last time, he got it on the very first try. It was so skillful and effortless that I was honestly amazed.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Right? Don't go falling for me now."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Not a chance."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Really? When I won it for you, you were all like, 'I love you, Hozumi-san! I love you so much!' "
Nozomi Anesaki
"I did not say all that."

Probably. ...To be honest, I was too excited at the time to remember properly.

Hozumi Hoshina
"By the way, what do you do with all these prizes?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hm? I display them."
Hozumi Hoshina
"But when I was in your room, you didn't have anything like that out."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Because I hide them in the shelves and closet..."

Even though I couldn't proudly display them, I collected them anyway. That's just the nature of being an otaku.
The Lord Wald figure Hozumi-san won for me made me so happy that I ended up putting it on display. But eventually, I'd have to put it away in the closet, too. Just in case anyone came over.

...Actually, yeah. I'd been hiding this side of myself for as long as I could remember.
I'd never had any intention of showing my otaku side to anyone besides Shun. Not ever.
And yet, here I was, casually talking about it with Hozumi-san. I found that strangely fascinating.
……
A silence fell between us for a while.

Hozumi Hoshina
"..."

...Still, I had a feeling Hozumi-san had been trying to say something this whole time.
So I waited patiently for him to speak.

Hozumi Hoshina
"...Anesaki. …I—"

And then, at last, Hozumi-san broke the silence.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"?! What?!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Could that be Senpai and Shizune-san...?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Huh…?"

Across the street, on the sidewalk in front of the park,
Senpai and Shizune-san were standing face-to-face and having a conversation.
They both looked strangely serious.
I wanted to know what was going on, but it didn't feel appropriate to interrupt.
Keeping our distance on the opposite side of the road, we walked past them.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...What do you think is going on?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"No idea... But yeah, something about it felt kind of off."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Right..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Are you curious?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh? I-I mean... maybe. I guess I am."
Hozumi Hoshina
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...By the way, Hozumi-san, what were you trying to say?"
Hozumi Hoshina

"Uh… Ah… No, forget it. It's nothing."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Really?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Yeah."

Chapter 35: An unexpected confession

The rest of the way passed in near silence, and before long, we arrived at my house.
I felt a little relieved to finally be free of that awkward tension.

Hozumi Hoshina
"...Well then... good luck tomorrow."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ah... yeah. Thanks for everything today."
Hozumi Hoshina
"You're welcome."
Nozomi Anesaki
"See you later."

I waved Hozumi-san goodbye and turned around.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Anesaki."

He stopped me.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Hm? What?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"...I've asked this before, but I'll ask it again."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Why... do you like Mizuho?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh…"

His unexpectedly serious question left me at a loss for words.
Why? Why was he asking me that again...?
I was more shaken than I expected.
Normally, I would have just casually said, "Because he's handsome," like I always did. But under his serious gaze, the words just wouldn't come out.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Why...? I mean, why are you asking this...?"

I couldn't really understand what was on his mind.

Hozumi Hoshina
"I'm just asking because I'm curious."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...What are you going to do with that information?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Maybe I'll do something. Depends on what you say."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Like what?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"That depends on your answer."
Nozomi Anesaki
"What's up with you…?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Just answer me. Why do you like Mizuho?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."

I thought about it a little.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...I told you already. ...Because he's handsome."

I ended up saying the first thing that came to mind.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Hmm... then..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Why don't you just date me?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Um…"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Hm?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I'm not really sure what you're saying."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...I'm saying you should go out with me. Forget about Mizuho."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"..."

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Huuh…?"

I could only stand there speechless.
What on earth was he saying all of a sudden...?

Nozomi Anesaki
"W-wait a second... How did you come to that conclusion?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"You like Mizuho because you think he's handsome, right?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Um... uh... yeah, I guess..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Then why can't it be me? We look the same. I'm handsome too, aren't I?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...*Sigh*..."

Yes, why not? You're handsome.
...Did you seriously think I was going to say that?!

Nozomi Anesaki
"R-rejected!!!"

I rejected him with all my heart.

Hozumi Hoshina
"...Why? You only like him for his looks, don't you?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I-it's not just his looks...! There's more... like how kind he is...!"

Once I said it, I realized that Hozumi-san was kind too.
Uhh... What other things do I like about Senpai...?
……

Nozomi Anesaki
"A-anyway! I like Senpai for lots of different reasons!"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Lots of reasons? Like what?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Just... everything! A lot of things!"
Hozumi Hoshina
"He and I are very alike, aren't we?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"You're totally different! I just... like Senpai more, that's all...!"

Wait a second... Everything about this situation is wrong.
Hozumi-san is in love with Shizune-san, isn't he?
It's not me he likes... right?

...Wait, hold on. The more I thought about it, the less any of this made sense…
Could it be... that Hozumi-san likes me?
Huh...? No… No way…
…Seriously?
Wait... that can't be...
I stole a glance at Hozumi-san's expression.

Nozomi Anesaki
"!"

My heart nearly stopped.
Wh-what...? Why is he looking at me like that...? Is he mad…?

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Hozumi-san?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"What?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Are you mad...?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Huh? I'm not mad."

...No, he was definitely angry. Anyone could see that. His expression was intimidating. His voice was lower than usual.
But I didn't know what had caused it.
As I stood there, dumbfounded, Hozumi-san put his foot on the pedal. The gesture was very rough.

Hozumi Hoshina
"I'm going home."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Huh? O-oh... yeah..."

...No, hang on a second.
That completely nonsensical conversation from a moment ago just... ended without any resolution.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Oh, about what I said before—it was a joke."

…What?

Nozomi Anesaki
"...A joke…?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Yeah."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...A-ah... I-I see... So that's all it was...?"

Hozumi Hoshina
"Why'd you take it seriously? Like I'd ever say something like that to you unless I was joking."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."

Well... I guess... that makes sense...
Hozumi-san liking me... that would be weird.
……
...But... Why am I getting kind of irritated...? What was even the point of messing with me like that...?

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Oh. Okay then. See you."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Huh? Are you mad about something?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Not really?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"You're obviously mad."
Nozomi Anesaki
"You're the one who's mad, Hozumi-san."
Hozumi Hoshina
"I'm not mad."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes, you are."
Hozumi Hoshina
"You're the one getting mad."
Nozomi Anesaki
"No, I'm not angry at all."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Your face says otherwise."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Your face is scary too!"
Hozumi Hoshina
"But why are you angry though?!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"You're the one who suddenly started snapping at me!"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Are you turning this around on me?!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"You're the one doing that!!!"

Hiss, hiss! We both glared at each other like two cats trying to intimidate one another.
And then Hozumi-san said:

Hozumi Hoshina
"Fine! Go screw around with Mizuho then…!"

Hiss! He threw out one last vulgar parting shot before storming off.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Wha... What is his problem?!"

What is he, an elementary school kid?! I don't get him at all! Ugh... either way, he's so annoying...!

Nozomi Anesaki
"I'm home!!!"
Shun Anesaki
"Whoa?! What's wrong?! What happened?!"

Shun, who had just come out of the living room, jumped when he saw me.

Shun Anesaki
"S-Sis? What's going on…?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Nothing."
Shun Anesaki
"Why are you angry...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I'm not angry."
Shun Anesaki
"...Did I do something?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"No."
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"...I'm sorry."

Shun suddenly bowed his head.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Huh? For what?"
Shun Anesaki
"...I… just ate your pudding…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"...I-I'll go buy you another one right now!"

Shun hurriedly put on his shoes and rushed out of the house before I could even stop him.
...Seriously, Shun... What kind of misunderstanding did he jump to...?
Well, whatever...
I took off my shoes and headed straight to my room.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Aaaargh!!! It's so annoying...!"

I threw myself onto the bed with a soft thump.
Honestly, I didn't even know why I was so angry or what exactly I was angry at, but either way, I was irritated.
This is bad... I need to calm down...
I turned my eyes toward Lord Wald sitting on display beside my bed.
……
It immediately made me think of Hozumi-san and I felt even more annoyed.
And then...
A ringtone suddenly started ringing from inside my bag.
I didn't pick up for a while, but it didn't seem like it was going to stop.
Ugh... what a pain... Who could it be...? I'm already irritated as it is...
I reluctantly reached into my bag and took out my phone.
Huh... it's Shizune-san. I wonder what this is about... That's unusual.
Feeling a little nervous, I quickly pressed the call button.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Y-yes…?"
Shizune Hiiragi
“...”
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Hello-hello…?"
Shizune Hiiragi
“...”
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Shizune-san…?"
Shizune Hiiragi
“...”

...? There was no response.
The call... it's still connected, though. Is the signal bad or something...?

Shizune Hiiragi
“...*Hic*…”
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hm? Hello-hello?"
Shizune Hiiragi
“...*Sniff*...”

...? What was that?
The moment I concentrated as hard as I could on listening...

Shizune Hiiragi
“Nozomi-shyaaaan…!”
Nozomi Anesaki

"?!"

The scream-like sob that came through the phone receiver made me jump.

Shizune Hiiragi
“Uuuhh…! Uuuh… Nozomi… Nozomi-shyaaan…!”
Nozomi Anesaki
"Wh-what's wrong?! Shizune-san?!"
Shizune Hiiragi
“Uuu... uuu... i-it... i... i' din'gowehhh... wehh…”

"D", "Dingoweh"?
Seriously, I can barely understand what she's saying.

Nozomi Anesaki
" 'Dingoweh'?"
Shizune Hiiragi
“Dingoweh… Dingowehll…”
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Wh-what happened? Why are you crying?"

And what are you saying?

Shizune Hiiragi
“*Hic*... uuu... th-that... um... wehhl..”
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Y-yes?"
Shizune Hiiragi
“I… I… owwwd Mijuho-kun…”

Translation: "I (unintelligible) Mizuho-kun"... Maybe?

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Is it about Senpai…?"
Shizune Hiiragi
“I... I got wejeeected...”

……
…Hm?
"wejeeected"?
"rejected"?
...WHAT?!

Nozomi Anesaki
"...C-could you say that one more time...?"
Shizune Hiiragi
“M-Mizuho-kun... r-re... rejec... rejected me... uuu... he rejected me...!”

This time, I heard it clearly. So it really was "I got rejected."
Wait a second... huh? How did things end up this way...?

Shizune Hiiragi
“Uuu... I knew... I knew it was going to happen, but... *hic*... it... it hurts... it hurts so much... *sniff*…”
Nozomi Anesaki
"...U-um... please, calm down... Take your time and speak slowly, okay? What happened…?"
Shizune Hiiragi
“O-okay…”

After that, I listened to Shizune-san's story, her words broken up by sobs.
It took quite a bit of effort to make sense of what she was saying, but the gist was this:
Apparently, on her way home today, Shizune-san happened to run into Hoshina-senpai along their usual route to school.
After some casual chat, Shizune-san tried to give Senpai the sweets she had made for club activities that day.
But he refused to take them. He gave some half-hearted excuse and simply shook his head.
When Senpai once again refused her sweets just a few days after turning down her cake, Shizune-san finally realized that something about him was different.
She kept asking him why he wouldn't accept them, until Senpai finally admitted the truth: he didn't like sweets.
Upon learning that she had been troubling him for so long, Shizune-san panicked and repeatedly apologized.
Naturally, Senpai only gave her his usual kind smile and told her, "It's fine. Don't worry about it."
But Shizune-san became convinced that he hated her. Still overwhelmed and confused, she ended up confessing her feelings to him.
"I like you," she said.
And then...
Senpai turned her down.
That was the whole story.

Shizune Hiiragi
“I really... I really wasn't planning to confess…”

After calming down somewhat, Shizune-san spoke again, sniffling softly.

Shizune Hiiragi
“Tomorrow was supposed to be your date with Mizuho-kun... Of course it would be wrong of me to confess my feelings knowing that…”
Nozomi Anesaki
"...You didn't have to worry about something like that..."
Shizune Hiiragi
“I... I panicked…”
Shizune Hiiragi
“But... I think... deep down... I was a little desperate too…”
Nozomi Anesaki

"Desperate?"
Shizune Hiiragi
“Y-yes... When I found out that you and Mizuho-kun were going on a date... I just couldn't calm down…”
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Shizune Hiiragi
“And so... I think... I ended up confessing…”
Nozomi Anesaki
"...I see..."
Shizune Hiiragi
“I'm sorry... I'm truly sorry... I was being selfish…”
Shizune Hiiragi
“But... it was just as I thought... Mizuho-kun really does have feelings for you, Nozomi-san…”
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Shizune Hiiragi
“It hurts so much... but... I... I'll try my best to give up on Mizuho-kun…”
Nozomi Anesaki
"...That's..."
Shizune Hiiragi
“Tomorrow... please enjoy your date, okay?”

In the end, Shizune-san ended the call in a clear, cheerful voice.
……
Senpai... rejected Shizune-san...? Why...?
...No, wait. That's right. I'd already suspected for some time that Senpai might have feelings for me.
So... was I right all along...?
……
...What is this feeling, I wonder.
It's not like I'm happy, or relieved, or anything like that.
If anything... It feels like the vague uneasiness that had been smoldering inside my chest these past few days only grew stronger.

It was almost midnight.
I was lying in bed with my face mask on, reading the book that the movie I was going to see tomorrow was based on.
I still had about a third of it left. On top of that, this book was by far the most difficult mystery novel I'd ever read.
……
Ahh... I can't focus at all...
Thoughts about Hozumi-san and Shizune-san have been endlessly circling through my mind.
Because of that, the contents of the book just aren't sinking in smoothly. I feel like I've been reading the same lines over and over again.

Nozomi Anesaki

"...*Yawn*..."

I let out a yawn that was half sigh and tossed the face mask into the trash.
My skin does feel moisturized, but it still seems to be lacking a little firmness... Well, I guess that's what happens when you run short on sleep.
I really should go to bed early tonight... I have to get up early tomorrow to get ready for the date, and I want to be in top shape.
But... I'll just read a little more…
I'll actually concentrate this time—

Hozumi Hoshina
"Why don't you just date me?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"~~~~!!!"

…Aaaargh!!!
Just thinking about it makes me angry...! Let me concentrate already...!
I forced Hozumi-san out of my head, opened my eyes wide, and focused on following the words on the page.
Concentrate. Concentrate, concentrate...!
Concentrate...
……
.....

Chapter 36: The designated day

Nozomi Anesaki
"!"

I snapped awake.
At the same time, a harsh artificial light flooded my vision, making me blink repeatedly.
Oh right, I fell asleep with the lights on…
What time is it?
5 AM.
Ugh… I woke up at such an awkward time…
I'm supposed to meet Senpai at 11 AM. Since we're meeting at the station, I'll have to leave home a little before 10:30.
Even if I give myself three hours to get ready… I still could've slept for another two hours or so…
But if I go back to sleep now, I'm not confident I'd be able to wake up at 7 AM.
Nothing I can do about it. Let's just get up…
I took a morning shower and headed back to my room.
I could feel it even in the shower… I'm more exhausted than I thought.
Maybe the lack of sleep over the past several days is finally catching up with me…
I never finished the book in the end… I'll read some more if I have time after I get ready…
I sat down at the table and peered into the mirror.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Eeek...!"

What the heck…? I look awful…!
My skin looks so dull, too. And don't I have faint dark circles under my eyes?
This is bad. My looks have seriously dropped to about C-tier…
Wh-what should I do…? Maybe I can somehow fix this with a massage and makeup?!
Anyway, I need to make my face look a little more presentable…! Ah… I'm so glad I woke up early…!

Shun Anesaki
"Sis?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"...Hey? Are you awake?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...I am..."
Shun Anesaki
"Can I come in?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Yes..."

Shun entered the room.
He saw me sitting with my head hanging down in front of the mirror and frowned.

Shun Anesaki
"...What's wrong?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...L-look… at my face…"

I slowly turned my face toward him.
He walked over, squinting slightly, and murmured, "Whoa."

Shun Anesaki
"You don't look well... Are you okay?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"…I-I knew it… I really do look awful, don't I…?"

Although I tried to hide my skin imperfections by making full use of foundation and concealer that I normally don't use, my makeup didn't sit well, and I felt like it ended up making me look even worse.

Shun Anesaki
"Maybe you'd be better off not wearing makeup?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"But… if I take it off… it looks really awful…"

I kept talking as I reluctantly wiped off my makeup.

Shun Anesaki
"Ah... It's not nearly as bad as you're making it out to be. You do look a little tired, though."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Right..."
Shun Anesaki
"But honestly, one'd have to be right up in your face to notice. It's nothing to stress over."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ugh… Today of all days... when I have a date with Senpai..."
Shun Anesaki
"You did the exact same thing the last time you went out with Prez. You got yourself all worked up and it backfired, am I wrong?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Th-that's so mean…!"
Shun Anesaki
"Yeah, yeah."

Shun stepped behind me and took a brush out of my makeup case.
Even though I hadn't asked him to, it looked like he was about to do my hair. He's such a good little brother. I was touched.

Shun Anesaki
"Take it easy. ...Just be yourself."

Shun casually said it as he blow-dried my hair.
Being myself...
Would I be accepted?
Would he come to like me?
...He?
As the time we'd agreed to meet drew near, I stood before the mirror by the front door and looked myself over from head to toe.
A decidedly unremarkable girl stared back at me.
...Such was the reality.

Shun Anesaki
"Well then... I should get going too."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh? You're going out?"
Shun Anesaki
"Yeah. I'm meeting up with some friends."
Nozomi Anesaki
"So that's why you got yourself up so early today."
Shun Anesaki
"...I'll be back by dinnertime."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hm... I see..."
Shun Anesaki

"Well... have fun."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Yeah, thanks..."
Shun Anesaki
"...Are you really sure you're feeling okay?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...I'm fine, I'm fine..."
Shun Anesaki
"Hmm… All right then... I'm heading out."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Take care."

Shun left the room.
I looked into the mirror once again.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...*Sigh*..."

I stepped outside.
Despite my own heavy, melancholy heart, the sky was bright and cloudless.
The harsh sunlight quickly drained my stamina bar.
I was not in the best shape, so I'd better make my way to the destination without wasting time.
Aah… It's so hot…
The sheer exhaustion was making my pace slower and slower.
Was the station always this far away…?
Actually…
I'm kind of sleepy… no… I'm just exhausted…
My head feels all fuzzy and dizzy. I just want to lie down…

Nozomi Anesaki
"..."

A sudden wave of dizziness hit me, and I sank down where I stood.
Everything went black before my eyes. Is it anemia?
I took a few deep breaths, and gradually, my vision returned to normal.
I felt sweat beading on my forehead. It wasn't because of the heat… This felt more like a cold sweat.
This isn't good… I'm starting to think I'm seriously unwell...
But staying hunched over here won't help. I need to find a way to keep going…
…All right.
I planted my feet firmly and forced myself to stand.
…Or rather, I tried to.
But then…

Nozomi Anesaki
"Ah…"

My vision suddenly faded into darkness once more.
My head was spinning, and my legs were trembling beneath me.
Ah… this is… actually really bad…
What should I do… I'm going to fall…
I can't see anything ahead of me… there's a ringing in my ears…
……
……
……

Chapter 37: Confession

I was lying on my back.
The surface beneath me felt comfortably familiar. It was probably my own bed.
It had been so hot just a moment ago, but now the cool air felt wonderful.
……
...Huh? Am I at home...?
I was supposed to be on a date with Senpai... I know I left the house... and after that...

Nozomi Anesaki
"!!!"

I bolted upright.

???
"?!"

At that moment, I sensed movement beside me. I looked over and…
……
……
……
…What?

Nozomi Anesaki
"Senpai…?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"..."

Senpai froze, his expression stiffening.
Why is he here...? What is going on...?

Nozomi Anesaki
"U-um...?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"Y-yeah…?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Why are you here, Senpai...? And more importantly, why am I at home...?"
Mizuho Hoshina

"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Mizuho Hoshina
"...Ah… I… I-I… Um…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."

…Aah.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...It's you, Hozumi-san…"
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Huh?!"

His face was practically screaming, "How did you know?!"

Nozomi Anesaki
"Why were you pretending to be Senpai...?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Well... I just... thought it'd be better that way..."

Hozumi-san avoided my gaze, his eyes shifting uneasily.
Watching him, I suddenly felt just as uncomfortable.
Then I remembered... We parted on such an awkward note yesterday...

Nozomi Anesaki
"U-um... why are you... here—actually, what time is it?!"

I jolted in realization and turned my eyes to the bedside clock.
11:10.
Oh crap, this is bad! It's already past the meeting time...!

Hozumi Hoshina
"...I already let Mizuho know."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"You... collapsed on the side of the road."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ah… Ooh…"

I see... so that's what happened. I definitely remember getting dizzy on my way to the station.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Could it be... that you were the one who found me, Hozumi-san...?"
Hozumi Hoshina

"…I saw someone collapsed on the ground, and then I realized it was you. I was seriously scared."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I see..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...So I decided to bring you back home, but... your brother wasn't here."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah... he's out right now..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"You also didn't lock your front door. That was really careless of you."
Nozomi Anesaki
"What? No way…"

Just how distracted was I…?

Hozumi Hoshina
"...So, um... I let myself in without permission..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...I'm sorry... You went through all that trouble for me... thank you."
Hozumi Hoshina
"I already let Mizuho know. He should be here any minute now."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Oh... really...? He's coming here...?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"He was really worried about you."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I see…"
Hozumi Hoshina
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."

Ah... this is so awkward...
How did things end up like this...?
After finally getting a chance to go on a date with Senpai...
I worked so hard to make it this far...
...So why does everything always go wrong for me?

Shun Anesaki
"You got yourself all worked up and it backfired."

...Shun was right after all.
I'm always trying too hard to be someone I'm not, so I'm constantly on edge. Even the smallest thing is enough to make me slip up.
I know that.
I'll never be naturally exceptional like Senpai or Shizune-san.
So I should just accept it and give up. But I can't. I'm still desperately trying.
Because if I don't try my hardest, he'll never love me.

...He?
I heard the doorbell ring.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Oh, sounds like Mizuho's here."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh…"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Well, I'm going home now. Take care."

Hozumi-san got to his feet and turned away.
But he stopped without taking another step.

Hozumi Hoshina
"...Huh?"

It was because I was holding onto Hozumi-san's sleeve. …I hadn't even realized I was doing it.

Nozomi Anesaki
"! Ah… um…"

I quickly pulled my hand back. Hozumi-san just stared at me, dumbfounded.
Ughhh... What am I doing...? This is embarrassing... so embarrassing...!
But still...

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Don't go."

I couldn't bear the thought of him leaving, so I honestly told him how I felt.
No... it's just... being alone with Senpai... it's kind of nerve-racking, you know...?

Hozumi Hoshina
"...Ah… Uh… Why…?"

Why does he always have to make me explain myself?!
I don't know how to say it... It's just... a feeling...
I stayed quiet, silently pleading with Hozumi-san.
I don't know what Hozumi-san made of my gaze, but...

Hozumi Hoshina
"..."

He quietly sighed, then turned away from me again.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Whaat?!"
Hozumi Hoshina

"?! What's wrong?!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"You're leaving?!"

At a time like this?! How heartless!

Hozumi Hoshina
"...N-no, I'm not leaving."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh…"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Mizuho's waiting outside, you know? I'll just go get him."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ah... oh... right..."

Right... unlike Hozumi-san, Senpai wouldn't just come inside someone's house without permission...

Hozumi Hoshina
"Well, I'll be right back."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes… Thank you."

Hozumi-san walked out of the room.
Right after that, I buried my face in my hands and squirmed.
When I thought back on what I had said and done, I felt so ashamed I wanted to die.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh… ugh…!"

I rolled around. I kicked and thrashed. Then rolled around some more…

Mizuho Hoshina
"Anesaki-san, are you all right?!"

He froze in place.

Mizuho Hoshina
"..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"..."
Mizuho Hoshina
"...Could it be... that you are hurt somewhere?!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...N-no, I'm fine, I'm fine..."

I can't believe someone saw me rolling around on the floor like that...

Mizuho Hoshina
"How are you feeling...? I heard you collapsed... Are you okay?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I-I'm okay now... I'm just a little tired..."
Mizuho Hoshina
"Heatstroke? Maybe anemia or something? I was so worried that I didn't think to buy anything..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"No, no... please don't worry about it..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Should I go get something?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"No... it's really fine..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"But you must want something, right? Aren't you thirsty or anything? Actually, I'm thirsty."
Nozomi Anesaki
"You can have anything you find in the fridge... It's in the living room downstairs."
Hozumi Hoshina
"All right, I'll go get something. For everyone."

Before we could say anything, Hozumi-san quickly left the room.
I suppose he was trying to be considerate, giving me and Senpai some privacy.
But I don't know... I have such mixed feelings about it...

Mizuho Hoshina
"Anesaki-san, are you really feeling okay?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes, I'm okay now. ...Um... Senpai..."
Mizuho Hoshina
"Hm?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I'm sorry things ended up like this..."
Mizuho Hoshina
"No, it's all right, don't worry about it. You couldn't help feeling unwell."
Nozomi Anesaki
"You even made reservations for the movie and everything..."
Mizuho Hoshina
"The movie's going to be in theaters for a while, so let's go when you're feeling better, Anesaki-san."
Nozomi Anesaki
"O-okay…"
Mizuho Hoshina
"Have you read the book?"

Senpai glanced over at the book sitting beside the bed.

Nozomi Anesaki
"I haven't read the last chapter yet."

Mizuho Hoshina
"I see. Well, experiencing the ending through the movie instead might be a fun, refreshing way to do it too."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Y-you're right."

I actually just couldn't finish reading it in time…

Mizuho Hoshina
"I was really happy, you know."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"I picked this movie because I liked it, but knowing you bought the book so we could enjoy it together… that made me really happy."
Mizuho Hoshina
"Thank you."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."

A warm, tingling feeling bloomed in my chest.
I'd been forcing myself to read it only because I wanted to get closer to Senpai... maybe it wasn't all for nothing after all...
Maybe all my efforts weren't in vain.
...I like Senpai.
His smile, his kindness... all these things remind me of Lord Wald.

Hozumi Hoshina
"But I think you have a chance."
Shizune Hiiragi
“Mizuho-kun really does have feelings for you, Nozomi-san…”

……
Is it really true...?
If it is true... then I...
I will…

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Senpai."
Mizuho Hoshina
"Hm?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I like you, Senpai."

To my surprise, I was able to say it quite easily.
And right after that...

Hozumi Hoshina

"?!?!"

As the door opened, a loud clatter echoed through the room.
The cups Hozumi-san was carrying on the tray fell, and tea spilled across the floor.
Senpai and I could only stare at Hozumi-san in shock as he finally spoke, going through a mountain of tissues from the box beside him.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Don't worry about me... Please continue…"

...Well... I tried to, but…
I couldn't stop glancing at Hozumi-san, who was desperately trying to clean the floor behind Senpai, and it was distracting.

Mizuho Hoshina
"...U-um… well…"

Turning his attention back to me, Senpai forced a smile.

Mizuho Hoshina
"...Did I just… hear that correctly…?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Yes."
Mizuho Hoshina
"...Uh…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...I-I like you, S-Senpai…"

I repeated it in a quiet mumble. It was hard to say with Hozumi-san around…

Mizuho Hoshina
"..."

Senpai stared at me with wide eyes.
A long silence followed.
The mood was tense and heavy, but I didn't feel anxious.

Mizuho Hoshina
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Mizuho Hoshina
"..."
Mizuho Hoshina
"...I'm sorry."

After a while, Senpai finally broke the silence.
I couldn't help but let out a quiet sigh.

It wasn't disappointment. It was a sense of relief.
...Ah... I knew it.
As those emotions welled up inside me, I felt my chest grow lighter.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Senpai…"
Mizuho Hoshina
"...Yes?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Why did you reject Shizune-san?"
Mizuho・Hozumi
"Huh?!"

Hozumi-san jumped up at the same time as Senpai.
He stopped wiping the floor and stared at Senpai with an expression of disbelief.

Mizuho Hoshina
"...U-um... How do you know about that...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Shizune-san told me over the phone yesterday."
Mizuho Hoshina
"Uh…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"She cried a lot."
Mizuho Hoshina
"..."

Senpai's expression twisted with pain.
...There it is. Just as I thought.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Senpai… you're in love with Shizune-san, aren't you?"

Deep down, I think I always knew it.
The gentle look on his face whenever he talked to Shizune-san, and the sorrowful expression that sometimes crossed his face…
He's never looked at me like that.

Mizuho Hoshina
"..."

For a while, he just stared at the floor in silence.

Mizuho Hoshina
"...Yes…"

He gave a small, resigned nod.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Then why... did you reject her?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"Because…"
Mizuho Hoshina
"...Shizune doesn't actually like me."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...What?"

…What is he talking about?

Nozomi Anesaki
"But didn't she confess to you…?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"...She did."
Nozomi Anesaki
"She said she liked you, didn't she?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"...Yes. ...But she's got it wrong."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Wrong…?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"...Shizune is not in love with me. She likes Hozumi."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Huuh?"

Hozumi-san was the first to react.
He slowly got to his feet and walked in our direction.

Hozumi Hoshina
"What the hell are you saying?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"She said she liked you. So what are you going on about?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Hey!"
Mizuho Hoshina
"...Hozumi, you're holding back because you're trying to spare my feelings, aren't you?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Huh?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"...You know Shizune has feelings for you, but you're pretending you don't because you don't want to hurt me, right?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"And I know… that you like her too."

Hozumi Hoshina
"You've read too many mystery novels and started seeing things that aren't there. Where is this foreshadowing you're talking about?"

Hozumi-san quickly rebutted him.
Although he said it in a joking manner, there was clear frustration in the way he looked at Senpai.

Mizuho Hoshina
"Back then..."

Senpai held Hozumi-san's gaze without flinching and started speaking.

Mizuho Hoshina
"You and Shizune both said that, didn't you?"

The room fell completely silent.
Hozumi-san didn't argue with that.
...I see. That means it's true...
I instinctively clutched my clothes. I felt a tight, squeezing pain in my chest.

Hozumi Hoshina
"...That was a long time ago. Things are different now."
Mizuho Hoshina
"Why are you holding back?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"You're the one who's holding back. I don't feel anything for Shizune anymore."
Hozumi Hoshina
"You tried to spare my feelings, dragging this out forever."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Shizune confessed to you and you like her back, right? So why the hell has this turned into such a complicated mess?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"You both like each other. Just get together already!"

Hozumi-san raised his voice in frustration.
In response, Senpai shot him an angry glare.

Mizuho Hoshina
"Shizune doesn't realize it."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Huh?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"She can't tell us apart."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...What are you talking about?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"It was you who liked sweets, but she always thought it was me."

Mizuho Hoshina
"...Back in middle school, she even called me by your name."
Hozumi Hoshina
"..."
Mizuho Hoshina
"Shizune loved you. You had feelings for her too, didn't you?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"So why did you suddenly start pushing her away?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"Why did you start treating her so coldly?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"Was it because you knew how I felt and decided to step aside?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"..."

Senpai's barrage of questions left Hozumi-san speechless.
I couldn't fully grasp what Senpai was saying.
But the fact that Hozumi-san had once been in love with Shizune-san... That truth weighed heavily on my heart.

Hozumi Hoshina
"...No."

After a few seconds of silence, Hozumi-san slowly shook his head.

Hozumi Hoshina
"I wasn't holding back. I'm not as selfless as you are."
Mizuho Hoshina
"...Then why didn't you return Shizune's feelings…?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"..."
Mizuho Hoshina
"..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Because she couldn't tell you and me apart."

Hozumi-san spoke in a calm, emotionless voice.
He met Senpai's frowning gaze and smiled slightly.

Chapter 38: Hozumi's past

Have you ever had to put effort into getting people to like you?
You haven't, have you?
You've always been the type people naturally gravitate toward. Ever since you were little, since kindergarten, even.
What's incredible is that it comes so naturally to you. You never have to try to make a good impression or win people over.

Everyone praises you for everything you do.
Even though you never sought that kind of attention.
We were twins, and yet I had almost nothing in common with you.
I wasn't as smart, there were only so many things I could do and I couldn't be kind to everyone the way you could. All of it really got on my nerves.
The most we had in common was our looks.
Because of it everyone assumed I was just like you.
They'd build up these expectations of me, only to end up disappointed.
People would say, "The older brother is so accomplished, but the younger brother is a disappointment."
Our parents were constantly telling me, "You should be more like Mizuho."
I hated it.
I envied you because everyone seemed to like you.
That's why I decided I wanted to become like you.
I studied diligently every single day.
I worked on every little thing you were good at and I wasn't.
I forced myself to be kind to people I didn't like.
I volunteered to do things I didn't want to do.
I watched my words. I tried to smile all the time, just like you.
And slowly, people's attitudes toward me began to change.
They started to like me.
People started showering me with praise at every opportunity.
Our parents were also happy about it.
To be honest, I was elated. It felt amazing.
But I made sure to appear humble, because that's what you did.
By the time we started elementary school, I had imitated every aspect of your personality until I was practically your exact copy.
It was around then that Shizune moved in next door to us.
When Shizune and her family came over to introduce themselves, I greeted them with the same friendly smile and polite bow I'd seen you give them.
It seemed like I made a good first impression on them.
They praised both of us, saying, "What polite, well-mannered boys you are."
I was pleased about that.
So I decided I'd keep trying to live like you.
From then on, I started seeing Shizune around the neighborhood fairly often.
Despite living next door, we weren't particularly close. We'd just exchange greetings whenever we happened to run into each other.
As time went on, I gradually started to develop feelings for Shizune.
In the sixth grade, she and I were placed in the same class.
At first, we barely spoke with each other.
I acted like you, but casually talking to girls just wasn't something that came naturally to me.
I think I only started talking to Shizune after you joined the same handicraft club as her.
At first, I only spoke to her when you were around. But eventually, we started saying hello to each other in class as well.
After that, I gradually found more and more opportunities to talk with Shizune.
And I fell in love with her.
Of course, I knew that you liked her too.
...But I never once thought about giving her up to you, not even for a second.

I acted like I was modest and considerate, but I was never as good a person as I pretended to be.
I wanted Shizune to like me, so I made an effort to be especially kind to her.
I showered her with praise for the sweets she made in the club.
When I found out that you and her shared an interest in mystery novels, I started reading them too.
Our conversations gradually became more enjoyable.
I began spending more and more time with her.
I started to think that Shizune might like me.
First year of middle school.
Keeping up the persona of "Mizuho Hoshina" was starting to become difficult.
The workload was heavier than in elementary school, and people began expecting more from me.
Naturally, you remained the perfect honor student.
You handled tedious responsibilities like being class representative and working on the student council with ease.
I continued putting in the same effort as before, but gradually, I began to realize I was reaching my limit.
It happened around that time.
It was a small, seemingly trivial thing.
The day we got back our first-term exam results.
I got my paper back, and I scored 90% on it.
It was far from a bad result.
With the average score being 60%, it was more than enough to put me among the top students.
But when Shizune looked at the test, she said, "That's unusual."
Because the standard for "Mizuho Hoshina" was a perfect 100%.
I laughed it off in the moment, but deep down, I felt something was off.
And then one weekend,
Shizune came over to our house.
When I returned with the drinks, I found you and Shizune enthusiastically talking about mystery novels.
I don't know why, but I hesitated to enter the room. I stood outside the door for a while.
And that was when I heard the one sentence from Shizune that changed everything.

Shizune Hiiragi
"I always enjoy talking with you, Hozumi-kun."

In that instant, something in me died away.
I realized that she didn't actually like me for who I was. She liked the version of me that was like you.
Everything suddenly felt so pointless.
That's why, starting that day, I gave up trying to be like you.
I started doing what I wanted to do.
I stopped studying until late at night.
I started sleeping when I felt like sleeping and having fun when I felt like having fun.
I also stopped forcing myself to be kind to people I didn't like.
I stopped volunteering for things that were a hassle.

I stopped forcing myself to laugh at things I didn't find funny.
I went back to speaking naturally.
Obviously, everything around me changed.
Everyone unanimously called it "rebelling."
I was no longer praised.
At first, Shizune couldn't understand why I had changed and repeatedly tried to get an answer out of me. But over time, she began to distance herself from me.
She never loved me for who I truly was.

Hozumi Hoshina
"...Do you understand now?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"She couldn't tell the difference between you and me."
Hozumi Hoshina
"No, that's not quite right. The truth is, Hozumi Hoshina never existed to her at all."
Mizuho Hoshina
"..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Shizune has been in love with you all along."

Hozumi-san delivered the words calmly but firmly to his stunned brother.

Mizuho Hoshina
"...But…"

Senpai still had a conflicted look on his face.
Seeing that, Hozumi-san ran a hand through his hair in frustration.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Seriously, why are you still hesitating…? You're so frustrating."
Mizuho Hoshina
"Wha—"
Hozumi Hoshina
"You say you like Shizune, yet you keep acting all nice to every other girl. How many idiots do you think are going to mistake that for something more?"

…You meant me, didn't you?

Hozumi Hoshina
"Being kind to everyone might be one of your best qualities, but that's the part of you I can't stand."
Mizuho Hoshina
"..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"You like Shizune, don't you? Then what are you waiting for? Go to her."
Mizuho Hoshina
"..."
Mizuho Hoshina

"...I will."

Senpai nodded firmly, then turned to me with an apologetic look.

Mizuho Hoshina
"I'm sorry, Anesaki-san… for everything…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"N-no, no, it's fine. Please go talk with Shizune-san. You can still catch the movie if you hurry, I really hope the two of you can enjoy it together."
Mizuho Hoshina
"...Yes. Thank you."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Of course."
Mizuho Hoshina
"...I'm really glad you told me how you feel, Anesaki-san."
Nozomi Anesaki
"…You're always kind to everyone, Senpai. I like that about you. "
Mizuho Hoshina
"...Hahaha, thank you."

Senpai gave me a wry smile, reached for the door, then looked back at Hozumi-san.

Mizuho Hoshina
"Hozumi."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Hm?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"We were really close back then, weren't we?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Yeah. I used to be a good younger brother."
Mizuho Hoshina
"But honestly, I like the person you are now more."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Huh?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"Now you seem a lot more comfortable in your skin. It's nice to see you being yourself."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Whatever. I get it, so just go already."
Mizuho Hoshina
"...Okay. See you."

Senpai gave us his usual princely smile before leaving the room, looking as carefree as ever.

Hozumi Hoshina
"...Unbelievable... he's almost too good to be real."

Hozumi-san grumbled under his breath, glaring at the doorway where Senpai had disappeared.

The room suddenly fell silent, and we both remained quiet.
I wanted to talk about something, but I didn't know what to say.
A lingering uneasiness still weighed on my heart.

Hozumi Hoshina
"...Uh... well… you know..."

Hozumi-san nervously turned toward me.

Hozumi Hoshina
"...How are you feeling?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh... ah, y-yeah... I'm mostly fine now…"
Hozumi Hoshina
"…But you don't really seem all that well."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Really…?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"You look really pale."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Uh…"

Right. I look like a complete mess today.
This is awful… I don't want Hozumi-san to see me like this.
I instinctively turned away and looked down, and then I heard him let out a small sigh.

Hozumi Hoshina
"...Listen."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"If you're feeling sick, actually take some time to rest, okay?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Okay."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Don't push yourself too hard."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."

It was just an offhand comment.
There probably wasn't any deeper meaning behind it.
He had simply said the first thing that came to mind. That was probably all there was to it.
And yet, for some reason, those words made my chest feel incredibly warm.
Maybe I didn't have to force myself anymore.
Maybe I could still be someone he cared about without constantly striving to earn it.
Maybe he could truly like me, instead of simply not hating me.
That was when I finally realized.

I finally understood what that strange irritation I'd felt yesterday had been, and what this lingering feeling in my heart really meant.
I… I was in love with him.

Chapter 39: The self I am for you

Hozumi Hoshina
"…Ah, right. How about some tea?"

Hozumi-san suddenly remembered the cup of tea he'd dropped on the floor and brought it over.
Since he'd spilled the other cups earlier, this was the only one that still had any tea left in it.

Nozomi Anesaki
"…Hozumi-san, you're thirsty, right? You can have it."
Hozumi Hoshina
"No, it's okay. I'll get some later. You need to drink to stay hydrated."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Okay…"

I reached out to take the cup from Hozumi-san, and…

Nozomi Anesaki
"Wah?!"

A splash of something cold hit me in the chest. Hozumi-san's hand had slipped, causing the tea in the cup to spill.

Hozumi Hoshina
"M-my bad!!!"

Hozumi-san grabbed another huge wad of tissues, balled them up, and started wiping my clothes.

Nozomi Anesaki
"W-wait, hold on!"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Huh?!'
Nozomi Anesaki
"Where are you putting your hands?!"
Hozumi Hoshina
"..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"?!"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Your chest!!!"

Hozumi-san let out a high-pitched cry and immediately pulled his hand away.

Nozomi Anesaki
"J-jeez... I'll do it myself. Give me the tissues…"
Hozumi Hoshina
"O-okay…"

Hozumi-san held out the tissues to me, his face bright red.
For some reason, I felt my own face starting to heat up, too.
And to think he once asked, "Can I touch your butt?" with a completely straight face.
If you keep acting like this, my otome-addled brain will start to get the wrong idea.
Don't get my hopes up.
Because…

Mizuho Hoshina
"And I know… that you like her too."

I was still affected by it.
I knew Hozumi-san no longer had feelings for Shizune-san.
But hearing that made me realize all over again that his type was someone like her.

Hozumi Hoshina
"...I'm sorry."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...What?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"I… spilled the tea."
Nozomi Anesaki
"…I-it's okay, really…"
Hozumi Hoshina
"…There's something else I need to apologize for."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Something else…?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"…Yeah."

Hozumi-san sat up straight, as if bracing himself, but he still couldn't meet my eyes.
He looked like he was hiding something he felt guilty about.

Hozumi Hoshina
"…You heard what I said earlier, so I think you already understand."
Hozumi Hoshina
"I knew that Mizuho liked Shizune."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Yeah."
Hozumi Hoshina
"I intentionally made you believe that you had a chance with him."
Hozumi Hoshina

"I knew you were going to be rejected, but I still acted like I was cheering you on."
Hozumi Hoshina
"The two of them were stuck going nowhere, so I decided to use you as a way to bring them together."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...At first, I didn't really think anything of it."
Hozumi Hoshina
"But you… you were trying so hard. You kept pushing yourself way past your limits."
Hozumi Hoshina
"At some point, I realized that what I'd done was wrong. …I do regret it, for what it's worth."
Hozumi Hoshina
"I'm sorry for getting your hopes up."

Hozumi-san lowered his head in a sincere apology.
Watching him, I found myself at a loss for words.
So that's how it was... I was just a pawn in all of this.
I see...
I get it now...
Honestly... this guy...

Nozomi Anesaki
"Scumbag."

I spat the word out.
Normally, Hozumi-san would have reported with, "You little shit," but now, he said nothing.

Nozomi Anesaki
"You really are the worst."
Hozumi Hoshina
"…I know."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Toying with someone's feelings like that… it's absolutely despicable."
Hozumi Hoshina
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Seriously… I still can't believe you're Hoshina-senpai's twin."
Hozumi Hoshina
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"You two may look alike, but that's where the resemblance ends."
Hozumi Hoshina
"…Yeah… my bad."
Nozomi Anesaki
"You're nothing like Senpai. You're crude, foul-mouthed, and just plain rude."
Nozomi Anesaki
"You're trash, an idiot, and a shithead."

Hozumi Hoshina
"..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"H-hey, aren't you going too far…?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Am I wrong?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"I know it already! You don't have to keep rubbing it in…!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Shithead!"
Hozumi Hoshina
"...What did you just say, you little shit?!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"You're the piece of shit here!"
Hozumi Hoshina
"You know, you keep calling me crude and all, but you're pretty bad yourself!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I know that!"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Your mouth's no better than mine! Most people don't just casually call someone trash, a scumbag, or a piece of shit!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I'm only saying it because it's the truth!"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Seriously... you don't even try to be cute with me…!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Gee, sorry about that...!"

Sorry I'm not like Shizune-san!
I added silently in my head, and immediately felt a wave of sadness wash over me.
What am I even doing…?

Hozumi Hoshina
"...Honestly... you're so damn annoying."

Hozumi-san spat the words out in irritation.
For a moment, I felt a flash of anger and was about to snap back—but stopped myself.
I bit my lip and glared at Hozumi-san, but he quickly looked away.

Hozumi Hoshina
"You're a slowpoke."
Hozumi Hoshina
"A total klutz."
Hozumi Hoshina
"You're smart, but somehow you're still an idiot."
Hozumi Hoshina
"You're insensitive."
Hozumi Hoshina

"And an obsessed fangirl."
Hozumi Hoshina
"You're always going on and on about Mizuho."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Mizuho is all you ever think about."
Hozumi Hoshina
"You're always praising him."
Hozumi Hoshina
"You even said that you like him more."
Hozumi Hoshina
"..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...You seriously piss me off."
Hozumi Hoshina
"..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Just fall for me already."

He said it in a barely audible voice.
So softly that his words were almost impossible to make out.
What?
What did he just say?
I widened my eyes and stared at Hozumi-san, and he turned back toward me with an annoyed expression on his face.

Hozumi Hoshina
"...I like you."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Even if you are a little shit."

……
……
……

Nozomi Anesaki
"...No way."
Hozumi Hoshina
"..."

Hozumi-san looked away again, his face still bright red.

Nozomi Anesaki
"H-hey... say it again."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Wh-what? You didn't hear me the first time...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I heard you, but... it just caught me so off guard that I didn't really get to savor it..."

I desperately wished reality had a backlog feature with voice playback.

Hozumi Hoshina
"What the hell does that even mean...? I don't get it."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Never mind that. Just say it again."
Hozumi Hoshina
"No."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Why?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Because it's embarrassing."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...You're such a chicken."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Shut up. No way I'm saying it."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Say it!"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Nope, not gonna."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...If you won't say it, then I'm not saying it either."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Huh?"

Hozumi-san turned toward me, and I quickly looked away.
I was probably bright red right now.
There was no way he wouldn't realize how I felt about him.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Huh… No way…"

...Exactly.

Hozumi Hoshina
"...Say it."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...No."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Seriously? Come on, it's just one time."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I refuse."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Say it."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I said no...! I'm not saying it until you do...!"
Hozumi Hoshina
"That's unfair! I'm the only one who's had to say it so far...!"

Nozomi Anesaki
"Come on, if you say it, I'll say it twice for you..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"You say it twice first!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I told you, you go first!"
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Funny, you had no trouble saying it twice to Mizuho."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ugh..."

...It wasn't really me confessing my feelings. It was more like I was trying to confirm how I felt…
That's why I only learned it just now.
A true, genuine confession takes an incredible amount of courage.
I could never manage those smooth, romantic lines and exchanges you get in otome games.

Hozumi Hoshina
"...All right."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hm?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Then let's say it at the same time."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"That way it's fair, right?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"W-well... I guess..."

Is that really the issue here? I don't think so...

Hozumi Hoshina
"All right... Are you ready?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh... y-yeah, okay."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Ready, go."
Hozumi・Nozomi
"..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Hey!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"What?!"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Say it!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"You should say it too!"

Hozumi Hoshina
"You don't look like you are about to say anything!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I-I don't know when to start!"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Immediately after 'ready, go.' "
Nozomi Anesaki
"Immediately after... okay..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Well?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"O-okay."
Hozumi Hoshina
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Ready, go."
Hozumi・Nozomi
"I…"
Hozumi・Nozomi
"..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Th-that was just practice. That's the timing we're going with, okay?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...O-okay."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Next time is the real thing, so you'd better say it. Seriously."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I said I will. You make sure you say it properly too."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Yeah."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."

I braced myself and took a deep breath.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Ready, go!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I like you!!!"

……
Hm?

Nozomi Anesaki
"W-wait... Did you just say it, Hozumi-san?"
Hozumi Hoshina

"I did."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Liar! You definitely didn't say it!"
Hozumi Hoshina
"I said I did."

He tried to play innocent, but with his face bright red and that smug grin, he had absolutely no chance of convincing me.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Y-you're the worst!! Why didn't you say it?!"
Hozumi Hoshina
"If I said it at the same time, you wouldn't have really heard it."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...You're absolute trash! You idiot!!!"
Hozumi Hoshina
"...But you like me anyway, don't you?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ugh..."

He's absolutely right.
I like Hozumi-san, even though he's a shithead, an idiot, and a total scumbag.
He is nothing like Lord Wald or Hoshina-senpai, yet somehow, I fell for him anyway.
I glared at Hozumi-san, grumbling under my breath. He suddenly stood up, looking quite satisfied with himself.

Hozumi Hoshina
"All right, then let's go hang out."
Nozomi Anesaki
"H-huuh...? That's awfully sudden..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Well, you look fine now."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I guess I am feeling better now, but still..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"I'll make up for that missed date with Mizuho."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Where are we going?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Somewhere nearby."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"What's with that weird look on your face?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I was just thinking… It's our first date, yet it's nothing special."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Da…"

He blushed.

Hozumi Hoshina
"...Is there somewhere else you want to go...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"No. Not really. Could you get another Lord Wald for me?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"...That guy again, really…? I guess I don't have a choice..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yay! I love you, Hozumi-san!"
Hozumi Hoshina
"You can't just say that like it's nothing."
Nozomi Anesaki
"All right, I'm going to change, so leave the room and wait outside."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Huh? Your outfit is fine as is."
Nozomi Anesaki
"It has tea stains on it."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Oh..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Don't peek."
Hozumi Hoshina
"I've already seen your panties three times anyway."

Hozumi-san headed out of the room, grumbling under his breath.
I cheerfully flung open my closet and pulled out the outfit I'd bought yesterday.
Clothes are nothing more than decoration, really.
Hozumi-san probably wouldn't care what I wore anyway.
But I still want to look a little cute.
Not for everyone. Just for him.

Happy end: White relation

I changed into my brand-new outfit and did a little spin in front of the mirror.
Perfect. The clothes feel great, and they look good on me too.
I still looked a little sick, but there was no point worrying about it now. It's whatever.
I picked up my bag and reached for the doorknob.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Sorry I kept you waiting!"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Took you long enough."

Hozumi-san, who had been waiting outside the room, turned around.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Oh…"

Then he froze in place, his eyes widening in shock.
Hehehe, now that's the reaction I wanted. I proudly puffed out my chest.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Well?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Does it suit me? Do I look cute?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Y-yeah... not bad."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Oh…"

I never expected him to just openly compliment me like that, and my heart skipped a beat.

Hozumi Hoshina
"This just proves that my fashion sense is the best."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Sure, sure. I'll let you have that one."

I tried to play it off, but the corners of my mouth curled up into a grin.
I'm glad he thought I looked cute.

Hozumi Hoshina
"It's way too hot... I really don't feel like walking."
Nozomi Anesaki
"By the way, you didn't bring your bike today?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"No, I left it where you collapsed. I'm going to pick it up now, so we'll have to walk until then."

...Right. He couldn't have carried me home while riding his bike, could he?

Nozomi Anesaki
"Then... Hozumi-san, how did you get me home?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Piggyback."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Oh wow."

...That's so embarrassing.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Wasn't I heavy?"
Hozumi Hoshina

"Of course you were heavy. You were unconscious, after all."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hahaha... yeah, that makes sense. Sorry you had to carry me in this heat. Thanks."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Eh, it's fine. In return, you'll have to forgive me for touching you in various places while I was carrying you."
Nozomi Anesaki
"HUH?! What?! What did you do to me while I was unconscious?!"
Hozumi Hoshina
"I-I didn't do anything on purpose! I just couldn't help touching you when I was carrying you on my back!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Where exactly did you touch me?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Your legs and... your arms... It's not like I had a choice. I was carrying you."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I guess so."
Hozumi Hoshina
"And... your butt."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."

In the end, he got what he wanted, huh…

Hozumi Hoshina
"I was careful, okay? But it just happened, I can't undo it...!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Well... yeah, I suppose that was unavoidable."

It happened because he was trying to carry me home, after all. And besides…

Nozomi Anesaki
"...You're my boyfriend now, so I guess it's okay if you touch me a little."

As soon as I said it out loud, I suddenly felt embarrassed.
Boyfriend... right. Hozumi-san... is my boyfriend.
A 3D boyfriend. An actual real boyfriend.
Wow... I'm happy, but it still doesn't feel real. What a weird feeling.

Hozumi Hoshina
"..."

Hozumi-san was blushing too.

Hozumi Hoshina
"...I see. Then let me touch your butt."

His usual embarrassed act was still going strong.

Nozomi Anesaki
"I wonder how things turned out for Senpai and Shizune-san."

Was he able to talk things through with her?
I hope everything worked out between them.

Hozumi Hoshina
"They're probably all over each other by now. I mean, these two were always lovey-dovey."

Immediately after Hozumi-san said that…

Shizune Hiiragi
"Nozomi-saaaaaaaan!!!"

A voice suddenly called out from behind us.
I turned around and saw Shizune-san sprinting toward us at full speed.

Shizune Hiiragi
"Nozomi-san!!!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Wah?!"

Before I could react, she threw herself at me and wrapped me in a hug with all her momentum. Her chest… so soft…

Mizuho Hoshina
"Shizune… you're so fast…"

A moment later, Senpai showed up, breathing heavily.
If the two of them are together... I guess things really did work out. I'm glad.

Shizune Hiiragi
"Nozomi-san... Nozomi-san...! Um, um, you see...!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Y-yes? What is it?"
Shizune Hiiragi
"I-I... um... just now... Mizuho-kun... invited me to see a movie with him...!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hehe, that's wonderful."
Shizune Hiiragi
"Yes! ...Ah, no! That's not what I mean! I have something to tell you…!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"? What is it?"
Shizune Hiiragi
"I-I... well... Mizuho-kun and I..."

Shizune-san fidgeted nervously, unable to meet my eyes. She was struggling to get the words out.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Are you and Senpai a couple now?"

Shizune-san's face suddenly turned bright red.
She stepped back a little from me and slowly shook her head with a troubled look on her face.

Shizune Hiiragi
"N-no... we're not..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...What?"
Shizune Hiiragi
"W-we're... not together."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Huuh?"

Hozumi-san interjected.
He turned to Senpai with a look of disbelief.

Hozumi Hoshina
"There is no way... You still haven't told her how you feel?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"No, no, that's not it..."

Senpai sighed, looking exhausted.

Mizuho Hoshina
"I confessed, I really did... but Shizune wouldn't believe me no matter what I said..."
Mizuho Hoshina
"I told her over and over, and she finally seemed to accept it, but..."
Mizuho Hoshina
"Then she said, 'I can't be with you until I've talked things over with Anesaki-san.' "
Hozumi・Nozomi
"..."

Good grief, those two are taking forever.
They're truly two of a kind, always worrying about everyone else's feelings before their own.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Shizune-san, you have feelings for Senpai, don't you?"
Shizune Hiiragi
"Y-yes... I do... But you love Mizuho-kun too, so..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Hey, you dummy."
Shizune Hiiragi

"Y-yes?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Seriously, what kind of nonsense is that?"
Shizune Hiiragi
"Wh-what do you mean...? I didn't say anything strange..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Listen. She doesn't like Mizuho anymore."
Shizune Hiiragi
"Huh…?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"She's crazy about me. Completely head over heels for me. Seriously, Mizuho doesn't even exist in her mind anymore."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Right?"

Hozumi-san turned around to look at me with a smug, confident grin.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Nope."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Huh?! Hey! What do you mean?!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ah, sorry. You were so full of yourself that I couldn't resist messing with you."
Hozumi Hoshina
"You jerk... seriously... don't scare me like that..."

Hozumi-san slumped his shoulders, looking genuinely relieved.

Hozumi Hoshina
"...Do you like me?"

He asked with a hint of doubt in his voice.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Y-yes… I do."

This time, I answered him honestly and nodded.

Hozumi Hoshina
"..."

Come on, you were the one who asked, so why are you getting all shy? Now you're making me embarrassed too.

Mizuho Hoshina
"Whaat…?"

Senpai stared back and forth between us, looking completely dumbfounded.

Mizuho Hoshina
"When did that even happen...?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Well, that's how it is. So you two can stop worrying, go ahead and be lovey-dovey."
Shizune Hiiragi
"I-is that really true, Nozomi-san...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes... it's true."
Shizune Hiiragi
"Th-then... would it really be all right for me to be with Mizuho-kun...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Don't be silly, I already told you that you don't need my permission. And honestly, I'll be happy if you and Senpai become a couple."
Shizune Hiiragi
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Well?"
Shizune Hiiragi
"Nozomi-san!!! I love you so much…!"

She hugged me again.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Hehe. Come on, you should be hugging Senpai like this instead."
Shizune Hiiragi
"! Mizuho-kun..."

She stepped away from me and turned to face Senpai.

Shizune Hiiragi
"M-Mizuho-kun..."
Mizuho Hoshina
"Y-yes?!"
Shizune Hiiragi
"I love you..."
Mizuho Hoshina
"Ah... y-yes... me too..."

It looked like they were too embarrassed to actually hug, so they just stood there, fidgeting awkwardly with flushed faces.
…Goodness.

Hozumi Hoshina
"What a pair of lovebirds…"

Indeed.

Shizune Hiiragi
"Oh, I know...! Since we're all here, why don't we all go see a movie together?"
Mizuho・Hozumi・Nozomi
"Huh?"
Shizune Hiiragi
"A double date! I'm sure it'll be lots of fun!"
Mizuho Hoshina
"I'm all for it, of course..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...What do you think?"

Hozumi-san shot me a quick glance.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Sure, I don't mind."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Hmm… Well, all right then."
Shizune Hiiragi
"Then let's head out right away!"

Shizune-san skipped off happily.
Senpai walked alongside her, and before long, the two of them naturally intertwined their hands.

Hozumi Hoshina
"...These two… are so shamelessly lovey-dovey…"

Hozumi-san muttered to himself as he glared at their backs.
I agreed with how he felt, but I also found myself feeling a little envious.

Hozumi Hoshina
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Hey."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...What?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"...I'm your boyfriend, right?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Uh… yeah…?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"So that means you'll let me get away with touching you a little, right?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Hm? Y-yeah…?"

I tensed my backside, bracing myself for his next move.

Hozumi-san reached out and grabbed my hand a little roughly.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Whoa."

His hand squeezed mine tightly.
I looked up at Hozumi-san in a daze, while he kept his face turned forward, only his eyes shifted toward me.

Hozumi Hoshina
"...It's fine, right? Just holding hands."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Y-yeah."

I was sure that we also looked like a pair of lovebirds to people... With that thought, I squeezed Hozumi-san's hand in return.
However…

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Hozumi-san…"
Hozumi Hoshina
"...What?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"We'll be riding the rest of the way, right?"

Before we knew it, we had reached the place where Hozumi-san's bike was parked.

Hozumi Hoshina
"..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"That was so quick."

HOZUMI EPILOGUES

Epilogue 1: Us, as usual

Hozumi Hoshina
"Nozomi, you're especially adorable today."
Hozumi Hoshina
"If you keep looking at me with those eyes... I won't be able to restrain myself..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"I want all of you..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Nozomi… I love you…"
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Pfft…"

Hozumi-san's body shook as he laid on the bed. It looked like he was trying to hold back his laughter.
I stopped writing the equation and cast a cold look at him.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Could you stop? I can't focus on studying like this."
Hozumi Hoshina
"You're cute even when you're mad, Nozomi."
Nozomi Anesaki
"J-jeez…! Seriously, quit it...!"

I got up and snatched the game console out of Hozumi-san's hands.
He propped himself up, looking annoyed.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Why did you do that? I was just getting to the good part."
Nozomi Anesaki
"What good part? You were just messing with me the whole time."

Hozumi-san wouldn't stop begging, so I reluctantly let him try an otome game... and now look at him.
He was dramatically reading every single one of Lord Wald's lines out loud while I was dying of embarrassment.
On top of that, he kept saying my name over and over... I know it's only a line from the game, but still…
Since he usually calls me by my last name, hearing him say my first name is almost too much for my heart to handle.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Give it back. It hasn't even been 5 minutes."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I'm sure you've already gotten the gist of it."
Hozumi Hoshina
"It's fun. I want to keep playing."
Nozomi Anesaki
"You mean it's funny because of how absurd it is, right?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"No, I'm actually enjoying it. I totally feel like a romantic heroine right now."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Hmm… Okay, wait a moment."

I opened the game's system settings screen and changed the protagonist's name.
Then I returned the game console to Hozumi-san.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Here you go. Enjoy."
Hozumi Hoshina

"Yeah."

Hozumi-san pressed the button on the game console again, a grin spreading across his face.

Hozumi Hoshina
" 'Can I kiss you, Hozumi?' "
Hozumi Hoshina
"..."

Hozumi-san silently closed the lid of the game console and sighed.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Oh? Are you done already?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"...I got plenty of enjoyment out of it."

Contrary to what he said, Hozumi-san's expression was gloomy.
It seems having Lord Wald's romantic lines directed at him was a bit too much to handle.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Do you… always play this game?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Y-yeah... so what? Is that a problem?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"No, it's not a problem. I just don't think I'll ever understand the appeal."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I'd rather you didn't understand it anyway, so that's fine."
Hozumi Hoshina
"I mean, isn't this Lord Wald guy way too cheesy?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Wha—! N-no, it's fine...! That's exactly why he's great!"
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Really? If this guy existed in real life, he'd be kind of scary."
Nozomi Anesaki
"These games are supposed to give you the kind of comfort you can't get in real life, so it's okay for them to be exaggerated...!"
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Can't get in real life…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"That's right. It's not like you're exactly the romantic type..."

It's been a few weeks since we became a couple.
But not much has changed between us.
We hold hands occasionally, but we've never hugged or kissed.
We don't even have those sweet little exchanges that lovers are supposed to have.
The only time Hozumi-san has ever told me he likes me was when he first confessed to me.
Basically, our relationship doesn't feel romantic at all.

It's not like I want Hozumi-san to be as over-the-top sweet as Lord Wald, but... I wouldn't mind a little more affection every now and then.
I shot Hozumi-san a light glare, hoping he'd understand what I meant. He nervously looked away.

Hozumi Hoshina
"...My bad. I'm just not used to this kind of thing, okay…?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Not used to it...? So were you always like this with the girls you dated?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Huh? The girls I dated…? You mean yourself?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh, y-yes. Actually, no... I meant your girlfriends before me."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Huh? I never had any."
Nozomi Anesaki
"What?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"What?"
Hozumi・Nozomi
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Huh?! Really?!"

I definitely didn't see that coming.
I'd always assumed Hozumi-san had had a girlfriend or two by now.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Wait... is that really so surprising…?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I mean... you seem like you'd be popular."
Hozumi Hoshina
"I was. Back in elementary school."

In other words, he was only popular back when he was putting on an act.

Nozomi Anesaki
"You mean you're not popular with girls anymore?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"I barely talk to them in the first place."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Still, you've had girls come onto you, haven't you?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Most girls lose interest after talking to me for a bit."

So he's really that off-putting to them, huh...?
...Well, to be fair, when I first met Hozumi-san, I also thought I'd never want anything to do with him again.

But now that I've gotten to know him, it's hard to imagine him not being popular. Then again, maybe that's just the bias of someone who's fallen for him.
Either way, this is a pretty nice surprise.

Hozumi Hoshina
"...What are you grinning about?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Nooothing? I was just thinking how lucky I am that you're such a scumbag."

If he weren't like that, someone else might have taken Hozumi-san away from me by now.

Hozumi Hoshina
"...What about you then? I'm guessing you've got plenty of experience, huh?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"What?!"
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Oh yeah, now that I think about it, you're kind of popular yourself, aren't you? You're the school's innocent little idol, after all."

Hozumi-san shrugged, looking less than pleased.
Apparently, he's gotten it into his head that I'm some kind of experienced, popular girl who has everything figured out.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Just so you know... I'm no different from you."
Hozumi Hoshina
"? No different how?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I mean... you're my first... boyfriend."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Huh? Ah… Really?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Y-yeah..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Didn't you say you were a seasoned expert in romance?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ah... th-that was... I was talking about games..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Huh?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I've only ever experienced romance through otome games..."

It wasn't like I'd never had anyone confess their feelings to me.
I'd been approached by plenty of guys, and I knew I was fairly popular.
But I'd never found anyone who could captivate me more than Lord Wald, and somewhere deep inside, I'd resigned myself to the idea that I'd never become close to anyone.

Hozumi Hoshina

"..."

Hozumi-san stared at me blankly. Feeling embarrassed, I lightly pouted.

Nozomi Anesaki
"I know... You probably think I'm cringe, don't you?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"...No, not at all... If anything..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...I was thinking that I'm glad you're like this."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh…"
Hozumi Hoshina
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...I-I see."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Yeah…"
Hozumi・Nozomi
"..."

I started feeling restless.
...This was like one of those rare moments we had right before holding hands.
A rare moment when we actually felt like a couple.
But...

Hozumi Hoshina
"..."

As I expected, Hozumi-san didn't make a move.
It looked like he wanted to say something, but all he did was sit there in silence.
I wasn't any different, though. I stood there frozen in place, unable to do anything.
I had no idea what I was supposed to do in moments like this.
I was just as inexperienced when it came to real-life romance.
The only experience I had was being passionately pursued by love interests in otome games.
What am I supposed to do when the other person doesn't make a move?
...Should I take the initiative?
.....
A-all right...

Nozomi Anesaki
"H-Hozumi-san!!!"

In one sudden motion, I threw my arms around Hozumi-san as he sat on the bed.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Whoa?! H-hey…!"

I must have caught him off guard, because he couldn't support my weight and fell backward.
This is less of a hug and more of a tackle...
...Actually, wait.

Hozumi･Nozomi
"..."

What am I supposed to do now...?
I only wanted to hug him, I wasn't trying to push him down.
So, naturally, I hadn't thought at all about what to do after this.

Hozumi Hoshina
"..."

Hozumi-san simply looked up at me, his expression tense.
Ugh… Why won't he do anything...?
I-if things have come to this...!

Nozomi Anesaki
"Tickle, tickle, tickle."

I decided to tickle his side.

Hozumi Hoshina
"?! Wait, stop... ah... hahaha!!!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Tickle, tickle, tickle."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Ha… Stop, I'm serious—pfft, hahaha!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Tickle, tickle, tickle."
Hozumi Hoshina
"H-hey... seriously, enough..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"I said stop!!!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Wah?!"

Hozumi-san grabbed both my arms, and in an instant, my world spun around.
Now Hozumi-san was on top, looking down at me.
And then...
It happened in the blink of an eye.
My vision suddenly darkened, and something touched my lips.
Soft, a little warm... A sensation I'd never known before.
That was…
By the time I realized it, my vision had already cleared again.

Hozumi Hoshina
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."

...Uh... um...
Th-that was... a kiss, wasn't it?
We actually kissed just now... didn't we?
Wh-what am I supposed to do now...?
Still too stunned to respond, I watched as Hozumi-san began to fidget uneasily.

Hozumi Hoshina
"...W-well...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Aren't you... gonna say something...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Wh-what am I supposed to say...?"

No, really.
It was over so fast that I couldn't really tell what it was like.

Hozumi Hoshina
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Aaaaah, I can't take this!!!"

Hozumi-san suddenly shouted, then dug his fingers into my sides...

Nozomi Anesaki
"Fwah?!"

And started tickling me mercilessly.

Hozumi Hoshina
"That's payback for earlier."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hahahaha!!! Wait, stop—ahhahaha!!!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"St—stooop! Foh, foh—ha, haha… haa!"
Hozumi Hoshina

"...You're making such weird noises…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I mean—hahaha! Hyo—hyahaha!!! Hahahaha…!"
Hozumi Hoshina
"..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Pfft... I can't... this is too funny."

Hozumi-san's face took on a mischievous, almost wicked grin as he got carried away and started tickling my sides again.
The sweet mood that had filled the air just moments ago vanished in an instant.
We'd finally had such a nice moment, too... Well, I guess this is fun in its own way.
I trembled as I reached for Hozumi-san's side, determined to get my revenge.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Bwah!!!"

Hozumi-san burst out laughing.
But he had no intention of stopping.
We kept tickling each other and making ridiculous noises, with not a hint of romance between us.

Hozomi・Nozomi
"Hyaaahaaah!!!"
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
(...Seriously, what are they even doing…?)
Shun Anesaki
(...I want to know, but…)
Shun Anesaki
(...I-I have to resist...!)

Epilogue 2: An adolescence in passing

It happened shortly after the start of the second semester.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Hello."

I arrived at the student council room later than usual and found the other members gathered around a desk, discussing something.

Mizuho Hoshina
"Ah, Anesaki-san, hello."
Treasurer
"You're a little late today."

Nozomi Anesaki
"Sorry... homeroom ran longer than usual. Have you already started?"
Secretary
"No, not really."

Each of the seniors had a similar-looking sheet of paper in front of them.

Nozomi Anesaki
"What are those?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"They're the results from the nationwide mock exam we took during summer break."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ohh…"

Oh, right. The seniors are preparing for their entrance exams. There are plenty of mock exams around this time of year.

Treasurer
"I got a B rating for T university… That's not ideal."
Mizuho Hoshina
"There's still plenty of time before the exams. It's not over yet."
Nozomi Anesaki
"So you're not planning to go to Sasajiin University?"

I heard that more than 80% of the students at this school go on to the affiliated university every year.
Most of my friends were apparently planning to attend Sasajiin University as well, so I rarely saw anyone worried about their mock exam ratings.

Treasurer
"I'm aiming for T university. Well, I'm trying, at least."
Secretary
"I'm aiming for K University."
Mizuho Hoshina
"I'm going to Sasajiin University."

That caught me off guard.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Hoshina-senpai, are you really staying on at Sasajiin?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"Yes."
Nozomi Anesaki
"But… you still seem to be studying quite a lot."

He's attending cram school and regularly taking supplementary classes.
Simply put, students from this school have a secure path to Sasajiin University. They can enroll regardless of their grades through the school's internal advancement system.

Even if he were aiming for a highly competitive faculty, I feel like Senpai could get in without much trouble...

Mizuho Hoshina
"Hmm... It's not really for the entrance exams. I just study because I have some free time and nothing else to do."
Nozomi Anesaki
"What?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"Seeing how seriously everyone applying to other universities was studying, I felt like I couldn't just sit around doing nothing."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Wh-wha…?"
Secretary・Treasurer
"Mr. Perfect."

Indeed.

Mizuho Hoshina
"Have you decided what you're going to do after graduation, Anesaki-san? You're only a second-year, so maybe you haven't thought about it yet."
Nozomi Anesaki
"No, I'm also planning to go to Sasajiin."
Mizuho Hoshina
"Oh, nice. So we'll be in the same university in two years. See you there."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes."

So Senpai is also staying on at Sasajiin.
I wonder what university Hozumi-san is aiming for... Then again, does he even plan on going to university?
I never considered that before.
Just as the student council meeting was wrapping up, I got a text from Hozumi-san.

Hozumi Hoshina
“I'm waiting at the gate.”

As usual, his messages were about as plain as they come.
But honestly, if Hozumi-san started sending emojis or cutesy emoticons, it would just feel weird. This curt style suits him just fine.

Mizuho Hoshina
"Was that Hozumi?"

Senpai, quick to catch on, asked me about it.
I nodded, feeling a little bashful. Hozumi-san and I had already been together for a few months, so it was kind of silly to still feel embarrassed about it.

Mizuho Hoshina
"All that's left is locking up, so you can go on ahead."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Sorry... I always leave that to you."
Mizuho Hoshina
"Don't worry about it. Just take good care of Hozumi for me."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Of course. I'll be heading out, then."

Come to think of it... it feels like it's been quite a while since I last saw Hozumi-san.
The last time was during summer vacation... about three weeks ago, I think.
We were hanging out all the time at the beginning of summer vacation, but halfway through, he suddenly stopped asking me out.
We'd still been texting pretty often, so I hadn't given it much thought...
But what if... he's starting to get tired of me...?
During the first semester, he'd come meet me after school almost every day... but now that the second semester has started, this is the first time he's done so.
……
Oh no... Now I'm starting to worry... What if the first thing he does when we meet is tell me he wants to break up…?
Oh, please no... I can't handle bad endings! I always force-skip them whenever they come up in games...!
Lost in my anxious thoughts, I found myself outside the school gates before I knew it.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Hey. Long time no see."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Y-yeah... Hi. It's been a while."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...You look kind of tired. Is everything okay?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"No, I'm fine."

From what I could tell, Hozumi-san seemed exactly the same as always. Maybe I'd just been overthinking things.
I relaxed my shoulders and hopped onto the rear rack of the bike.
At that moment, Hozumi-san let out a quiet sigh.
I couldn't help but flinch, and he glanced back at me with a confused expression.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Hm? What's up?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"N-no, it's nothing."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Hmm?"

Hozumi-san turned back around and started pedaling.
What was that about...? That sigh just now...

Nozomi Anesaki
"Hozumi-san, what have you been up to these past three weeks?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Hm? Mm... not much."

Hozumi-san answered in a strangely evasive tone.
I could tell he was giving off a definite "don't ask any more questions" vibe.
...Yeah, Hozumi-san really did seem a little different from usual. He was quieter than normal, too.
It felt like he was keeping something from me... or that something was bothering him...
D-don't tell me it's that...?
That he's been trying to figure out how to tell me he wants to break up...?
...Ugh... The more I thought about it, the more convinced I became that something like that was happening...
Lost in my spiraling thoughts, I found myself home before I knew it.

Hozumi Hoshina
"...Later."

In the end, Hozumi-san didn't bring up whatever was on his mind. He simply turned to leave.
If there really was nothing wrong, I'd be more than happy. But leaving things with such an obvious awkwardness between us made it impossible for me to relax.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Hozumi-san, is there something you wanted to tell me?"

I instinctively called after Hozumi-san, stopping him in his tracks.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Huh?"

That reaction told me I was right.

Nozomi Anesaki
"If there's something you need to say... I'll hear you out..."

…Even though I'm scared.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Ah... I mean, it's not really a 'serious conversation' or anything..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Okay…"
Hozumi Hoshina
"It's just... this probably isn't the best place."

He nervously glanced around the area.
Ugh... I knew this wasn't going to be a casual conversation... I'm terrified...

Nozomi Anesaki
"Then... um... do you want to come inside?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Is Shun home?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Would that be a problem?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"No, it's fine… I just don't want to deal with him right now."

They're always bickering whenever they run into each other… Though, to be fair, it's usually because Shun provokes him.
I pressed the doorbell.
After waiting for a little while and getting no response, I turned back to Hozumi-san.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Looks like he's not home."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Then I'll drop in for a bit."

After we settled into my room, Hozumi-san still didn't say anything for quite a while.
We sat across from each other with the table between us, the silence stretching on.
Then his phone rang in his bag.
Hozumi-san pulled it out and briefly furrowed his brows at the screen.
He muted the ringtone with a tap before setting his device down on the floor without much care.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Are you sure you don't want to answer?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"It's fine. I know what it's about."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hmm…"
Hozumi Hoshina
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...So, what happened?"

I finally managed to get us talking, but the serious look on Hozumi-san's face only made me more uneasy.
Just when I started thinking, "I really don't want to hear this," Hozumi-san slowly sighed and started talking.

Hozumi Hoshina
"...So…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Y-yeah?"
Hozumi Hoshina

"...I was wondering if you could... help me with my studying..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Huh? Studying?"

That was so unlike Hozumi-san that I couldn't help but blink in surprise and reply with a question.
I mean... come on. Just look at how he'd acted up until now.
He was always going out, even though he was supposed to be studying for his entrance exams.
Even during exam period, he went about his life as if nothing had changed.
He'd play otome games right beside me while I was working hard on my summer homework...
I don't know what he was like at school, but at least when he was with me, he never once brought up anything related to studying.
I'm sure he's no different at home.
I can vividly imagine Hozumi-san sprawled out, casually reading Zump while Hoshina-senpai studies away at his desk next to him.
Actually, I once asked him outright, "Shouldn't you be studying, Hozumi-san? You're taking entrance exams, aren't you?"
But back then, Hozumi-san had only given me some overly dramatic answer like, 'I'm going to live freely and stay true to myself (striking a cool pose),' the kind of thing you'd expect from a perpetual adolescent.
And now that same Hozumi-san is asking me to help him with studying? Did he bump his head or something?

Hozumi Hoshina
"Well, it's just..."

Hozumi-san seemed to realize how unlike himself he sounded, and he stumbled over his words as he tried to explain himself.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Well... I'm kind of in trouble, in a bunch of ways."

...That wasn't an explanation at all.

Nozomi Anesaki
"What exactly is wrong? ...Wait, are you saying you might not graduate?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"No! You've got it wrong! It's not that! ...That's not what I'm talking about..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hm?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"...I guess I'm paying the price for my stubbornness… or something like that..."

Stubbornness? What does he mean by that?

Hozumi Hoshina

"W-well... anyway... um, yeah. I have an assignment that's due tomorrow, but I can't solve some of the problems."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ohh. I thought you usually just winged your homework."
Hozumi Hoshina
"This one's different. If I don't do it properly, I'll be in a lot of trouble..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I understand. I'm totally fine with helping you out... What kind of problems can't you solve?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Uh, well..."

Hozumi-san pulled a file out of his bag.
Seeing him with actual paperwork in his hands... it just felt completely wrong.

Hozumi Hoshina
"These are third-year level questions. Do you know how to do them?"

Saying that, he pulled a worksheet out of the file.
As he did, a familiar-looking piece of paper came out with it.

Hozumi Hoshina
"...Ah!"

Hozumi-san made an "I messed up" expression, hurriedly turned the paper face down, and slipped it back into the file.

Hozumi Hoshina
"...You saw it?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"No, I didn't."
Hozumi Hoshina
"You've got sharp eyes. There's no way you didn't see it."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Well, okay, I did see it, but I didn't really get a good look at it."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Ah, I see…"

Hozumi-san sighed in relief, then started preparing his writing utensils and notebook.

Nozomi Anesaki
"..."

I lied. I saw it. I got a perfectly clear look at that paper just now.
It was the same paper the seniors had been looking at in the student council room earlier today—the results of the nationwide mock exam.
I immediately lied and said I hadn't seen it because it felt like I'd accidentally caught a glimpse of something I wasn't supposed to see.
Right…

Image:
(You need 212 more points for a B rating.)
The letter "E" next to his desired university...
Isn't that really bad? Getting an E this late in the year... doesn't that basically mean there's no hope...?
...No. That wasn't what surprised me the most. What shocked me more than anything was...
Hozumi-san... was aiming for Sasajiin?!

Hozumi Hoshina
"...Anesaki? Are you listening?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ah, wh-what?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"This question. Do you know how to do it?"

Hozumi-san turned the worksheet toward me. It was obviously a mock exam question sheet.
He said it was an assignment he had to turn in, but that was almost certainly a lie. He just wanted to review his mock exam.
Knowing Hozumi-san, I never thought I'd see the day... but had he finally decided to seriously commit himself to studying?
In other words... was he actually planning to take the entrance exam for Sasajiin University?

Nozomi Anesaki
"Let's see... math. ...Oh, yeah, I think I can handle this one."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Wait, seriously? You're amazing. You haven't even studied this unit yet, have you?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah, technically, it's third-year material, but you're basically just applying stuff we learned in second year."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Are all the people at Sasajiin like this?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"No, I'm just a genius."
Hozumi Hoshina
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hey, you were supposed to poke fun at me. Now I just sound like a prick."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...I mean, it's true, though."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...D-don't say that so seriously. It's creepy. I'm not really a genius or anything. I just study harder than other people."
Hozumi Hoshina
"You're planning to go to Sasajiin University, aren't you? You have a guaranteed pathway, so why do you work so hard?"

Despite asking that, Hozumi-san seemed to immediately figure out the answer.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Ah, right. It's for your 'image,' isn't it?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah. But honestly, I think it's mostly just become a habit now. I feel restless if I'm not studying."
Hozumi Hoshina
"You're kind of like Mizuho..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"That's an insult to Senpai."
Hozumi Hoshina
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Do you know that he's also planning to go to Sasajiin?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"I do."

...Oh. So he already knew.
And yet Hozumi-san was aiming for Sasajiin too. …Hmm. The more I thought about it, the less sense it made.
After all, it had already been a huge surprise to learn that he was actually planning to take university entrance exams like everyone else.
But what surprised me even more was that he'd chosen Sasajiin.
I knew his parents had always told him, "You should go to the same university as Mizuho."
And every time they said it, he'd push back with, "No way in hell."
That's why I'd always thought Sasajiin was the one university he'd never consider... Had something happened to change his mind?
Had he finally reached the point where he couldn't resist his parents anymore...?

Hozumi Hoshina
"So, how do I solve this one?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ah, okay, so—"

...Well, if Hozumi-san is serious about this, then I'll do everything I can to support him...
An E rating, though... I'm a little worried. Is he going to be okay...?
After going over a few of the questions from the mock exam, Hozumi-san put away his writing utensils with a relieved look on his face.

Hozumi Hoshina
"I think I mostly get it now. Thanks."
Nozomi Anesaki
"What about the next one? Do you need help with that too?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Nah, I'm good. I can just use the same approach as the problem we just did, right?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Oh, yeah, exactly."

I think he really understood it well.

After teaching him, I realized that Hozumi-san wasn't bad at learning at all.
He used to get good grades, after all... So it's not like he's completely incapable of studying...
Still, that letter 'E' kept looming in my thoughts. I wonder what his chances of getting into Sasajiin are if he's getting an E rating at this point in the year...

Hozumi Hoshina
"All right, I'm heading home now."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Already? It's only been half an hour... You can stay a little longer."
Hozumi Hoshina
"No, I'm good. I don't want to deal with Shun when he comes back."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Haha…"

Well, I do find it a hassle to calm those two down, so I kind of agree.

Hozumi Hoshina
"All right, see you."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah, see you."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Are you feeling better now?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"You seemed kind of down."

Well... honestly, I should be the one asking that. Hozumi-san's strange behavior made me start jumping to conclusions.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Hozumi-san…"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Hm?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Do you…"

"...love me?"
Yeah, like I could ever bring myself to ask that!
If this were a game and that option appeared, I'd pick it without a second thought. But saying a line like that out loud in real life... that takes some serious courage.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Never mind..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Hmm? Well, if there's something you want to talk about, tell me. I'll listen."
Nozomi Anesaki

"...You sounded like a real boyfriend just now."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Not 'like' one. I am one."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Hehe."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...What's with you? You're creeping me out."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I'm just glad you didn't tell me you wanted to break up or something."
Hozumi Hoshina
"H-huuuh…? Why would you even think that?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I mean... we haven't seen each other in a while... and you've been acting kind of weird today..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"So I started bracing myself for all kinds of possibilities..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Why— Don't always assume the worst... Makes me look stupid for already thinking about next year and all..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Next year...? Hozumi-san... I didn't think you were the type to stick with something for that long..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Seriously, are you a hopeless romantic or a realist? I can't figure you out..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I-I like you too, Hozumi-san... I'll probably still like you next year, too..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Why 'probably'?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...I've never stayed obsessed with one character for a whole year before..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...So even that Lord Wald guy will have been abandoned by a year from now... Poor thing..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"What? Of course I'd never get tired of Lord Wald. I'll love him forever."
Hozumi Hoshina
"You're sure about that one, huh?"

After delivering this sharp retort, Hozumi-san adjusted the strap of the bag he was holding.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Anyway, just so you know, I'm not planning on breaking up with you."
Nozomi Anesaki
"O-okay..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...The reason I haven't been seeing you lately is... well, I've just been kind of busy..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Oh…?"
Hozumi Hoshina

"It's really not a big deal, so don't worry about it."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Okay. I won't."
Hozumi Hoshina
"All right, then—"

Just as Hozumi-san was about to wave goodbye, he suddenly stepped closer.
The look in his eyes was serious. The atmosphere suddenly felt soft and intimate.
This... this feels like he's about to kiss me...!

Shun Anesaki
"What the hell are you two doing in the entryway?!"
Hozumi・Nozomi
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"At least go to your room! Why are you making me watch this?!"
Hozumi Hoshina
"That wasn't what we were trying to do."

Hozumi-san sighed, then reached into his pocket and pulled out a Hi-Chew.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Here. You can have it."
Shun Anesaki
"...Tch."

Shun clicked his tongue but accepted the Hi-Chew anyway.
It was like Hozumi-san was taming him with treats... He'd gotten surprisingly good at dealing with Shun lately.

Hozumi Hoshina
"See ya."

Before Shun could start griping again, Hozumi-san made a quick escape through the front door.

About two hours later...
When I got back to my room after dinner, I heard an unfamiliar electronic beep.
What is that...? It's not my phone's ringtone...
Curious, I followed the sound to its source.
I crouched down and peeked underneath the table… And there it was.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Hozumi-san... you left your phone behind..."

The word "Home" was displayed on the screen.
I wasn't sure whether I should answer Hozumi-san's phone without permission, and as I hesitated, the ringing eventually stopped.

A few seconds later, "Home" appeared on the screen again.
Hmm... Maybe Hozumi-san had noticed his phone was missing and called it from home?
After a moment's hesitation, I touched the screen to answer the call.

Woman's voice
“Hozumi?! Where are you? What are you doing?! Are you still out fooling around?!”
Woman's voice
“We need to have a talk, so get home now!!! That university preference form... what exactly were you thinking?!”
Woman's voice
“I understand that you don't want to go to the same university as Mizuho. But I won't let you give up on university altogether!!!”
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."

This is... Hozumi-san's mother, isn't it?
What am I supposed to do...? I can't find a chance to interrupt. Actually... I probably shouldn't have answered this call in the first place...

Hozumi's mother
“Hozumi?! Are you listening?!”
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Hozumi's mother
“Hozumi?! Answer me!!!”
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Hello."

I couldn't stay silent any longer, so I timidly spoke up.
A terrifying silence followed.

Hozumi's mother
“Huh...? Oh goodness... Did I call the wrong number...?”
Nozomi Anesaki
"N-no! You have the right number...! It's Hozumi-san's phone...!"
Hozumi's mother
“A– Uh-huh...? Really...? Then where is Hozumi?”
Nozomi Anesaki
"Umm... it looks like Hozumi-san left his phone behind. I'm holding onto it for him right now..."
Hozumi's mother
“Oh, I see. So that's what happened. Um... and you are...?”
Nozomi Anesaki
"I'm…"

What should I do...? Is it okay to just say, "I'm Hozumi-san's girlfriend!"...?
It's kind of embarrassing... but I don't know what else to call myself... Hozumi-san's... friend?
Hmm... but I feel like I should properly introduce myself...

Hozumi's mother
“Oh... wait! Are you... Anesaki-san?”
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh? Y-yes, I am..."
Hozumi's mother
“Oh! Just as I thought! Thank you for always looking after Hozumi.”
Nozomi Anesaki
"N-no, not at all… The pleasure is all mine…?"

I was so confused that my response came out sounding like a question. Hozumi-san's mother then continued in a gentle voice that was a complete 180 from the one she'd used earlier.

Hozumi's mother
“Mizuho told me about you two. I never imagined that someone like Anesaki-san would look after my stupid son…”
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ah… haha... no... um..."

How does she know about me...?
...Ah, Senpai has probably mentioned me before. Maybe he's told her that I'm a capable junior or something.

Nozomi Anesaki
"I'm sorry for not introducing myself sooner. My name is Nozomi Anesaki. I'm Hozumi-san's girlfriend."
Hozumi's mother
“Oh my... You're so polite. And I'm really sorry about that sprain.”
Nozomi Anesaki
"No, don't worry, it was nothing serious. I'm okay."
Hozumi's mother
“Has Hozumi been causing you any trouble?”
Nozomi Anesaki
"N-no, not at all. He's always been very good to me."
Hozumi's mother
“I'm sorry about earlier... I suddenly started talking about things you probably didn't understand.”
Nozomi Anesaki
"And I'm sorry I didn't respond right away. Um... has Hozumi-san still not made it home?"
Hozumi's mother
“No, he hasn't... Anesaki-san, do you have any idea where he might have gone?”
Nozomi Anesaki
"No... We parted ways about two hours ago. I assumed he went straight home afterward..."
Hozumi's mother
“Ugh… Honestly... he's always wandering off and causing trouble…”
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ahaha... By the way, should I bring Hozumi-san's phone over to you?"
Hozumi's mother

“No, no, I'll have Hozumi go pick it up once he gets home. Could you hold onto it until then?”
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ah, of course. Understood."
Hozumi's mother
“If Hozumi ends up coming to your place first, could you ask him to come home right away?”
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes, I'll tell him."
Hozumi's mother
“Ah... and… there's one more thing I'd like you to tell him.”
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes?"
Hozumi's mother
“Just tell him this: 'You can choose wherever you want to go, but you must go to university and graduate.' ”
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh…"
Hozumi's mother
“That boy... he never listens to me. I'm only asking you to get this one thing through to him.”
Nozomi Anesaki
"Y-yes, I'll make sure he knows."
Hozumi's mother
“Well then... he's a bit of a handful, but please look after him.”
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Yes. I'll do my best."
Hozumi's mother
“Goodbye.”
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes, goodbye."

I ended the call and sighed. Man... that was nerve-wracking...
Still, what did she mean by "giving up on university"...? Wasn't Hozumi-san planning to to Sasajiin...?
I was still puzzling over it when the doorbell rang.
Could it be Hozumi-san?
I hurried to the front door, and sure enough, Hozumi-san and Shun were arguing again.

Shun Anesaki
"What do you want?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"I'll leave right away. Where's Anesaki?"
Shun Anesaki
"I'm Anesaki too, you know."
Hozumi Hoshina
"…I meant Nozomi."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I'm here, I'm here!"

I quickly stepped between the two of them, and Shun disappeared upstairs with a sulky look on his face.
My little brother is surprisingly good at reading the room.

Nozomi Anesaki
"You came here to pick up your phone, didn't you?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Yeah, that's right."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Then where have you been for the past two hours?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Huh?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Your mom called. She said you need to come home right away."
Hozumi Hoshina
"H-huuuh?! …Really?!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Did she say anything else? Anything strange?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"She didn't say anything strange, really..."

I remembered the other thing Hozumi-san's mother had asked me to tell him, but I hesitated.
I wasn't sure if this was the right time to bring it up.

Hozumi Hoshina
"...What is it? Did she tell you something?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Um... I have a question for you."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Sure."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Are you not planning to go to university?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Huh?"

Hozumi-san stared blankly for a moment.
After a short pause, his expression turned sour, as though he'd realized what was going on.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Ah... so my mom told you."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Ugh... She just went and looked at my career survey without asking..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"What did you put on it?"

Hozumi Hoshina
"...Nothing. I just wrote 'none.' "
Nozomi Anesaki
"Wait... so you really aren't planning to go to university after all?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"That's not what I said."

Hozumi-san rejected the assumption at once, then faltered through the rest of his explanation, struggling to find the right words.

Hozumi Hoshina
"I only wrote that I don't have a university I'm applying to. I never said I was giving up on university entirely."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hm? What do you mean?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"I mean..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"I'm not applying this year. I'll take the exams next year."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh..."

I mulled over Hozumi-san's words. So... does that mean he's planning to take a gap year and try again...?

Hozumi Hoshina
"You saw that thing, didn't you?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"What thing?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"...My mock exam results."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ah... uh... no... I didn't really look at it that carefully..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Bullshit. It was obvious. You were giving me that pitying look, and it pissed me off."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Yeah, that's right! I got an E rating for Sasajiin! So what?!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Don't take it out on me."
Hozumi Hoshina
"There's no point in taking it this year. I'd just be wasting the application fee. I'm going to study for a year and apply to Sasajiin next winter."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I see now…"

…But why though?

Nozomi Anesaki

"You were so adamant about not going to the same university as Senpai... So why did you decide to aim for Sasajiin?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Your mom told me you can go to whatever university you want."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Seriously? She said that?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah. So you don't have to force yourself to apply to Sasajiin if you don't want to."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...You…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"You aren't happy that I'm applying to the same university as you…?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"What? No... of course I'm happy about it..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...HUH?! That's your reason?! You just want to go to the same university as me?!"
Hozumi Hoshina
"What do you mean 'just'?! Is that really such a bad reason?!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"No, but... choosing a university is a major decision that will affect your future... You should think about it a little more carefully..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"For someone who's always daydreaming, you can be surprisingly down-to-earth."
Nozomi Anesaki
"The 2D world and reality are completely different things."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...I did actually think this through seriously."

Hozumi-san fell silent for a moment, and the mood suddenly shifted. I could tell he was being serious, so I gave him my full attention.

Hozumi Hoshina
"At first, I had no intention of going to the same university as Mizuho. I was thinking, 'No way am I applying to Sasajiin.' "
Hozumi Hoshina
"But then, around this time of year, I had to start thinking about my future. I figured I'd go to the university I actually wanted to attend, but..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...There wasn't one. I don't have some big dream I'm chasing or anything. There's nothing I particularly want to do."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Until now, all I wanted was a life different from Mizuho's. I hated being compared to him, so what mattered most was that my path differed from his."
Hozumi Hoshina

"But that was it. I never actually had any idea of what I wanted to do with my life."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...But lately, I've started thinking that maybe it'd be nice to go to the same university as you."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh…"
Hozumi Hoshina
"And also... I want to put in effort to be someone worthy of you."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"It's not like there was another university I wanted to go to, or some other goal I was chasing. So I figured I might as well aim for the place I actually want to be."
Hozumi Hoshina
"I still hate the idea of going to the same university as Mizuho, but... I think it's pretty stupid to hold myself back just to avoid him."
Hozumi Hoshina
"I guess, up until now... the only way I could define myself was by doing the opposite of everything Mizuho did."
Hozumi Hoshina
"I thought that was what made me me, but that was wrong. What Mizuho does has nothing to do with it."
Hozumi Hoshina
"I'm going to Sasajiin because I want to. And if I have to become a hardcore study addict like Mizuho to get there, then so be it."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...That's why I went to the library to study after I left you earlier."
Nozomi Anesaki
"So that's why... Is that why we haven't been seeing each other much lately? Because you've been studying?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Yeah. At the level I'm at right now, there's no way I'd get into Sasajiin. Even if I started studying like crazy now, I don't think I could catch up in time."
Nozomi Anesaki
"You got an E rating, after all..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Ugh..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"But if that's your goal, then I'll support you."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...I'm grateful for that, but… convincing my parents comes first."

Hozumi-san groaned, looking like he had a headache.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Convincing them? Why? If you're aiming for Sasajiin, wouldn't they be happy?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"No... My parents put appearances above everything. They pushed me to be like Mizuho because they worried about what others would think."

Hozumi Hoshina
"If I tell them I'm taking a gap year and applying next year, they'll probably lose it..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I don't think they will."

I had no doubt about it.
After talking with Hozumi-san's mother earlier, I realized something. She was simply worried about him.
Her telling him to "go to the same (good) university as Mizuho" had nothing to do with keeping up appearances.
All she wanted was to give Hozumi-san more options, since he hadn't yet decided what he wanted to do with his life.
If that weren't the case, she wouldn't have said something like, "Go to whichever university you want, but make sure you get a degree."
Hozumi-san said that he felt like his parents saw him as a burden, but I was sure that wasn't the case.
Parents nag their children because they care and want what's best for them.

Nozomi Anesaki
"I think she'll understand. So when you get home, make sure you talk to her about it."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Honestly... What did my mom say to you?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Nothing, really. She just said, 'Please take care of my son.' "
Hozumi Hoshina
"...What's that supposed to mean?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Anyway, since she asked me to look after you, I'm going to train you hard so you can get into Sasajiin next year!"
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Must be nice being you... You have a guaranteed pathway..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Well, yeah."

But listening to Hozumi-san made me realize something.
I didn't have any dreams or goals for the future either.
I'd simply assumed that I'd move on to Sasajiin University through the internal advancement system.
That's why I never even considered going to another university.
But now, I'm actually excited about the prospect of going there.
If I get to spend my university years with Hozumi-san, I'm sure I'll have a much more enjoyable school life than I do now.
...Maybe that's reason enough for now. I can take my time figuring out what I want to pursue once I'm in university.
Together with the person standing right in front of me.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Do your best, okay?"

Hozumi Hoshina
"Yeah, yeah..."

But if he pushes himself too hard, I'm sure he'll eventually burn himself out.
Because forcing himself to become "someone who's worthy of me" would only make him feel trapped by expectations.
That's why...

Nozomi Anesaki
"If you start feeling tired, promise me you'll take a break."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Okay?"

And when that time comes, I'll give him all the love and affection he deserves, just as he is.
...But if I said something like that, he'd probably get all full of himself, so I'll keep it to myself until then.

HOZUMI FANBOOK

Epilogue 3: Valentine's Day

February 14th.
It was Valentine's Day, of course.
After school, I bowed to Hozumi-san, who was waiting for me by the school gate, just like always.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Sorry, Hozumi-san. I don't have any chocolate today."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Huh?"

Hozumi-san's expression fell.
Ah... I guess he must have been really looking forward to this. I feel bad.

Hozumi Hoshina
"...Why?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Um... the full story is kind of long, but... simply put, I messed up."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Huh? Messed up?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah, messed up."

Hozumi-san wasn't the only one who had been excited for this day. I was as well.
This was my first Valentine's Day since I got a 3D boyfriend.
Relishing the joy of finally being able to make my special chocolate for someone other than Lord Wald, I excitedly got to work in the kitchen last night.

However, I wanted it to be perfect so badly that I couldn't manage to make anything I was satisfied with, and by the time I realized it, I had run out of ingredients.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Sorry... I'll redeem myself next time."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Well, it is what it is."

Hozumi-san reluctantly nodded and got on his bicycle.
As I sat down on the rear rack, my eyes happened to fall on the basket.
Inside was a stylish paper bag.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Wait, is that chocolate?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Hm? Oh, yeah."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Is it a gift?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Yeah."
Nozomi Anesaki
"From Shizune-san?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"No, a girl from my class."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Oh, but just so you know, it's only a courtesy gift."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Oh... I-I see..."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Are you relieved?"

Hozumi-san turned around with a grin.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...You said you didn't really talk with girls, but apparently you still get courtesy chocolates from them."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Yeah... I was surprised too. I've never gotten any before."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Oh, really?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Yeah. This is the first time I got one since I started high school. I wonder why."

Hozumi-san looked puzzled as he pedaled along.
I could have told him why, but I decided to keep it to myself.
...It's because he's mellowed out quite a bit.

It's not like his personality has completely changed, but he does seem noticeably softer than he used to be.
He's been studying hard lately, too, so I suppose the girls in his class have started to see him as more approachable.
I think it's a good thing, but I have to admit, I'm a little conflicted.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Shithead."

I muttered it quietly toward the back in front of me.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Huh? What was that, you little shit?"

Hearing him call me that again after so long made me smile.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Uh… what are you smiling about? Are you a masochist or something?"

Mm-hm. Now that's the Hozumi-san I know.

I bought some Pocky at the convenience store we stopped at along the way.
I was torn between that and a simple chocolate bar, but I decided to go with what I felt like having right now.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Hozumi-san, I'll give you some Pocky."

When I handed him the full box, Hozumi-san frowned.

Hozumi Hoshina
"...Is that seriously all you're doing for Valentine's?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"No, of course not. I'll redo the actual Valentine's chocolate properly and give it to you tomorrow."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Just bear with this for today."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Hmm."

Hozumi-san accepted the Pocky, immediately opened the package, and took out a stick.
He put one end of it between his lips and leaned forward.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Have some."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh?"
Hozumi Hoshina

"Come on, have some."

Hozumi-san leaned in, bringing the Pocky in his mouth toward me.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...What? You want me to bite the other end…?"

The tip of the Pocky bobbed along with his little nod.
Which means... he wants to play the Pocky game.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...No."

There was no way I could do something that embarrassing.
I turned away, and Hozumi-san finished off the Pocky with a bored look on his face.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Today is Valentine's Day."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I know."
Hozumi Hoshina
"I'm your boyfriend, aren't I?"

...And how exactly does that lead to playing the Pocky Game?
I was still trying to figure out the connection when Hozumi-san took out another stick and put it in his mouth.
...I have no choice.
I braced myself and bit down on the other end of the Pocky.
I locked eyes with Hozumi-san at a distance far closer than I'd anticipated.

Hozumi Hoshina
"?!"

Then Hozumi-san suddenly jumped back.
The force of it made me pull my mouth away as well.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Ah, the Pocky fell...! What a waste."
Hozumi Hoshina
"What possessed you to do that?!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Excuse me? You're the one who told me to do it."
Hozumi Hoshina
"How could you actually take this seriously…?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"W-wait, what...? You were joking...?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Obviously, idiot."

Nozomi Anesaki
"Ugh..."

I worked up the courage to do my duty as his girlfriend, and that's what I get? Honestly, he's such a pain.
I shrugged slightly and put a Pocky stick in my mouth.
Then I happily crunched away at it.
A moment later, I felt Hozumi-san's gaze.
He was staring intently at my mouth.
It looked like he was waiting for the right moment.
And so, I...

Hozumi Hoshina
"...!"

As Hozumi-san lunged toward me, I quickly pulled back.
I ate the rest of the Pocky, as he stood there dumbfounded, still awkwardly leaning forward.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Too bad."

When I gave him a smug grin, his face immediately turned bright red.

Hozumi Hoshina
"You're the worst...!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hm? Were you trying to do something?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Y-you little… shit…!"

If he wanted a kiss, he should've just gone along with the Pocky game.
He's such a pain.
But... I guess that's exactly what makes him Hozumi-san.

Epilogue 4: Enjoying the fall foliage

(Hozumi's POV)

Nozomi Anesaki
"Wow... It's beautiful."
Hozumi Hoshina
"I agree."
Nozomi Anesaki
"It's just amazing."
Hozumi Hoshina
"I agree."
Nozomi Anesaki

"This place truly lives up to its reputation. It's such a delight to admire the autumn foliage."
Hozumi Hoshina
"I agree."
Nozomi Anesaki
"It really makes you appreciate the beauty of Japan's four seasons."
Hozumi Hoshina
"I agree."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...I'm really glad the weather turned out so nice today."
Hozumi Hoshina
"I agree."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."

She glared at me with a sullen expression.
I shot her back a silent "Got a problem?" look. In response, she gave me a sheepish look, her eyebrows drooping slightly.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Hozumi-san... are you bored?"

...That's not fair.

Hozumi Hoshina
"I'm not bored at all."

That wasn't a lie.
I was enjoying this in my own way.
If you asked me how exactly, I probably couldn't tell you. But... I guess I was enjoying it about as much as riding home with her on the back of my bike, going to the arcade, or just lazing around in her room together.
Put simply, it was nothing out of the ordinary. But I'd never once considered any of it dull.

Nozomi Anesaki
"But you've only been saying, 'I agree,' this whole time."
Hozumi Hoshina
"What else am I supposed to say?"

I'm not wrong, am I?
The autumn leaves are certainly beautiful.
But once you've made a passing comment about them, there isn't exactly much else to say.
No, I suppose someone who truly appreciated beauty could probably spend an hour discussing this scenery alone.
But I'd need a few more decades before I became someone like that.
And that's probably true for her too.

Hozumi Hoshina
"You've been saying nothing but 'beautiful' and 'amazing' this whole time too."

Nozomi Anesaki
"Ugh... That's not true."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Then come up with something else."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...They're amazing."
Hozumi Hoshina
"There it is. 'Amazing.' "
Nozomi Anesaki
"I wasn't finished! They are amazing… and so red."
Hozumi Hoshina
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"A-and also… yellow."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Yeah, yeah, that's enough. Enough."

I dismissively waved my hand.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Be honest, you're also getting bored, aren't you?"

The moment I said that, Anesaki's expression turned awkward and she went quiet.
Looks like I was right.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Let's go look at the fall foliage!"

Anesaki brought it up earlier this week.
Her sudden suggestion caught me off guard, but it didn't take me long to figure out where it had come from.
We had recently heard from Mizuho about how he went to see the autumn leaves with Shizune.
At the time, I just laughed it off, saying something like, "You two sound like an old married couple." I never thought Anesaki would be influenced by that.
Maybe she got swept up by Mizuho's dramatic storytelling.
She must have imagined some incredibly exciting, romantic date, but...

Nozomi Anesaki
"...To be honest, I'm getting a little bored."

Just as I thought.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Well, I figured as much."
Nozomi Anesaki
"But it's still really beautiful, right?"
Hozumi Hoshina

"I agree."
Nozomi Anesaki
"And there's the 'I agree' again."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Then try saying something besides 'beautiful' and 'amazing.' And don't use 'red' or 'yellow' either."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Ookay."

Anesaki bent down and picked up a bright red maple leaf.

Nozomi Anesaki
"This is an iroha maple. It's considered one of the classic varieties associated with autumn foliage, and apparently its leaves usually turn red."
Nozomi Anesaki
"The ones that turn yellow are called ōmomiji—"
Hozumi Hoshina
"Wait, stop."

I cut her off when I realized this was going to take a while.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Where did you learn that? ...Don't tell me you know this stuff just because you're a Sasajiin student."
Nozomi Anesaki
"It was written in the pamphlet."
Hozumi Hoshina
"...Ooh."

So she actually did her homework.
Just like when she prepared for that movie date with Mizuho, she always gives it her all.
I genuinely respect that side of her.

Hozumi Hoshina
"Okay, let's walk a little more and then head home."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh? Isn't that a little early?"
Hozumi Hoshina
"You're bored too, right?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hmm... Well, yeah."
Hozumi Hoshina
"I'm starting to get hungry too."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ah, yeah, me too."
Hozumi Hoshina
"I heard there's a place nearby with really good pudding."
Nozomi Anesaki

"What?! We're going! I want it!"

I couldn't help but smile at the reaction I'd expected.
I decided to keep quiet about the fact that I'd done my own homework, too.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Then let's do as you said."
Hozumi Hoshina
"You changed your mind pretty quickly. Are you already done with the leaves?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yep. I'm more of a food-over-scenery person."
Hozumi Hoshina
"Same."

Maybe a few decades from now, I'll learn to appreciate it.
When that happens, we can come see it again. ...I kept that thought to myself, though.